

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The biggest tech** companies kept swaths of the stock market humming in the third quarter, helping to lift the S&P 500 and Nasdaq by 2% and 2.5%, respectively, for the three months. The Dow fell 2.7% in the period. **A1**
- ◆ **The yield on the** 10-year Treasury note rose above 5.3%, blowing past a 2007 peak to reach its highest level since 2002. **B1**
- ◆ **Walgreens'** private-equity owner, Sycamore Partners, is nearing a deal to sell U.K. pharmacy chain Boots for close to \$9 billion, including debt. **B1**
- ◆ **Mattel Chief Executive** Ynon Kreiz was tapped to become co-CEO of the combined Paramount-Warner Bros. Discovery once the \$81 billion deal closes. **B2**
- ◆ **DoorDash** extended its range of partnerships to deliver more clothing, shoes and other items to answer consumers' expectations. **B1**
- ◆ **The Fed's independent** watchdog said it found no evidence of administrative misconduct over the renovation of the central bank's headquarters. **A2**
- ◆ **BMW intends** to use artificial intelligence to help it reduce its workforce and improve efficiency as it prepares for increasingly challenging market conditions. **B3**
- ◆ **German union IG Metall** warned of a potential conflict with VW after the carmaker said that it plans to terminate some wage agreements. **B3**
- ◆ **Nidec swung** to a heavy annual net loss due to a \$4 billion impairment in its auto-parts division and other businesses. **B5**

Worldwide

- ◆ **A FlyDubai jet** bound for Israel made an emergency landing in Saudi Arabia after the co-pilot stabbed the captain. Authorities believe it was an attempt to crash the plane. **A1**
- ◆ **The U.K.'s Burnham** cited "strong indications" that Iran played a part in a foiled attack on an RAF base. **A8**
- ◆ **Hegseth is creating** a command for autonomous warfare, overhauling the way the Pentagon buys, tests and deploys drones and other technologies. **A3**
- ◆ **A next-generation** weight-loss drug from Eli Lilly, when combined with Zepbound, showed strong promise in a study. **A3**
- ◆ **Trump began** sending \$500 checks to nearly one million people and enclosed a letter touting his healthcare record a month before elections. **A3**
- ◆ **The FTC is** investigating Anthropic and OpenAI to determine whether they deceived consumers about the potential harms of AI. **A4**
- ◆ **OpenAI President** Brockman backed out of a pledge to make a multimillion-dollar donation to a PAC supporting pro-AI candidates. **A4**
- ◆ **A U.S. pressure campaign** has left dozens of Iran-linked tankers that once supplied Iranian oil to China stranded in Asian waters. **A6**
- ◆ **Medicare is rolling** out a program to match prices offered in other countries for certain expensive drugs. **A2**
- ◆ **Mexico is** stepping up its fight against drug-cartel laundering following pressure from the U.S. **A8**

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Passenger Yaniv Hayun helped subdue a pilot-turned-attacker in the cockpit of a FlyDubai jet. Flight 1073 safely landed in Saudi Arabia, and Hayun—still in a bloody shirt—was greeted later Wednesday in Israel. Scan the code for a video.

Stabbing, Terrifying Nosedive Bring Chaos to Flight 1073

Passengers, crew subdue pilot who stabbed his captain en route to Tel Aviv

Almog Italie was flying home from a vacation in Japan with his wife and two teenagers, casually snapping pictures of irrigated circles of farmland in the desert below, when the FlyDubai 737 MAX suddenly went into a steep nosedive. "It started dropping as if there was turbulence, but crazy. Twenty, 30 seconds of a crazy free fall. It then stabilized and then again started falling," said Italie, an Israeli e-commerce worker. "We didn't understand what was happening."

What Italie couldn't see from his seat in Row 20 on Flight 1073 was a desperate fight unfolding in the cockpit. One pilot had stabbed the plane's captain, who fought back and opened the cockpit door, said Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. Seeing a commotion, a small group of passengers and crew members rushed to the front to win back control of the plane, according to interviews with passengers and social-media videos verified by The Wall Street Journal. Yaniv Hayun, a passenger, said in a video shared by Israel's public broadcaster that he and another man found the door was unlocked but was blocked by the fallen pilot, so

they shoved it open. Inside, he said he saw the injured captain on the ground as the co-pilot hovered over the controls. "I grabbed the attacker and put him in a chokehold and took him outside," Hayun said, then called other Israeli passengers to help. Afterward, the pilots lay on the floor of the kitchen area receiving medical care, blood smearing their uniforms and the walls. One passenger looked on in shock, a rivulet of

blood running down the middle of his forehead. "They attacked us right now, in this plane," he said in a video posted on social media. "They tried to murder the pilot, and we took over." Two other pilots who were aboard to operate the next flight assumed control of the plane. Flight data show they fought for five minutes to stabilize the jet as it pitched up and down amid the unsettled situation aboard and the damage done by a rapid dive during which the plane lost 15,000 feet of altitude in 55 seconds. Once they had it under control, they issued a Squawk 7700, a radio signal indicating a general emergency. Seven

By Anat Peled in Tel Aviv, Benjamin Katz in London and Summer Said in Dubai

Tycoon, 94, Is Building A Family Investing Behemoth

By JULIET CHUNG

The Kirsh family is building out what is expected to be one of the largest family offices created in recent years after its patriarch, Nathan Kirsh, sold his restaurant-supply company, Jetro Restaurant Depot, earlier this year for \$29 billion, including debt. Representatives for the family have been interviewing potential investment chiefs, investment committee members and advisers for the existing Kirsh family office in New York, sometimes called Kifo, as they prepare to manage the sudden influx of money, said people familiar with the matter. The family—Kirsh and his three children and their families—also has kicked off a search process for a head of private investments and a head of public investments. The family currently has a few employees in its small family office and works with outside investment firms, the people familiar said. They ultimately expect to have most of their fortune managed through their revamped family office, including oversight of money managed by outside firms. The company sale to Sysco, which is expected to close by the end of the first quarter, was for \$22 billion in cash and 91.5 million in Sysco shares, worth about \$7.1 billion at Wednesday's close. The Kirshes are part of an

U.S. Military Exit Leaves Iraq in Peril

Baghdad is threatened by militants in a conflict fed by America's war with Iran

By JARED MALSIN AND SANGAR KHALEEL

BAGHDAD—After spending more than 23 years and \$1.7 trillion, America is winding down what critics have called its forever war in Iraq, closing the last major U.S. military base on Wednesday. "We don't think we need the military there anymore," President Trump said

during a White House visit by Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi in July. "We have a fantastic champion, a new champion," the president said. "He's young, and he's handsome." Zaidi, a 41-year-old businessman, sat beside Trump during the visit and announced a deadline, also set for Wednesday, for Iranian-backed militias to hand

over their weapons. "There is no justification for their existence after the 30th of September," he said. Instead, America's open-ended war with Iran is pushing Iraq deeper into conflict, with the U.S. exit leaving behind a country where well-armed militias are only tightening their grip. Militants and

INSIDE



U.S. NEWS

Ken Griffin's record-setting donation will start Carnegie Mellon campus in Miami. **A3**



SPORTS

Travis Kelce got into wedding shape—and embarked on a late-career honeymoon. **A16**

Now We're All Starting to Talk Like AI Chatbots Too

'Prompt speak' and robotic turns of phrase are seeping into conversations at the office

By KATHERINE BINDLEY

Sara Wimmercranz recently found herself opening a work meeting with what's often referred to as contrast framing, a linguistic tool favored by chat-

bots. This is not a morning meeting, she began, it's a reset. It was just as Wimmercranz feared. She's ingested so much AI-generated content that it's now coming out of her mouth. "We just sound like



Droning on

Europe's Carmakers See Cure for Woes: Supersize U.S. SUVs

By STEPHEN WILMOT

BMW, Audi and other European carmakers are trying to revive their sales with a new generation of supersized luxury SUVs in America. BMW is looking to make a supersized sport-utility vehicle specifically for the U.S., it told investors in Munich this week. Volvo Cars has said it would introduce a larger SUV in the U.S. as part of a major portfolio revamp. And Audi recently launched the Q9, its first full-size SUV, on the roof of a New York hotel. "Americans love big SUVs. So why don't we listen to that?" Volvo Cars Chief Executive Håkan Samuelsson said in an interview. European automakers are hungry for growth after a sales collapse in China triggered by falling home prices and digitally savvy local competitors. China used to ac-

count for as much as half of profit for companies such as BMW, Mercedes-Benz and Audi owner Volkswagen. The business case for launching larger SUVs in the U.S. has grown even stronger after President Trump eased emissions standards. Under new rules, automakers no longer need to sell as many fuel-efficient cars to compensate for big SUVs, which typically come with big, gas-guzzling engines. As profit from China has dried up, the U.S. has taken on outsized importance. Big SUVs are a particularly attractive niche to grow into because they carry higher margins. "Typically in the auto industry, the bigger the vehicle, the bigger the profits," said Tyson Jominy, a senior vice president

◆ **Ford faults supplier** for F-150's sales drop..... B1

U.S. NEWS

Data Point to an Economic Pickup

GDP revised higher for second quarter and price increases accelerated in August

By MATT GROSSMAN

New reports out Wednesday showed the U.S. economy grew more than previously thought in the second quarter of 2026 and that inflation remained firm in August. They added to evidence that the economy is powering past challenges and fueling continued price increases.

The Commerce Department raised its reading for annualized gross domestic product growth in the second quarter to 2.2%, well above the 1.5% that had previously been reported. The key consumer-spending and investment categories were both stronger than previously thought.

A key metric of underlying growth trends, real final sales to private domestic purchasers, was also tweaked higher, to 4.6%.

Meanwhile, the inflation metric known as the personal-consumption expenditures



Data point to consumers being in sound financial shape.

price index rose by 3.4% over the past 12 months, the Commerce Department said in a separate report Wednesday, level from a month earlier.

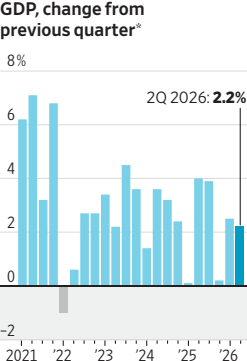
In August alone, price increases accelerated. The overall index rose by 0.3%, and the core version that excludes food and energy prices rose by 0.2%, faster than the July readings.

That acceleration came despite a tweak to the PCE inflation formula that otherwise pulled down annualized inflation readings recorded in re-

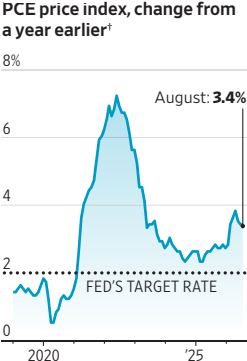
cent months. To address mis-measurement concerns, the Bureau of Economic Analysis changed how three price categories are tabulated—legal services, investment services and computer software—and applied the change retroactively.

Wednesday's numbers added to evidence that despite constraints like tariffs, an immigration crackdown and high energy prices, the economy remains on solid footing.

The GDP revisions cast growth seen earlier this year



GDP, change from previous quarter* PCE price index, change from a year earlier†



in a substantially better light. The previous estimate, of 1.5% inflation-adjusted second-quarter growth, had looked like a sizable slowdown from the rate seen in the first quarter. Now, the revised look back at the first half of the year paints a picture of steadier economic expansion.

Upward revisions to the investment category—which includes construction—emphasize how important the build-out of AI infrastructure has been to economic growth. And an in-

crease in estimates of second-quarter consumer spending underscores that with a solid labor market and strong stock returns, household finances have remained in good shape.

The PCE numbers didn't come as a surprise to Wall Street analysts, because the index's formula draws on other government inflation data that were published earlier in the month.

◆ Inflation hits Eurozone's biggest economies..... A7

Report Finds No Misconduct in Fed Renovation

By NICK TIMIRAOUS

The Federal Reserve's independent watchdog said Wednesday it found no evidence of administrative misconduct and no grounds to refer anyone for criminal prosecution over the renovation of the central bank's headquarters.

The report, by the Fed's office of the inspector general, removes the last formal threat to former Fed Chair Jerome Powell after the project became a vehicle for the Trump administration's potential legal campaign against him.

But the 120-page report was sharply critical of how the Fed managed the renovation of two historic buildings, finding that its oversight framework was insufficient for a project of its size. Construction costs have swelled to around \$2.4 billion, up from an estimate of \$1.3 billion in 2020, according to the report.

Powell announced in January that U.S. prosecutors were investigating him over testimony he gave to Congress last year about the building renovation. He denied any wrongdoing and instead cast the probe as part of the Trump administration's pressure campaign to lower interest rates.

When the Justice Department said in April it had closed the criminal investigation of Powell, it told Sen. Thom Tillis (R., N.C.) that the case could be revived only by a criminal referral from the Fed's inspector general, an assurance Tillis made public and that cleared



The Federal Reserve headquarters renovation site in Washington earlier this year.

the way for Powell's successor Kevin Warsh to be confirmed as Fed chairman in May.

"At no point during our evaluation did we find reasonable grounds to believe that a violation of federal criminal law had occurred," the report said. "Further, while our report outlines deficiencies in the management of the renovation project" the report "did not identify administrative misconduct."

Hours after the report was released, President Trump said on social media that Powell should be forced to resign from the Fed's board and that he had asked Attorney General Todd Blanche to study the findings and determine what to do about the project. If Powell doesn't step down, Trump wrote, the government should sue him "for either corruption or incompetence."

The findings give something

to both sides of a yearlong fight, but aren't likely to satisfy anyone. Administration officials who decried the renovation as fiscal mismanagement now have a federal watchdog largely in agreement. But in addition to finding no evidence of misconduct, the report concluded the design features that the Fed's critics highlighted as evidence of wasteful spending didn't drive the overruns.

In clearing Powell of wrongdoing, including making false representations to lawmakers, the report delivered the finding that matters legally for Powell alongside an unflattering account of the institution he ran. The report faulted the Fed's facilities services team for not having done more to flag rising costs and construction delays to the Fed's Board of Governors, whose responsibilities include

setting interest rates, regulating banks and overseeing the nation's payment systems.

The inspector general said the Fed board's governance and oversight framework was insufficient to manage the risks of a project of that size and complexity. Investigators faulted the Fed on several fronts, including not establishing a project cost ceiling or taking other steps that would have given its outside construction managers more incentive to hold down costs, particularly as rising inflation contributed to building cost overruns.

For example, the report said that after construction began in 2022, the board didn't obtain an updated cost estimate from its construction manager until this January, after it had already awarded more than \$2 billion in work. Investigators were concerned by the delay.

It also challenged the premise that rising materials costs were largely to blame for certain cost overruns. Major mechanical, electrical and plumbing items ended up running about \$500 million above an initial \$200 million estimate in 2022, well ahead of what inflation could explain.

The renovation is scheduled for completion next year.

Warsh said in a letter Tuesday to the inspector general that he had earlier asked the head of the General Services Administration, the agency responsible for managing federal workspaces, to lead an outside review of the renovation.

Effective immediately, Warsh said, the GSA would serve as the project executive and report to him and the board.

He accepted all of the inspector general's recommendations. "If any arm of government should be showing vigilance in cost control, it is the nation's central bank," he wrote.

In April, weeks before his term as chairman ended, Powell made the unusual move of announcing he would stay on as a governor and decide his departure by what he judged best for the institution. Powell's remaining term runs through January 2028.

The testimony resurfaced as the basis of an investigation opened by Jeanine Pirro, the U.S. attorney in Washington, when her office sent two subpoenas to the Fed in January.

A spokesman for Pirro said Wednesday she was reviewing the inspector general's report.

Stocks Limp Into Quarter

Continued from Page One

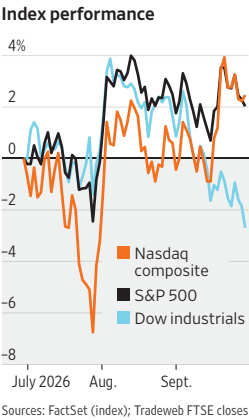
a positive quarter," said Ross Mayfield, investment strategist at Baird.

Strong earnings reports helped bolster investors' confidence. Microsoft reported robust cloud growth and increasing AI subscribers and Nvidia's finance chief predicted 70% revenue growth in the company's 2028 fiscal year.

Meanwhile, software rebounded as investors backed away from the idea that AI would replace software as a service in a SaaS-pocalypse. Salesforce ended the quarter up 47% and Workday up 56%, though both are still down on a year-to-date basis.

Bitcoin, the world's largest cryptocurrency, rose 42% for its best quarter since the last three months of 2024.

Interest rates and energy prices weighed on other parts of the market, denting consumer spending.

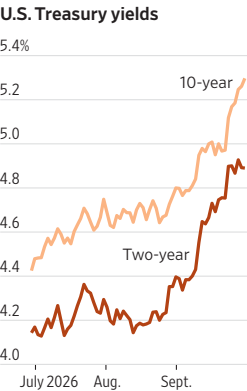


have an outsize impact on performance, fell 2.3%, snapping a five-quarter winning streak. The Russell 2000, which is generally made up of smaller, nontechnology stocks, declined 7.5%.

"Bonds, real-estate investment trusts and consumer (discretionary) got smashed," said Jay Hatfield, chief executive at Infrastructure Capital Advisors.

The 10-year U.S. Treasury yield ended the past three months with its largest quarterly gain since 1994, notching a rise of nearly 0.9 percentage point. On Wednesday, the last day of the quarter, the 10-year touched a 24-year high.

The Iran war is the biggest



culprit. Brent crude futures rose 42% to \$103.53 a barrel in the quarter.

Cboe Global Markets wrote in a research note in September that the correlation between oil prices and the 10-year Treasury yield is now higher than it has been at any point since the First Gulf War in 1990.

After September's rate increase, investors are projecting a roughly 60% chance of at least four more rate increases over the next 12 months, according to CME data. Fed officials penciled in at least one more increase this year.

Still, that may not be enough to drag down a resilient market, said Mayfield.

"Twenty-five basis points here and there on rates are not going to stop the freight train that is AI," he said.

Investment in data centers and related artificial-intelligence infrastructure is projected to total \$10.3 trillion from 2025 to 2032, the yearly equivalent of 3.6% of gross domestic product, according to a recent study published by the Brookings Institution.

On Wednesday, the Nasdaq composite gained 0.2% and the S&P 500 ticked down 0.3%, while the Dow Jones Industrial Average slid 0.9%.

The S&P 500 and the Nasdaq are still on track for their fourth year in a row of double-digit gains for the first time since the late 1990s.

The Dow, after three years of double-digit increases, is setting a slower pace in 2026, rising 5.9% through the end of September.

Over the coming quarter, investors will be closely watching inflation and jobs data for clues as to how soon and how much Fed officials will want to raise rates, said Rob Haworth, senior investment strategist at U.S. Bank.

The question on many minds, said Rebecca Venter, senior fixed-income client portfolio manager at Vanguard, is: "What will the hiking cycle need to look like for the Fed to meet its goal?"

Medicare Seeks to Cut Some Drug Prices

By LIZ ESSLEY WHYTE AND LIZZY LAWRENCE

The Trump administration is rolling out a program aimed at getting Medicare to match prices in other countries for certain high-cost drugs, such as cancer and autoimmune disorder medicines.

Health officials plowed past objections from drugmakers and said the new effort, known as Globe, would start Jan. 1. Drugmakers who cut earlier deals with the White House to lower their prices are expected to be exempt from the current effort.

The final rule governing the program, issued Wednesday, applies to few drugs and is less ambitious than the administration initially proposed. Still, it represents one of the most legally significant attempts yet by the second Trump administration to bring down U.S. drug costs by linking them to overseas prices.

The plan calls for Medicare to set what it pays for certain drugs based on what 19 other countries with similar economies pay. Under an experiment run by Medicare's Innovation Center, the pricing plan will be tested for some patients receiving some of the drugs covered by Medicare Part B—generally expensive drugs that doctors or hospitals administer in person, rather than pills taken at home. An example is Entyvio, made by Takeda, for Crohn's and ulcerative colitis. If the five-year program shows that it saves taxpayers money without sacrificing quality, it could be expanded nationwide.

The Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services administrator, Mehmet Oz, said that "we're taking action to pilot a new approach to lower costs and strengthen the quality of care while preserving medical innovation."

The trade association representing large pharmaceutical firms, which has opposed government-led efforts to bring down prices, decried the move as unlawful and harmful to patients.

"This policy exceeds agency authority, does nothing to lower patients' out-of-pocket costs, and imports foreign prices based on discriminatory value metrics and government price controls that delay, limit, or deny access to new treatments," said Pharmaceutical Research and Manufacturers of America spokesman Chantse Jones.

The Globe program applies to a small slice of medicines, but is expected to have far-reaching implications if it survives legal challenges and demonstrates cost savings.

CORRECTIONS & AMPLIFICATIONS

The last name of Dimmy Kanyankole, Bolt's general manager in East Africa, was misspelled as Kanyankola in a Business & Finance article on Monday about Uber's Kenyan safari business and

in the section's Index to People.

A Sports article on Wednesday about Cam Schlitter and Ben Rice omitted the byline for Jared Diamond.

Readers can alert The Wall Street Journal to any errors in news articles by emailing wsjcontact@wsj.com or by calling 888-762-5450.

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U.S. NEWS

Next-Gen Drug Fuels Weight Reduction, Study Says

By ALEX JANIN

A next-generation weight-loss drug from **Eli Lilly**, when combined with Zepbound, helped people lose substantially more weight than Zepbound alone, according to a new study.

The experimental injection, eloralintide, which mimics a hormone called amylin that helps signal fullness after eating, was studied in combination with a Zepbound shot in patients with Type 2 diabetes.

Patients on the highest dose of the combination lost an average of 23.3% of their body weight over roughly 11 months while those on Zepbound alone lost an average of 14.8% of their weight. This data combines the results from patients who stayed in the trial as well as anticipated results of those who dropped out.

“This will be a turning point for the field,” said Dan Skovronsky, Lilly’s chief scientific officer. “I think this combination will be the most tolerable therapy that we’ve developed yet for the degree of weight loss that we expect to achieve.”

More drugmakers are studying whether adding an amylin drug to a GLP-1 could increase weight loss with fewer side effects. Patients with Type 2 diabetes historically lose less weight on GLP-1s than patients without diabetes.

Lilly, which has the lead in the weight-loss-drug market, is also testing eloralintide as a stand-alone drug in separate late-stage studies.

Trump Sends Checks, Letters on Healthcare

By NATALIE ANDREWS

WASHINGTON—President Trump began sending \$500 checks to nearly one million people and enclosed a letter touting his record on cutting healthcare costs, just a month before voters go to the polls for the midterm elections.

The administration first announced the checks earlier this month, saying the payments would go to people who paid what it called excessive fees under the Affordable Care Act, drawing on a surplus pool of funds. On Wednesday, the president posted a video from the Oval Office saying “our Administration is doing the right thing and giving the money back to the people who were wrongly ripped off.”

In the letter accompanying the checks that is signed by Trump, he says: “Since returning to office, I have fought to lower Healthcare Costs, increase Accountability, and Put Patients First.” He also touts the TrumpRx drug program that offers some medications for lower costs through negotiated deals the administration made with pharmaceutical companies. Republicans are working to defend their majorities in the House and Senate this fall, but face voters concerned about rising costs.

The checks will go to people who bought ACA plans in 30 states that use the federal health insurance marketplace to sell ACA coverage. An administration official said the primary recipients of the checks will be people who didn’t receive subsidized healthcare plans.

The user fees are levied as a percentage of the premiums charged for the ACA plans. Premiums have gone up recently, and the Trump administration cut costs for operating the federal marketplace, HealthCare.gov, according to Jeff Grant, a former official at the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services. Grant said the Biden administration cut back user fee rates.

New Command to Oversee Drone Tech

‘AutoWarCom’ will shift how Pentagon buys and deploys new technologies

By SHELBY HOLLIDAY AND LARA SELIGMAN

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth is creating a four-star combatant command for autonomous warfare, overhauling the way the Pentagon buys, tests and deploys drones and other cutting-edge technologies.

The Autonomous Warfare Command, or “AutoWarCom,” will be directed to buy new drones and robotics “in the fastest peacetime shift in modern military history,” Hegseth said in a speech at U.S. Marine Corps Base Quantico, Va. The command is set to be functional in October of 2027.

Hegseth also announced in a speech to the troops that entrepreneurs Elon Musk and Palmer Luckey and former House Speaker Newt Gingrich will study the future of warfare. Called “Project Meridian,” the effort would be led by the Pentagon with the goal of uncovering new ideas about how future generations will



Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth unveiled the move Wednesday.

fight. Their findings would be due in 120 days.

To lay the groundwork for the autonomous-warfare command, Hegseth is initially tapping Owen West, a former Marine, assistant defense secretary and Goldman Sachs trader, as well as Max Stratiser, a Navy SEAL test pilot who has built robotic systems in combat. A four-star military officer, yet to be named, would eventually take over.

A top priority is to rapidly establish an American-made pipeline of cheap, unmanned systems so that the U.S. can

of authorities, though some combatant commanders have signaled support for the change, according to people familiar with the deliberations.

President Trump supports the move, Hegseth said, though he acknowledged it is likely to meet resistance in a department that has historically delegated the authority to test and buy weapons to the services, such as the Army and the Navy. The Pentagon has sought to triple spending on autonomous warfare, proposing \$74 billion for drone and counterdrone technology in its record budget request.

Hegseth has already consolidated many of the Pentagon’s drone and autonomous systems under a single office that he established in June. Now, he is directing that office to lay the groundwork for the combatant command by launching “Project Agincourt,” which West and Stratiser will lead.

Eventually putting a four-star officer in charge of the new command would put it on an even plane with other powerful military organizations, such as Cyber Command and Space Command.

To supercharge the testing, purchasing and fielding of un-

manned systems, West plans to expand on a series of industry competitions that his organization established over the past year under the military’s Drone Dominance Program.

For each competition, known as a “gauntlet,” dozens of companies are invited to put their commercial drones to the test, flying realistic missions created and piloted by the military. Top-performing companies receive multi-million-dollar orders within weeks of the final results.

As the Pentagon races to keep pace with technological developments, it is also looking decades ahead, with Hegseth directing outside experts to study the future of warfare.

Unveiling Project Meridian, Hegseth said the Pentagon’s chief technology officer, Emil Michael, will work with Musk, Luckey and Gingrich.

Separately, Hegseth announced a new office in charge of making sure military installations can generate their own power independent of the civilian energy grid. The office, dubbed “Fortress America,” will be headed by a senior civilian and a two-star military officer, according to a memo reviewed by the Journal.



Construction of Carnegie Mellon’s Miami campus, above in a rendering, is set to begin in 2027.

Hedge-Fund Titan’s Gift Spurs New Miami Campus

By DEBORAH ACOSTA

MIAMI—Hedge-fund titan Ken Griffin is donating \$2 billion to start a Carnegie Mellon University campus in Miami, part of the largest individual gift yet toward higher education.

The Pittsburgh-based university, known for its expertise in computer science, artificial intelligence and robotics, will open a 35-acre campus in Miami’s Wynwood neighborhood that will focus on technology and innovation.

“The students who graduate and the tech companies that come to Miami to leverage those skills will change the very fabric of Miami for decades if not centuries to come,” Griffin said in an interview.

Citadel’s chief executive is also giving \$1 billion to Carnegie Mellon’s main Pittsburgh campus. Griffin’s combined \$3 billion donation is the largest single gift toward higher education from any individual, according to an announcement from Carnegie Mellon University.

The donation helps advance Griffin’s aim to establish South Florida as a leading global-business and technology hub. A spokesman said Griffin has now given \$2.4 billion in donations to South Florida, where he moved his firm Citadel’s

headquarters, and more than \$5.7 billion in total charitable giving.

“I believe that all great American cities are anchored by great universities and Carnegie Mellon will bring a great university here to Miami complementary to other universities here in the region,” Griffin said.

In addition to the donation, Griffin is joining Carnegie Mellon’s Board of Trustees. CMU’s computer science school in Pittsburgh will also be renamed the Kenneth C. Griffin School of Computer Science.

Citadel has a history of scooping up talent from Carnegie Mellon, boasting a long list of quantitative engineers and other employees who attended the university.

Property developer Stephen Ross has also poured billions of dollars into office towers, condominiums, retail centers and schools in West Palm Beach, Fla., about 70 miles north of Miami. He also helped recruit Vanderbilt University’s graduate campus to West Palm Beach. That program has raised about \$400 million from donations. It recently doubled its planned student population to 2,000, and the school will focus on defense tech, finance, space tech and national-security studies when it opens in 2029.

While Carnegie Mellon op-

erates satellite campuses in New York City; Mountain View, Calif.; and Qatar, serving up to a few hundred students each, Miami will be its largest expansion by far. The university projects the campus eventually will support more than 3,500 undergraduate, master’s and Ph.D. students, nearly 300 faculty and over 600 staff members.

“Miami is an area in which Carnegie Mellon can reinvent not only what students learn, but how they learn,” said Farnam Jahanian, president of Carnegie Mellon.

Carnegie Mellon Miami will focus on human health and biological discovery, national security and strategic capabilities, energy and climate resilience, and advanced manufacturing and industrial transformation, making it a good fit with the region’s burgeoning defense tech and healthcare industries. Interdisciplinary programs will integrate artificial intelligence, computing, and machine learning alongside CMU’s humanities, fine arts and design disciplines.

Carnegie Mellon’s new Miami campus will sit on a roughly 30-acre site purchased from developer Moishe Mana for \$1.1 billion, according to a press release. Details about who ultimately will hold the deed to the 35-acre property weren’t made public.

Construction is slated to begin in 2027, with the campus aiming to enroll its first students in 2028.

The Miami campus will host industry research labs and venture studios, so that students, faculty and industry and community partners can build technologies alongside one another.

The new Carnegie Mellon campus will sit blocks from Griffin’s other major investment in the neighborhood, where he joined with Goldman Properties to acquire an office tower from Chicago-based developer Sterling Bay, for \$180 million.



The donation helps advance Ken Griffin’s aim to establish South Florida as a leading global business and technology hub.

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U.S. NEWS

GOP’s Affordability Push Falters in Senate

Chamber leaves town for midterms without passing legislation on costs

WASHINGTON—Senate Republicans made a late push to show voters they were trying to rein in the high costs of living but the legislation failed to advance, as polls signal their control of the chamber could be in jeopardy in November’s midterm elections.

By Lindsay Wise, Amrith Ramkumar and Siobhan Hughes

The Republican bill related to artificial-intelligence data centers was blocked Wednesday by Democrats, who dismissed it as the product of a desperate political exercise, and no votes are planned on issues such as suspending the gas tax. The AI measure’s failure allows Republicans to paint Democrats as obstructionists but deprives them of a legislative win to run on as they head home to campaign.

With just over a month to go before the midterms, Democrats are giving Republicans a run for their money in states



Senate Majority Leader John Thune, above on Wednesday, said a data-center bill pushed unsuccessfully by the GOP was the same bill the House had passed with Democratic support.

President Trump won by double digits in 2024, including Ohio, Iowa, Alaska, Texas and Kansas. The latest Wall Street Journal poll showed Americans in both parties backing ideas such as government-imposed price caps and other market interventions to make life more affordable.

“You don’t take anything for granted, and we know the

American people are hurting right now,” said Sen. Mike Rounds (R., S.D.). “We know that, so as part of our responsibility we have to be doing whatever we can to try to address the issue.”

In Wednesday’s action, the Senate fell short of advancing the Ratepayer Protection Act, a bill aimed at limiting the impact of data centers on power

prices. The legislation drew 57 votes in favor and 43 against, but it needed 60 votes under Senate rules.

The measure was sponsored by Sen. Jon Husted (R., Ohio), who is in a fierce re-election battle with former Democratic Sen. Sherrod Brown. Brown has been hammering Husted as an ally of the tech industry who helped fuel Ohio’s data-center

boom when he was a top state official.

Ohio has become increasingly competitive as voters sour on high prices and the Iran war, and Democrats see it as one of their top targets as they try to flip four seats to win control of the Senate. Democrats in other key states including Texas and Michigan have also used data centers to target Republicans. Trump has rejected tough oversight of the industry.

“All Republicans offer is a toothless messaging bill. This bill is a fraud,” said Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer (D., N.Y.). Schumer pointed out that the guardrails proposed in Husted’s legislation aren’t mandatory.

Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R., S.D.) rejected the idea that the vote was a messaging stunt. He noted that the House already passed the same measure, 417-3, with broad support from Democrats. If the Senate also passed it, it would head straight to Trump’s desk to be signed into law.

Some Republican senators said they regretted not spending more time on pocketbook issues in the run-up to the election. Sen. Josh Hawley (R., Mo.) listed bills he said he wished

the GOP-led Senate had put more effort behind, including measures to suspend the gas tax, allow taxpayers to deduct out-of-pocket medical expenses, and to cap insulin prices.

Sen. Susan Collins (R., Maine) had advocated for a vote on a bipartisan bill she championed that would extend a cap on insulin prices to people with private insurance before the Senate recessed for the final weeks before the election. But Thune said it was hard to hold a vote because it would take too much time given the procedural hurdles to getting legislation on the floor. Collins, seeking reelection, is in a close race against Democrat Troy Jackson.

On data centers, Husted accused Senate Democrats of being more interested in playing politics than addressing affordability. His bill is centered on commitments by data-center developers to pay more for power and help fund energy infrastructure and a requirement that states consider such measures. The goal is to address fears that AI data centers are pushing up electricity prices.

“It is the only game in town,” Husted said. “It is the only bill that has a chance to get to the president’s desk before we get to the election.”

OpenAI President Backs Out Of Pledge To AI PAC

By Maxwell Zeff and Laura J. Nelson

OpenAI co-founder and President Greg Brockman told employees he won’t make a pledged multimillion-dollar donation to a political group working to elect members of Congress who support pro-artificial intelligence policies.

Brockman and his wife donated \$25 million to Leading the Future last September and had committed to contributing another \$25 million in 2026. Brockman said at the time he had made the donation in a personal capacity, but OpenAI employees criticized the move as an attempt by the company’s leadership to thwart sensible AI regulations.

Brockman sent a Slack message to OpenAI employees in June acknowledging the distraction his donation had created and saying he and his wife had no plans to go through with the second donation, according to a person familiar with the matter.

Leading the Future was launched last year to support candidates for Congress who backed favorable regulation for the artificial-intelligence industry and to push back against arguments that AI models must be regulated before they create catastrophic risks for society. In the year since the super PAC’s launch, AI has become an increasingly polarizing topic and is expected to be a top issue in this year’s midterm elections.

The pro-AI group launched with financial backing from Silicon Valley leaders including the venture firm Andreessen Horowitz, the AI startup Perplexity, 8VC managing partner and Palantir Technologies co-founder Joe Lonsdale, and SV Angel founder Ron Conway.

Leading the Future has made independent expenditures to support and oppose Republicans and Democrats running for the House and Senate.

In June, OpenAI distanced itself from Brockman’s contributions to the super PAC, writing in a blog post that the couple made their contributions in a personal capacity and that the company didn’t direct the PAC’s activities or “have visibility into their operations.”

A representative for Leading the Future declined to comment. Brockman didn’t respond to a request for comment.

Brockman’s withdrawal of his pledge was earlier reported by the New York Times.

News Corp., owner of the Journal, has a content-licensing partnership with OpenAI.

Secret Data-Center Pacts Come Under New Scrutiny

By Neil Mehta and Amrith Ramkumar

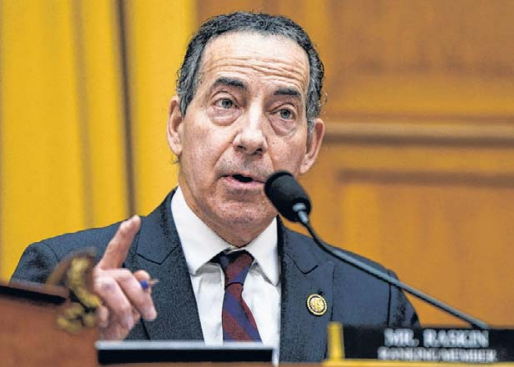
WASHINGTON—A Democratic lawmaker wants more information on the secret agreements between tech companies building data centers and local officials approving them, their latest attempt to increase oversight of the facilities powering artificial intelligence and tap in to voters’ AI backlash ahead of the midterm elections.

Rep. Jamie Raskin (D., Md.), the top Democrat on the House Judiciary Committee, sent letters to Amazon.com, Alphabet’s Google, Meta Platforms and Oracle on Tuesday seeking information on the nondisclosure agreements those companies signed with government officials related to data-center build-outs, according to copies of the letters viewed by The Wall Street Journal.

“Residents cannot weigh a project’s costs against its benefits, hold their officials accountable or safeguard their own resources when the basic terms are kept secret,” Raskin wrote while demanding detailed information on each company’s data-center portfolio and use of the agreements.

Amazon said it no longer uses NDAs with government collaborators on data-center projects. The other companies didn’t comment.

The questioning is an early indication of what AI companies can expect if Democrats



Rep. Jamie Raskin (D., Md.) seeks information on NDAs companies signed with government officials over data centers.

win back power in Congress in November, a prospect that has many in the industry bracing for a wave of demands and hearings.

Local communities have cited nondisclosure agreements and secrecy surrounding data-center plans as a reason they oppose the facilities, which many blame for pushing up power prices and consuming large amounts of water. Consumers across the country have said they had little input before massive infrastructure projects were approved for construction close to their homes subsidized in some way by locals.

Fears about AI replacing human workers and anger at the tech industry have also driven bipartisan opposition to the data-center build-out,

turning the once-obscure computer infrastructure into a political liability.

Industry executives have said that they hope to be more transparent moving forward and have committed to paying more for the power needed to run data centers and investing more in local communities.

Lawmakers across the country are scrutinizing NDA agreements to capitalize on data centers’ historic unpopularity.

Raskin, along with Reps. Greg Landsman (D., Ohio) and Tom Barrett (R., Mich.), introduced a bill last week to limit NDAs with government officials related to data-center projects. States, too, have opposed the agreements, with several introducing bills to ban data-center NDAs.

Other CEOs Privately Challenged Amodoi for His Alarm

By Amrith Ramkumar and Josh Dawsey

WASHINGTON—After agreeing to sign a statement of principles to keep artificial-intelligence models safe Tuesday, AI chief executives surrounded President Trump outside the White House to present the image of a unified industry addressing the public’s fears.

Behind the scenes, industry leaders including Jensen Huang of Nvidia had just questioned Anthropic’s Dario Amodoi about his warnings about the dangers of AI, people familiar with the matter said.

The executives asked Amodoi why he was being so extreme in public about the capabilities of AI models and risks they posed, following a lunch in the East Room with about two dozen CEOs. Amodoi told the other executives that it is important to be honest with the public about model capabilities and not play down risks, some of the people said.

Their conversation occurred with a smaller group of executives and White House aides and advisers who were hashing out the principles in the Roosevelt Room, some of

the people said.

Trump and House Speaker Mike Johnson (R., La.) got the top AI companies to agree to the principles at the lunch, but the questioning of Amodoi is the latest indication of tensions under the surface between Anthropic and the rest of the industry that could hinder the sector’s plan for “self-regulation” using model evaluations and internal controls.

Amodoi has previously criticized the White House and competitors for playing down safety concerns and warned about AI models carrying out cyberattacks and extreme job losses driven by the technology, making him a target for criticism by many in Washington and Silicon Valley.

Jay Clayton, director of national intelligence, said in a statement that the meeting was “one of the most, if not the most, constructive and collegial industry meetings I have ever seen.”

“The focal point was, ‘What is best for the American people and globe?’ and that focal point drove agreement,” said the candidate to be Trump’s next AI “czar” coordinating policy across the administration.



Anthropic’s Dario Amodoi at the White House on Tuesday.

On Tuesday, Amodoi told reporters “we can win safely” if the industry and administration work together, and Trump praised him for being “great.” The duo dined together at the White House Sunday for their first face-to-face meeting.

Anthropic has sought to mend fences with the administration recently and is gearing up for an initial public offering it hopes will value the company at some \$2 trillion. The company is still reeling from a pair of bruising battles with the administration ear-

lier this year that included a 2½-week shutdown of two of its models due to security concerns and being blacklisted by the Pentagon over a dispute regarding how AI is used in the military.

Tuesday’s principles were the result of months of discussions over how to prevent AI cyberattacks following the release of Anthropic’s Mythos and similar models earlier this year. The administration is testing powerful models before they are released publicly, but recent hacks by AI models have demonstrated the need for

stronger reviews when models are being trained and developed, industry executives say.

This summer, Anthropic, OpenAI and Alphabet’s Google had coalesced around an approach being considered by the administration for a self-regulatory organization similar to the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority, which oversees brokerage firms.

Huang, Meta Platforms CEO Mark Zuckerberg and SpaceX’s Elon Musk told Trump they worried the idea would concentrate too much power in the leading AI companies, so the idea was scrapped, The Wall Street Journal previously reported.

That structure also would have involved many of the ideas included in Tuesday’s principles, such as stronger internal reviews of models during development and external testing.

That highlighted the pressure facing the White House and industry due to public concerns about AI and the data centers powering it.

Zuckerberg in particular played a key role in finalizing Tuesday’s principles, frequently talking to Trump and others in the administration, some of the people said.

U.S. NEWS

White House Stymies
RFK Jr. Food Agenda

Ultraprocessed definition becomes a flashpoint inside the administration

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s efforts to re-vamp America's food system have hit their biggest hurdle yet: the White House.

By Liz Essley Whyte, Jesse Newman and Josh Dawsey

Two years ago, the Trump campaign joined forces with Kennedy, embracing his ambition to wage war on chronic disease. But concerns about whether his ideas on food are even feasible have prompted clashes within the administration, casting uncertainty over a once-potent political agenda that drew support from millions of voters.

At a July meeting convened by senior White House officials, tensions were running high. Up for discussion was a definition of ultraprocessed food—a wonky but critical part of Kennedy's plans to overhaul the U.S. food supply—and whether it should undergo a layer of further review by White House staff.

The definition that health officials pushed for: Processed food should be considered ultraprocessed if it contains ingredients such as artificial colors, nonnutritive sweeteners or chemical preservatives, with exemptions, according to people familiar with the matter and a document viewed by The Wall Street Journal. White House staffers were concerned the definition could cover most food in U.S. grocery

stores and support existing efforts to sue food companies over bad health outcomes.

One of Kennedy's top aides, Calley Means, accused White House officials of trying to block the definition to cater to special interests, some of the people said. Means, a fiery influencer and wellness author, raised his voice and repeatedly asked why the definition required additional review, saying it wasn't open for further debate. He said Kennedy's health department had already worked on it for months and had vetted it with scientists.

In response, White House officials highlighted concerns that the definition could be exploited by the plaintiffs' bar and be grounds for a lawsuit against the government. They also pointed to its potential impact on the food industry and international trade agreements.

Initiative stalled

The internal discord has stalled efforts to curb the country's reliance on ultraprocessed foods, a cornerstone of Kennedy's agenda to remake the U.S. food supply.

Means has mounted an expansive effort to roll out policies in Trump's second term, saying the administration needs to deliver for its "Make America Healthy Again" supporters. White House officials have often viewed him as overly aggressive, pushing policies that aren't feasible and seeming unwilling to compromise to make them more achievable, officials said.

Means complained in other meetings that he believed some White House officials were behaving like it was their job to help food-industry lobbyists

work against Kennedy's agenda, one person said.

"The White House has repeatedly taken on special interests and broken processes to deliver effective and legally durable MAHA policies," said White House spokesman Kush Desai. "The entire Trump administration continues to work closely with stakeholders and industry leaders to continue overhauling our country's food and updating nutritional guidance."

White House chief of staff Susie Wiles had voiced support for Kennedy's agenda throughout the year and met with MAHA advocates in April to hear their concerns about the administration's support for pesticides and other issues.

The Department of Health and Human Services didn't respond to requests for comment.

The outcome of the July meeting: White House officials decided that the ultraprocessed-food definition would go through further review, people familiar with the decision said. Still, Kennedy's team thought it had clearance to unveil the definition and planned a high-profile food-policy event in August, some of the people said.

Kennedy's allies were jubilant. The weekend before the event, the White House reversed course, nixing a debut of the full definition. Certain White House officials were caught off guard, unaware the health department aimed to unveil it, a person familiar with the matter said.

The White House reversed and nixed a debut of the full definition.



President Trump and Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. at the White House

Mark Paoletta, a White House lawyer who is running the office that reviews all new regulations, opposed the plan. Paoletta viewed the definition as adding new rules when the administration's goal is to cut red tape, people familiar with the matter said. He also agreed with industry arguments that the measure could be a boon to the trial bar, the people said.

Wiles stopped returning calls from MAHA advocates that weekend, people familiar with the matter said.

HHS officials still held the event, premiering a separate food effort and saying they were continuing to work on the ultraprocessed-food policy.

Means and Dr. Heidi Overton, Trump's nominee to lead the Food and Drug Administration, tried again to publish the definition at the end of the month but were again forbid-

den by others in the White House, people familiar with the matter said.

In the weeks since the definition's scuttled unveiling, many food and agriculture groups and companies, as well as health groups and consumer advocates, have sought to weigh in. White House staff have met to discuss the definition with groups representing farmers, meatpackers, food and beverage manufacturers, grocers and more.

"We have the shortest lifespans of any wealthy country," said Jerold Mande, chief executive of Nourish Science, a nonprofit, and a former FDA and Agriculture Department official. "It's an urgent problem that the MAHA movement and RFK Jr. came to power saying they were going to address, and they've had a decidedly mixed record."

A top health official said Tuesday at a "MAHA Summit" hosted by Kennedy allies that HHS is in the "final stages" with the ultra-processed food definition and that finishing it

will help the administration craft new rules for food labels. "That will have a huge impact on being able to understand what a product is," said Kennedy aide Stefanie Spear.

Safety review

Meanwhile, Kennedy has yet to launch a safety review of some of the most common ingredients in ultraprocessed food. Last year, former FDA commissioner David Kessler asked the agency to declare certain refined carbohydrates unsafe.

In March, Kennedy backed Kessler's effort, according to a draft letter viewed by the Journal. "I believe your petition points toward a historic opportunity to significantly improve the quality of our food supply and thus the health of our citizens," he wrote. The text of the draft letter was earlier reported by the Washington Post.

The White House blocked release of the letter, people familiar with the matter said.

U.S. WATCH



ROLLING ALONG: Eitan Gerstle of Seattle looked on as Amtrak Cascades train 516 to Vancouver, British Columbia, crossed the Salmon Bay Bridge on the first day of service for Amtrak's Airo trainsets in Seattle on Wednesday.

TENNESSEE

Execution Attempt Fails, Witnesses Say

Tennessee officials were unable to put Christa Gail Pike to death for a 1995 murder Wednesday, media witnesses said, after the lethal injection was halted for hours as courts considered a last-minute appeal of what would have been the state's first execution of a woman in at least 200 years.

Pike, 50, had been scheduled for execution for a killing she committed at age 18 after the U.S. Supreme Court overturned an appeals court ruling that stopped the lethal injection hour before it was to start.

Officials appeared to give Pike two doses of pentobarbital. At 7:46 p.m. prison officials closed the curtain to the media room. They raised the curtain three minutes later. Pike could be heard loudly snoring, and the curtain was closed again at 8:06 p.m. Pike continued to be heard snoring until the microphone was cut off at about 8:53 p.m.

Lawyers for Pike filed an emergency motion to the U.S. Supreme Court seeking to immediately halt and stay the execution, saying she was in "unnecessary agony."

—Associated Press

WISCONSIN

Mosque Leader Can Be Deported

The U.S. can deport the leader of Wisconsin's largest mosque—an outspoken advocate of Palestinian rights—on the grounds that he is a threat to national security, an immigration judge ruled on Wednesday.

Salah Sarsour was detained in Milwaukee in March by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers. A federal judge ordered Sarsour's release in June, saying he raised a "substantial" claim that the Trump administration was targeting him for speaking out against Israel and advocating for Palestinian rights.

Sarsour said he intends to appeal. "I will continue fighting to defend the right to free speech and to stay in the country I have called home for more than three decades," he said.

Government attorneys say Sarsour's decades-old convictions in Israel make him a threat to national security and accuse him of lying on his green-card application and falsely claiming citizenship to vote.

—Associated Press

Mogul Sets Up Wealth Behemoth

Continued from Page One explosive wealth boom at the top. Total U.S. household wealth reached a record \$185.7 trillion in the second quarter of 2026, according to Federal Reserve data, though new wealth is disproportionately accruing to the already well-off. The share of wealth held by families in the top 0.1% climbed to 15% from 13.5% five years earlier; families in the rest of the top 1%, a much larger group, saw their share of wealth hit 17.5%, from 17.2%.

The number of single-family offices, which manage the fortunes and affairs of a single family, roughly reflects the surge in wealth at the top. Wealth-intelligence firm Altrata estimates there were 9,237 single-family offices globally in 2025, up from 6,269 in 2019.

Jeff Bezos' stepfather, Mike Bezos, hired a chief executive

for his Miami-based family office last year as he began institutionalizing it; he and his late wife, Jacklyn Bezos, were estimated to be worth about \$45 billion earlier that year.

SGF Capital was set up in Dallas in 2024 to manage the fortune of the late oilman Aubrey Stephens, who died in 2024, months after selling his company for \$26 billion.

Members of the Mills family, who in 2021 sold their majority stake in medical-supplies distributor Medline Industries to a private-equity consortium for more than \$30 billion excluding debt, set up several family offices—Cedar Pine, Council Ring Capital and MBB Capital Partners—to manage their pieces of the fortune.

Nvidia Chief Executive Jensen Huang, whose fortune has climbed to an estimated nearly \$200 billion, has a small family office but also has become a client of multifamily office Iconiq Capital in San Francisco, according to people familiar with the matter.

A family office's function varies depending on the desires of the family that forms it, but the most sophisticated can manage a family's fortune

as well as provide tax-and-estate planning, legal counsel and concierge services like private planes, bill pay, household staffing and the management of a portfolio of homes. Some advise a single-family office is worth setting up only if a family has a net worth of at least \$1 billion.

Joining a family office can come with risks for investment staff compared with working at an institutional investment firm.

A patriarch or matriarch

could change his or her mind about wanting to have and manage a family office, and opportunities for promotion can be slimmer. Navigating family dynamics also is a consideration. Family offices today often need to operate across generations and jurisdictions, according to Citigroup's 2026 Global Family Office Report, based on its survey of 351 family office clients.

Headhunters say good governance can reduce some risks of joining a family office and that

a family's long-term investment horizon can be attractive.

Born in South Africa to Lithuanian Jewish immigrants, Nathan "Natie" Kirsh, 94 years old, early on served small businesses during apartheid that sought affordable goods through his wholesale distribution business.

Customers, including Black shopkeepers who didn't have access to credit, visited his warehouses to pick up produce and other items and paid with cash, a model that cut delivery and distribution costs.

He was looking abroad for opportunities by the mid-1970s. During a visit to New York, he studied how bodegas sourced their goods and found it inefficient, he told a London Business School class in 2011, looking back on a career that had spanned continents and companies.

He founded Jetto Cash & Carry in Brooklyn in 1976 with a similar model and built what became Jetto Restaurant Depot into a dominant force in the restaurant-supply market.

"I have an instinct to see opportunity where others may not," he said in the talk.

Restaurant Depot operates 167 stores across 35 states and had about \$16 billion in revenue in 2025.

Linda Mirels, one of Kirsh's children and an immediate past president of UJA-Federation of New York, is heavily involved in the process of building out the family office, the people said. She is working with executive search firm BraddockMatthewsBarrett. Members of the family—which also include Kirsh's other daughter, Wendy Fisher, president of the Solomon R. Guggenheim Foundation board in New York, London, Los Angeles and elsewhere.

The search firm has described the investment chief as having a "rare" mandate to create a family office investment platform from the ground up.

The family's investment portfolio includes a London skyscraper called Tower 42, Australian real-estate company Abacus Property Group and a stake in outsourced CIO firm Partners Capital. Partners has managed part of their wealth to date, along with consulting and OCIO firm Cambridge Associates.



Restaurant Depot, founded by Kirsh, operates 167 stores.

WORLD NEWS

Iran’s Vessels Stranded in Asian Waters

Crews on ships run low on food, water and fuel, as providers fear U.S. sanctions

By JON EMONT

COLOMBO, Sri Lanka—Some 15 miles off the southwest coast of Sri Lanka, about 20 empty Iranian oil tankers are stranded, drifting with their engines idled as food, fuel and fresh water run low. They are the most visible consequence of the new pressure campaign by the U.S. to bring Iran to heel. Dozens of Iranian or Iranian-linked tankers that participated in the shadowy trade of getting sanctioned oil to China have been stuck in the waters near Asian countries like Sri Lanka and Malaysia since July, when the U.S. reimposed its blockade of the Strait of Hormuz. Then, recently, U.S. officials pressured Sri Lanka into blocking local ships from provisioning the tankers and their crews, according to Sri Lankan government documents and companies that provide provisions to those ships. The Trump administration is pursuing a hardball strategy aimed at forcing Iran into making concessions in the

monthslong conflict. In recent days, the U.S.—which slapped Iran with a slew of new sanctions this summer—warned Iran’s trading partners to ditch the country. Before the war, ships carrying Iranian oil would ferry the crude to international waters off Malaysia, where they transferred it to other tankers that would carry it to Chinese refineries, an operation designed to evade U.S. sanctions on Iranian oil. The tankers would then sail back to Iran, pick up more oil, and do it again. Some tankers are Iranian. Others sail under different flags but have been sanctioned by the U.S. because of their involvement in such subterfuge. Now, the blockade has dealt this trade a blow. Iranian ships can’t return home. The U.S. sanctions blitz means that some Asian ports that once serviced them refuse them out of fear of U.S. sanctions, leaving the tankers adrift at sea. The squeeze also has affected container ships bringing goods to Iran. On a recent journey to international waters off the coast of Malaysia chartered by United Against Nuclear Iran—a U.S. advocacy group—empty, rusting Iranian-linked ships floated in the water. Many have been anchored there since July.

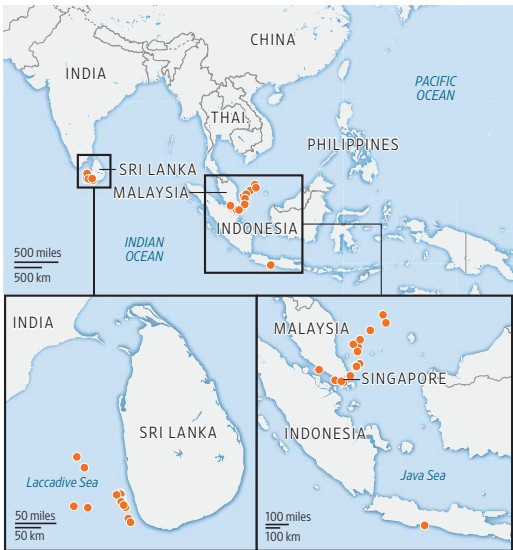


An Iranian-flagged carrier was seen off Malaysia in September.

One was the Elva, a sanctioned tanker that had loaded up with oil on Iran’s Kharg Island and crossed the Strait of Hormuz in June, said financial-data provider LSEG. It has been lingering off Malaysia since discharging the crude to another vessel in August. Sailors on the Elva appeared bored. One started dancing when he saw a passing boat. Oil analysts expect that the last of the Iranian oil waiting to be transferred to buyers will run out in the coming weeks, with payments to Iran to conclude by year’s end. During the past two months, many of the tankers have left the area off Malaysia for the Indian Ocean and the coast of Sri Lanka, which is closer to Iran and has a history of providing fuel, provisions and repair

crews to Iranian ships. But in August, the U.S. Embassy in Sri Lanka told the government it was tracking 19 Iranian tankers off the country’s western coast and urged officials to tell port-service providers to deny them support or risk U.S. secondary sanctions, according to Sri Lankan government documents seen by The Wall Street Journal. Around this time, many of the Iranian vessels pulled away from Sri Lanka’s territorial waters, with many drifting deeper into the Indian Ocean, their engines idled to conserve fuel, said ship-tracking data and Sri Lankan maritime businesses. The State Department said that the U.S. will “continue to disrupt, expose, and dismantle” Iran’s illicit oil trade, and called on the international community to hold Iran ac-

Latest positions of select stranded tankers as of Sept. 29



Source: MarineTraffic

ANDREW BARNETT/WSJ

countable. It didn’t reply to a request for comment on the conditions facing the crews of the Iran-linked vessels. Dubai-based shipping agents for the tankers have pleaded with businesses in Sri Lanka to send food and fuel. But representatives of Sri Lankan shipping companies say it has become difficult to get approval from port authorities. The owner of a Sri Lankan shipping-repair company that dispatched a team to an Iranian vessel just before the onset of the new rules found the provisions on the tanker were dwindling. While repair crews are normally fed on board and can wash there, the tanker’s crew told them to bring their own food and warned them that they couldn’t wash because the vessel needed to conserve fresh water, the company official said. Thushara Rodrigo, a spokesman for Sri Lanka’s foreign ministry, acknowledged the risk that sanctioned ships might run out of food, fuel and water. He said that if ships require emergency provisions, private companies could be reluctant to supply the tankers and risk sanctions. Advocates of a tougher Iran policy say that targeting those that provision the ships could raise the cost—and risk—of owning and servicing vessels that carry Iranian oil and goods, making it difficult to carry out Iran’s shadow oil trade. “A vessel that is sitting and not carrying oil is just a hole in the budget,” said Mark Wallace, UANI’s CEO, who has called for tougher U.S. sanctions against Malaysian groups that supply the ships.

How Plane Disaster Was Averted

Continued from Page One minutes later, they changed the alert to a code signaling unlawful interference—used to describe attempts to jeopardize the safety of the airplane, like hijacking or hostage taking. The pilots then steered the plane to an emergency landing in the Saudi city of Tabuk. About 170 passengers, almost all Israeli and many of them children, were safe and accounted for. Four Americans, all U.S.-Israeli dual nationals, were on the plane, according to a State Department spokesman. Saudi authorities had the first crack at interviewing the passengers and crew. They have initially assessed that the attacking pilot tried to deliberately crash the plane, people familiar with the matter said. They don’t yet have a theory

Experts Marvel at Safe Landing

Aviation experts were surprised the plane didn’t crash after a descent so extreme that most of the rudder was ripped off the tail. “That was a serious descent and strong aerodynamic forces on that rudder for that to happen. I’m just amazed the aircraft didn’t come apart,” said Steve Arroyo, a former United Airlines pilot and aviation-safety expert. Jeff Guzzetti, another

aviation safety expert, said given the rate of descent, it might not have been possible for the plane to level out if it had fallen below 10,000 feet. “What saved them is there was enough altitude left for them to recover,” said Guzzetti, who used to investigate crashes for the National Transportation Safety Board and the Federal Aviation Administration in the U.S. —Associated Press

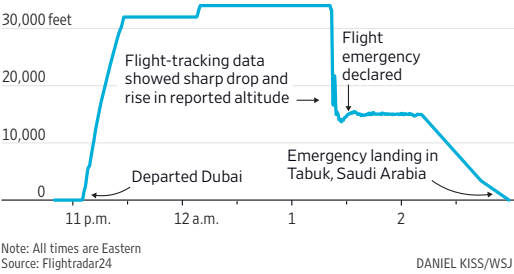


FlyDubai flight diverted to Saudi Arabia after cockpit struggle



- 1 11:05 p.m. Departs Dubai
- 2 1:21 a.m. Altitude fluctuations begin
- 3 1:22 a.m. Aircraft drops more than 14,000 feet in under 30 seconds
- 4 1:31 a.m. Transponder signals general emergency (Squawk 7700)
- 5 1:38 a.m. Transponder switches to code for unlawful interference (Squawk 7500)
- 6 Around 2:45 a.m. Lands at Tabuk Regional Airport

FlyDubai flight showed extreme altitude fluctuations before landing in Saudi Arabia



Note: All times are Eastern Source: Flightradar24

DANIEL KISS/WSJ

The FlyDubai plane, with damage to its tail, is shown after an emergency landing.

kot holiday in Israel. Photos shared with the Journal showed strollers, children carrying colorful backpacks, and their parents among the passengers. Flight-tracking data service Flightradar24 shows the plane took off shortly after 7 a.m. local time and began climbing to 34,000 feet. The first sign of trouble came about two hours and 15 minutes into the flight when the aircraft started to lose altitude. The plane hurtled into a nearly minute-long nosedive, plummeting almost 3 miles. The speed of the dive pushed the plane to the limits of its engineering. A section of the plane’s rudder—which controls side to side movements—was ripped from its tail, according to images of the aircraft and an official familiar with the initial investigation. Italie gripped his seat and tightened his seat belt, wondering if there was a problem with the plane. The commotion in the cockpit, the passengers rushing forward and the new pilots taking charge all happened so fast, Italie said. After the fight was over, doctors treated the injured, and one of the pilots was restrained, he said. On the ground in Saudi Arabia, authorities questioned the passengers and crew, keeping them for about seven hours before the airline could bring in another plane to fly them onward to Israel. As the new flight approached the airport in Tel Aviv, it checked in with the tower. “Thank you for bringing our passengers safely back home,” the tower radioed back.

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into the incident continues. The near-disaster sent a shudder through a region racked by three years of war and raised a host of troubling possibilities that officials in Saudi Arabia, Israel and the United Arab Emirates are just beginning to investigate. Negotiations to end the war Israel and the U.S. launched against Iran appear stalled, and anger runs high over Israel’s conduct in the war against Hamas in the Gaza Strip. The U.S. has tightened its economic sanctions on Iran and bolstered its naval blockade by persuading countries including the United Arab Emirates to cut air links with the country. Iran’s top national-security official has warned that countries that block Iranian flights will lose the use of their own airports. The incident hit one of the most robust links between Israel and the outside world. While many Western carriers have repeatedly cut flights to Israel during the years of conflict, the U.A.E., which signed a diplomatic accord with Israel in 2020, has provided steady connections with multiple flights each day between Tel Aviv and the international aviation hub of Dubai. It also delivered another blow to Dubai, whose important tourism and aviation earners have been shaken by thousands of Iranian attacks on the country and concerns about the continuing war. The scenario echoed other air disasters like the crashes of EgyptAir Flight 990 into the Atlantic in 1999 and Germanwings Flight 9525 into the French Alps in 2015, which some regulators attributed to actions by their first officers. The latter led to requirements that two crew members be in the cockpit at all times. “The protocols to try to stop these things from happening in general work very efficiently. But when insiders are involved, inherently, the risk of bypassing protocols is there,” said Matthew Borie,

chief intelligence officer and co-founder of Osprey Flight Solutions. “The vast majority of these post-9/11 security measures in the aviation industry are meant to deal with passengers—to stop people from being able to access the cockpit. But that assumes the people in the cockpit are part of the solution and not part of the potential problem.” A former FlyDubai crew member said all pilots are subject to security screening before flights and have medical checks at least once a year. FlyDubai’s budget flights from Dubai to Tel Aviv attract a consistent crowd of Jewish and Arab Israelis

coming home from vacations, international workers coming in for stints, and a handful of business travelers. It isn’t unusual to see hippy travelers, families in Orthodox clothing and women in hijab on flights that also typically teem with children. Passengers make their way through normal security in Dubai to a gate further back in the airport, then get bused across the tarmac to walk aboard the plane. By halfway through the 3½-hour flight, many are often slumped over their partners asleep. Wednesday’s flight was bringing families home in the middle of the weeklong Suk-

WORLD NEWS

Antisemitism
Claims Threaten
French Far Right

Le Pen’s protégé reportedly wrote private messages over a decade ago

By Noemie Bisserbe

PARIS—For more than a decade Marine Le Pen has sought to distance her party from its antisemitic past, elevating her fresh-faced protégé Jordan Bardella to the highest ranks of the National Rally.

Now, allegations about Bardella’s past are testing that strategy.

French news outlet Mediapart reported this week that Bardella wrote antisemitic private messages more than a decade ago, including that “All banks are owned by Jews.”

“Jews must dominate other peoples, crush them, and rob them,” the outlet reported him as writing in email and Facebook messages. “They want a new world order dominated by Israel, with Jerusalem of course, as its capital.”

Bardella denied that he wrote the messages, dismissing the report as a smear campaign. “This is an attempt to destabilize the presidential

campaign, with the goal of politically destroying me,” he told reporters Tuesday, adding that he filed a defamation lawsuit against Mediapart.

Mediapart didn’t identify the recipients of the messages, and The Wall Street Journal couldn’t independently confirm their authenticity.

The allegations against Bardella, whom Le Pen has favored as her choice for prime minister should she win the presidency next year, have thrown the party into turmoil and triggered a frantic internal effort to unmask the source of the report.

Le Pen and Bardella appeared side by side Tuesday at a meeting at the National Assembly in Paris, during which they said the alleged messages were fake and pledged to fight back.

“We are not going to take this lying down,” Le Pen said, sitting next to Bardella. “We are going to expose this manipulation, and we’ll find out who’s behind it.”

Jean-Philippe Tanguy, a French lawmaker and close Le Pen aide, accused former members of the party who were ousted in recent years of being responsible.

French President Emman-



Jordan Bardella, 31, helped widen the party’s appeal, particularly among younger residents.

uel Macron denounced the contents of the alleged messages as extremely serious and unacceptable. “We will never tolerate antisemitic comments,” he said Wednesday.

When she took over the party in 2011, Le Pen began a process of what she called de-demonization to shake off the party’s image as racist and antisemitic. The National Rally, formerly known as the National Front, was founded by her late father, Jean-Marie Le Pen and two former SS Nazis, Pierre Bousquet and Léon Gaultier. Jean-Marie Le Pen’s nativist and antisemitic rhet-

oric made him a pariah of Europe’s political establishment and, at times, a source of embarrassment to his own daughter. In 2015, she ejected her father from the party over his repeated characterization of Nazi gas chambers as a “detail of history.”

Marine Le Pen instead pushed a new generation of young party members, including Bardella, who is now 31 years old. Unencumbered by the Le Pen family name, he helped broaden the party’s appeal, particularly among younger generations. National Rally’s group in the National Assembly, France’s lower house of

Parliament, grew from a handful to 122 lawmakers. Bardella quickly rose through the party’s ranks, taking over National Rally’s presidency as Le Pen launched her 2022 presidential bid.

In a 2023 TV interview, Bardella, however, sparked outrage when he said Jean-Marie Le Pen wasn’t an antisemite. Days later, some Jewish groups tried to stop him, and the rest of the National Rally delegation, from taking part in a march against antisemitism organized in Paris in the wake of the Oct. 7, 2023, attacks in Israel.

The National Rally adopted a firmly pro-Israel stance on the war in Gaza, helping ameliorate the party’s relationship with Israel. In March 2025, the government of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu invited Bardella to

Israel, an unprecedented visit for the far-right party.

Macron’s government condemned the attacks on Israel while voicing staunch support for Palestinian rights and statehood throughout Israel’s subsequent war on Gaza.

Bardella was expected to run in next year’s presidential elections after Le Pen was convicted of misusing European funds and barred from seeking office for five years. But in July, Le Pen said she would run after appellate judges reduced the lower court sentence, narrowing the effective ban to 15 months, which the politician had already completed.

The court, however, sentenced her to a three-year prison term, with two of the years suspended. The remaining year, judges said, could be served wearing an electronic bracelet, raising the possibility that Le Pen would have to campaign under judicial surveillance.

Le Pen denies wrongdoing and has appealed the ruling.

Despite her conviction, Le Pen remains a front-runner in presidential polls.

Yonathan Arfi, president of the Representative Council of French Jewish Institutions, said the messages, if really sent by Bardella, would represent “a stinging rebuke of the National Rally’s de-demonization strategy.”

“How could a political leader who made such repugnant antisemitic remarks have subsequently been entrusted with such responsibilities in a party that claims to have changed and to be fighting against hatred of Jews?” he wrote on X this week.

Inflation in Eurozone’s Biggest Economies Hits Multiyear Highs

By Ed Frankl

Inflation among leading eurozone nations climbed to multiyear highs in September, reflecting enduring energy-price pressures that could push the European Central Bank to raise its key interest rate again in October.

Consumer prices rose 3.3%

in Germany, 3.4% in France and 4.1% in Italy compared with the same month of last year, up from August’s 2.9%, 2.6% and 3.2%, respectively. The readings, based on data harmonized to European Union standards, were higher than expected by economists polled by The Wall Street Journal in France and Italy,

while matching for Germany.

Energy inflation accelerated after fuel prices jumped in September on escalating tensions in the Middle East. Prices also increased for food, the countries’ statistics agencies said Wednesday.

Price growth therefore reached its strongest level since December 2023 in Ger-

many, January 2024 in France and September 2023 in Italy, the data showed.

The ECB in September raised its key rate, with its president, Christine Lagarde, saying policymakers couldn’t “look through” the recent jump in oil and gas prices. She told EU lawmakers this week that a measured response was

appropriate to keep inflation in check.

However, the data suggests that indirect effects of higher energy costs are beginning to feed through, Capital Economics economist Jack Allen-Reynolds said in a note to clients.

Inflation data for Spain and Belgium published Tuesday also showed price growth well

above the ECB’s 2% target. Investors are about evenly split on whether the central bank will hike or not on Oct. 29.

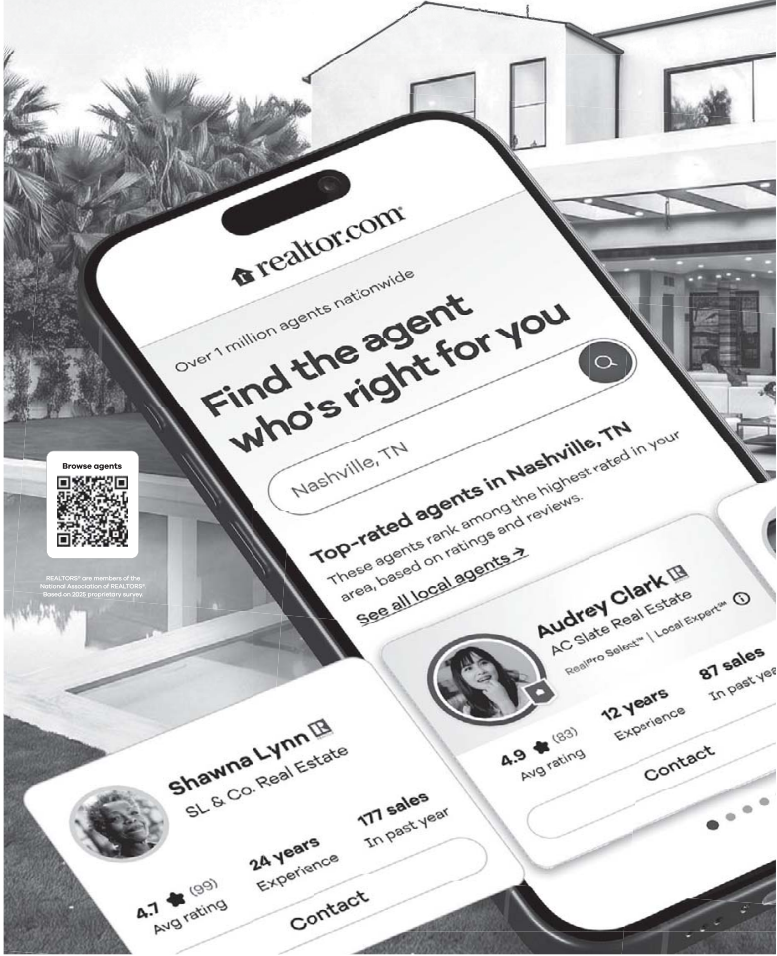
“With eurozone inflation likely to average near 4% by the end of the year, we expect two more ECB rate hikes in the current cycle,” said Oxford Economics economist Rory Fennessy.



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WORLD NEWS

U.K. Says Iran Likely Tied to Foiled Attack

Tehran played a part in attempt to strike RAF Fairford base, prime minister says

By MAX COLCHESTER

U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham said there were “strong indications” that Iran played a part in a foiled attack on RAF Fairford last weekend, when five masked men were arrested next to the air base which has been used by the U.S. as a staging post for bombers striking Iran.

“We will say more in due course, but we can confirm our belief that we believe Iran to have played a part,” Burnham told the BBC.

His comments back up earlier assertions by Secretary of State Marco Rubio that a foreign actor was behind the botched attempt. U.S. officials have said they consider Iran to be the most likely culprit.

U.S. officials were aware of an Iran-linked plot to attack the bomber aircraft and kill personnel at the base, said an official familiar with the intelligence. A branch of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps had recruited U.K. nationals to carry out the plot, which involved several steps including a diversion in the nearby neighborhood, an official said.

Asked about those claims, the White House referred to comments made by President Trump, who earlier said the men intended to do serious



Police guard an area near RAF Fairford air base in Britain.

damage to the base, which houses about a dozen heavy U.S. bombers, and that they had been under investigation. Iran has a record of using

criminal proxies to carry out covert operations on European soil, usually targeting Jewish sites or dissidents of the regime. Past plots have involved

hiring young men via encrypted apps. Sometimes those hired didn’t know who they were working for.

Using proxies to plot an attack on a U.K. military installation would mark a significant escalation, given Britain isn’t directly at war with Iran. Iran has targeted British bases abroad during the war.

The details of the incident are still shrouded in mystery. U.K. counterterrorism police released the men on bail shortly after they were arrested and said they found no explosives in the three white vans they were driving.

A further twist emerged Monday after officials said police were alerted to the plot early Sunday by one of the arrested suspects, who called

emergency services to tip them off. That revelation fueled speculation that one of the suspects might have gotten cold feet about the operation.

Iran’s Embassy in the U.K. has said it “categorically rejects” attempts to link Iran to the arrests.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps has warned the U.K. that it would face consequences for allowing the U.S. to use its bases to attack Iran.

The five men arrested were all in their 20s and living in London, police said. The vans they drove to the site contained black barrels holding fuel, they said.

“I have complete confidence in the way British security services are handling this,” Burnham added.

Defying Trump Has Given Carney Popular Mandate to Change Canada

By AMANDA COLETTA

TORONTO—Overhauling environmental reviews and accelerating approvals of oil pipelines and mines. Massive increases in military spending. Mending ties with China, India and Saudi Arabia.

Prime Minister Mark Carney is barreling forward with a re-wiring of Canada’s economic, national-security and foreign policies that, in some cases, would once have been unthinkable and unpopular. A political novice until he won the premiership last year, Carney has vanquished opposition that might have felled his predecessors because of confrontations with President Trump that has given him highflying popularity.

Polls show that Carney’s Liberals would win a majority if an election were held today. A survey released Tuesday from Nanos Research found he was the preferred choice for prime minister of more than 60% of respondents, the highest level it has recorded for him.

Several lawmakers from across the political spectrum have defected to the Liberals in the past year. His opponents

are laboring to land a punch. Conservative Party leader Pierre Poilievre has spent months squaring off against critics within his own party.

Even in Alberta, a traditionally conservative stronghold, people have more favorable views of Carney than Poilievre and Alberta Premier Danielle Smith, a recent Ipsos poll shows.

“I cannot remember, in my adult life, a prime minister having this good an 18 months,” said Darrell Bricker, chief executive of Ipsos.

Analysts said Carney has succeeded in framing most of his domestic and international agenda around reducing Canada’s reliance on the U.S. It has worked with a Canadian public furious about the hits their economy has taken from the Trump administration’s tariffs and the threats the president has made about annexing America’s neighbor.

In normal times, polls show

building pipelines and spending more on defense have been divisive issues here, but most Canadians support both. A Pew Research Survey this year found Canadians have a more favorable view of China than the U.S. In 2026, 44% of Canadians viewed China favorably, it found, up from 14% in 2023.

Lori Turnbull, a political scientist at Nova Scotia’s Dalhousie University, said Carney likely wanted to pursue many of these policies as prime minister, but the conflict with the U.S. “gives him a logic, gives

him a narrative that might make more sense to people.”

“The way he’s describing it is essentially we’re in an emergency situation, we’re in a kind of something that’s similar to a war,” she said. “He’s made this about our sovereignty, and so it all kind of fits together.”

A sign of bipartisan support for parts of Carney’s agenda was on display recently as he

hosted Canada’s inaugural investment summit, where former Conservative Prime Minister Stephen Harper delivered the closing keynote address and backed the current Canadian leader’s approach to dealing with Trump.

“It is clear that the current U.S. administration views our level of economic integration as incompatible with our separate sovereignty,” said Harper, who called himself one of the most pro-U.S. prime ministers. “Thus, to maintain that sovereignty, we must pursue diminished reliance on the United States.”

Carney’s public defiance amid Trump’s attacks has set him apart from other world leaders, who often have cut quick trade deals with Trump, only to get threats of even more tariffs.

In a January speech at Davos, Carney urged middle powers to stand up to hegemony and called for the formation of “different coalitions for different issues based on common values and interests.”

Just because Carney is popular now doesn’t mean he isn’t generating criticism.

An omnibus bill introduced

Premier is pressing environmental, defense, foreign-relations issues.



A recent poll showed Mark Carney was the preferred choice for prime minister of more than 60% of respondents.

last week to speed up the approval process of major infrastructure projects and to revamp the environmental-review processes for those projects is drawing praise from business groups but opposition from indigenous people, environmental groups and labor unions, who could challenge it in court. The bill would allow infrastructure, energy and mining projects to undergo a single review lasting no more than a year.

“The prime minister wants us to believe that rolling out the red carpet for the wealthiest corporations and investors is going to make Canada strong,” said Avi Lewis, the leader of the left-of-center New Democratic Party. “But we can’t save Canada by selling it off.”

Carney’s international strategy also isn’t without chal-

lenges and tricky trade-offs.

Brokering trade deals with other countries and building new infrastructure to get products to non-U.S. markets won’t happen overnight, even with expedited approval processes.

While Trump’s tariffs and import bans aren’t expected to plunge Canada’s economy into a recession, they will cause job losses and are hitting manufacturing sectors hard. Most Canadians supported Carney’s decision to walk away from trade talks.

“Canadians are assuming the worst, hoping for the best,” said Bricker. “They know that they’re not going to get through this unscathed, but they feel the person who could do the best job of making sure that they’re damaged the least is Mark Carney.”

WORLDWATCH



REMEMBERING: Flowers are presented at a Martyrs’ Day ceremony to honor to fallen national heroes in Beijing.

UKRAINE Strikes Hit Power Grid, Kill Seven

Russia pressed its missile-and-drone barrage of Ukraine, killing seven people, mainly targeting the power grid, officials said Wednesday.

Moscow’s escalation of its aerial campaign since late August is putting pressure on Ukraine as it braces for winter, when Russia regularly bombards energy facilities to deny Ukrainians heat, power and running water.

“There has been virtually no day since summer when the enemy did not attack energy infrastructure,” Prime Minister Serhii Korotshuk said.

Ukrainian officials say Moscow isn’t engaging with U.S. efforts to halt the fighting, 4½ years after Russia invaded its neighbor.

—Associated Press

FRANCE 13 Sentenced in Deadly Boat Sinking

Thirteen people were sentenced to prison terms of up to 10 years on Wednesday in connection with the sinking of a boat in the English Channel nearly five years ago, in one of the biggest tragedies of migrants making the crossing.

Thirty-one migrants, most of whom were Iraqi Kurds, died in 2021 when their boat sank.

Fourteen people, including two who remain at large, were on trial. One of them was acquitted. They were accused of organizing the crossing of a boat that was unfit for open-sea navigation, was overloaded and lacked appropriate life jackets. A probe into seven military personnel who were indicted for not helping survivors is continuing.

—Associated Press

GAZA STRIP Israeli Attacks Leave Five Dead

Israeli strikes killed five Palestinians and wounded 19 in Gaza, hospital officials said Wednesday, the latest of nearly daily attacks since Israel and Hamas agreed to a truce nearly a year ago, halting the heaviest of the fighting.

Officials at Shifa Hospital said an Israeli strike killed a woman and critically wounded her husband in Gaza City, while another hit a bus, killing four and wounding at least 14. Elsewhere in the strip, a strike in Khan Younis wounded four Palestinians, officials at Nasser Hospital said.

Israel’s military didn’t respond to questions about the bus strike, but said it was reviewing information about the strike in Khan Younis.

—Associated Press

HONG KONG Financial Dispute Spurred Murder

The killing of Hong Kong socialite Abby Choi was likely linked to a financial dispute with her ex-father-in-law over a luxury apartment, the prosecution said Wednesday, in a case that has shocked the city after Choi’s dismembered body was found three years ago.

In her opening statement at the murder trial, a prosecutor alleged Choi’s ex-husband Alex Kwong, his father Kwong Kau and his brother Anthony Kwong killed Choi together in February 2023.

Choi was a 28-year-old socialite and mother of four who shared her glamorous life on social media.

The trio of defendants pleaded not guilty to the murder charge.

—Associated Press

Mexico Steps Up Fight Against Cartels

By MAX FILLION

Mexican authorities are stepping up their fight against cartel money laundering after pressure from the U.S. and other international authorities.

The country’s legislature recently expanded anti-money-laundering laws to impose stricter due-diligence requirements and push companies to collect more information on their controlling ownership, among other measures. President Claudia Sheinbaum installed a new head of Mexico’s financial-intelligence unit, which gathers information on suspicious transactions and reports them to law enforcement.

But anti-money-laundering experts question whether the measures will improve the country’s enforcement and be enough to satisfy the Trump administration and the Financial Action Task Force, an international body that sets standards for combating money laundering. U.S. authorities and FATF, which can each effectively sever Mexico’s banks from their global counterparts, have criticized Mexico’s low money-laundering conviction numbers.

The U.S. increasingly has pressured Mexico to rein in its drug cartels, which began holding territory as far back as the 1980s and have grown in power amid the recent rise of fentanyl. The Trump administration has tried to lean on the banking sector, both in Mexico and the U.S., to flag suspicious transactions.

Shortly after the designations, Sheinbaum appointed a new UIF director. The official, Omar Reyes Colmenares, has gained a strong reputation among Treasury officials, people familiar with the matter said. The president also appointed a new head of Mexico’s national securities commission, which plays a role in

anti-money-laundering enforcement, following the FinCEN blacklists.

Mexico’s anti-money-laundering revamp was partly aimed at ensuring the country stays off FATF’s “gray list,” a designation that has posed harsh economic consequences for countries subject to it.

The body reviews countries’ money-laundering regimes and rates them based on their structure and effectiveness. Countries with poor results land on the so-called gray list and are handed recommendations that, once completed, can get the country delisted. Businesses often shy away from investment in countries on the list, viewing them as higher-risk jurisdictions.

Mexico’s last FATF evaluation, in 2018, found that although Mexico had well-developed laws and institutions for fighting money laundering, the country secured just 103 convictions between 2013 and 2016.

Representatives from the FATF’s 40 members, which include the U.S., are set to review the results of the Mexican review in October. Mexico will have one year to address any deficiencies in the evaluation before FATF weighs a gray listing.

Despite the new laws, fresh leadership and significant pressure from the Treasury and FATF, Mexico might still struggle to increase its enforcement numbers. The new effort could get dragged down because criminal networks often get protection from corrupt officials, said Guadalupe Correa-Cabrera, a political-science professor and corruption researcher at George Mason University. “There isn’t enough strong political will to go beyond what we have, even though the new rules are on paper.”

Max Fillion writes for Dow Jones Risk Journal.

FROM PAGE ONE



U.S. Exit Leaves Iraq In Peril

Continued from Page One
Iranian forces launched more than 600 attacks on U.S. diplomatic and military facilities in Iraq in the first two months of the war, The Wall Street Journal reported.

In a sign of Iraq's instability, the U.S. Embassy in Baghdad now sends frequent security warnings to individual Americans and others. About two a week regard kidnapping by militants. A team from the Journal abruptly left Baghdad this month after Iraqi, U.S. and European officials warned of a security threat that American officials later said was a kidnapping risk by a Shiite militia.

Iran-backed militias have long exercised influence in Iraq. But Tehran has renewed its support since the U.S. initiated its bombing campaign in Iran in February, according to current and former U.S. officials and defense experts.

The flow of small arms, drones and small-diameter, short-range rockets from Iran initially slowed while Tehran focused on fighting the U.S., but ramped up this summer, a U.S. official said. Recent attacks involved longer-range missiles and drones, the official said, hinting at a menacing weapons upgrade.

This month, a drone attack that Saudi Arabia said was launched from Iraq near the border with Iran temporarily closed its East-West oil pipeline—an increasingly vital artery in the months since Iran disrupted shipping in the Strait of Hormuz. Other attacks damaged an U.S. diplomatic and logistics hub at the Baghdad airport.

Zaidi, who never held public office before becoming prime minister in May, has been embraced by the Trump administration as someone they can do business with. He owns a bank, an insurance company and media and construction firms. His bank was banned by the Treasury Department from dollar transactions in 2024 over suspicions it helped finance Iran and its proxies. Zaidi denied knowing about such transactions. Former U.S. officials said they didn't believe he had any personal involvement.

The Trump administration is counting on Zaidi to disarm the militants, which number in the tens of thousands and include paramilitary groups that receive funding or weapons from Iran.

Maj Gen. Saad Maan, a spokesman for the Iraqi military, said some militant factions had handed in their weapons, and others are planning to do so.

Others scoffed at the idea. "These weapons are for our sovereignty, our freedom," said Kazem al-Fartousi, a spokesman for Kata'ib Sayyid Al-

Shuhada, a paramilitary group the U.S. designated as a terrorist organization, funded and armed by Iran.

A forced disarmament by the government "will not happen," he said in an interview in Baghdad. His group and other militias hold top positions in ministries, as well as dozens of seats in Iraq's parliament where they played a role in Zaidi's selection in the negotiations that followed last year's election.

"The government is an outcome we helped produce," he said.

Zaidi and his deputies are now talking about pushing Wednesday's disarmament deadline to next year.

"The Counter-Terrorism Service, through its security and operational roles, is advancing its strategy to control weapons and consolidate them under state authority," said Sabah Al-Nu'man, a spokesperson for the commander in chief of Iraq's armed forces.

The military exit follows an agreement between the Biden administration and the previous Iraqi prime minister to remove American troops by 2026.

The U.S. has made clear to Iraq that it was critical they retain their sovereignty and prevent attacks from within its borders by Iranian-backed militias, a senior U.S. official said. A Pentagon official said the U.S. was ending its official military operation, but it maintained intelligence, surveillance and other capabilities in the region that could be used in Iraq.

Ayatollah postcards

In Baghdad, young professionals sipped iced coffee and typed on laptops in the exclusive Karrada neighborhood on a recent, seemingly peaceful day. Yet many said they plan to leave, worried that insecurity and economic pressures will build without a strong U.S. presence.

"If the troops were to leave, why were they here in the first place? They were here to accomplish a goal. Did they? No," said Mustafa Al-Zaidi, a 22-year-old medical student who plans to eventually work abroad. "Will we be like Afghanistan or like Yemen and Syria?"

In late March, militiamen believed to be affiliated with Kataib Hezbollah, a U.S.-designated terrorist group, kidnapped American freelance journalist Shelly Kittleson, bundling her into a car on a busy street in Baghdad. She was released about a week later, after the group negotiated with the Iraqi government for the release of imprisoned militants, current and former U.S. officials said.

"We are in a state of war launched by the American-Zionist enemy against Islam," said Abu Mujahid al-Assaf, a Kataib Hezbollah official, in a social-media post announcing Kittleson's release. The group, known for roadside bombings and



Clockwise from top left, Rahman Hussein Ahmad; Ayatollah Ali Khamenei poster; U.S. troops in 2008.

sniper attacks against U.S. troops, is among the Iran-backed militias rejecting Zaidi's call for disarmament.

Some residents expressed resentment about Iran's interference at a time when Iraq, the world's fifth-largest oil producer, is showing signs of an economic recovery. In Baghdad, new boutiques and cafes have opened. The government is building the capital's tallest structure, the central bank headquarters, on the banks of the Tigris.

"If something is not in Iraq's interest, we don't want them," said Rahman Hussein Ahmed, a 51-year-old former fighter in a rebel group that opposed both Iran and the U.S. Militia leaders, he said, "are tools of Iranian interests."

Iran's influence is visible in a souvenir stall in Baghdad's old city. Postcards feature the picture of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran's supreme leader who was killed in the U.S.-Israeli attack this year. Another shows Qassem Soleimani, the former commander of Iran's Quds Force killed in a U.S. airstrike in 2020.

At Baghdad's airport, a portrait of Abu Mahdi al-Muhandis, a militia commander killed in the same 2020 strike, awaits visitors outside the arrivals hall. Posters put up around the city center say, "We will make the decision," a jab at the prime minister's militia disarmament initiative.

Before the militias emerged, Iran and Iraq had fought a nearly eight-year war that was estimated to have killed hundreds of thousands and ended



Kazem al-Fartousi, a spokesman for Kata'ib Sayyid al-Shuhada in Baghdad.



CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: MOISES SAMAN/MAGNUM FOR WSJ; TAHER AL-SUDANI/REUTERS; MOISES SAMAN/MAGNUM

in a stalemate in 1988. Fifteen years later, the U.S. invaded Iraq to take down Saddam Hussein, buttressed by Bush administration claims—later proven false—that the Iraqi leader was hiding weapons of mass destruction. Close to 4,500 U.S. troops and as many as 300,000 Iraqis were killed.

In working-class Sadr City, veterans reminisced over tea about shooting down U.S. helicopters in the early days of the 2003 U.S. military occupation.

The chaos that followed the U.S. invasion created an opening for Iran to extend its influence in Iraq, whose population is predominantly Shia, the same branch of Islam followed by most Iranians.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, or IRGC, helped organize armed groups that attacked American troops with the aim of driving the U.S. out of Iraq. The IRGC sent rockets, armor-piercing explosives and other armaments to the Iraq-based militias, and dispatched its officers to train them, declassified U.S. intelligence documents show.

After winding down the initial war, the U.S. withdrew its troops in 2011. Three years later, American troops returned to battle Islamic State, or ISIS, a group of Sunni extremists who spilled into Iraq from Syria. Thousands of U.S. airstrikes helped Iraqi and Syrian forces defeat the militants, and American troops remained in Iraq.

By then, the Iran-backed militias were entrenched. After helping fight ISIS, some militias were absorbed into Iraq's political system, forming political parties that had a

say in the prime minister's selection. Militia members took influential jobs in the education ministry and the tax and customs authority.

Al-Fartousi, spokesman for the Kata'ib Sayyid Al-Shuhada militia, said his organization and other armed groups often act independently of Iran and have grown this year. "The resistance factions have become stronger because they are tackling the most important event in the world, which is the U.S. war with Iran," he said. "The U.S. drove us into this war."

The Pentagon's Inspector General said in a report this year that U.S. support to Iraq in key counterterrorism operations had "slowed to a near halt" because of the Iran war.

‘Go legit’

Zaidi's selection as prime minister was a compromise. Trump warned he would cut off U.S. aid to Iraq when Nouri al-Maliki, a former prime minister close to Iran, was proposed for the job in January.

Zaidi, who dresses in dark blue suits and has a bushy black mustache and cropped beard, was quickly embraced by Washington. Political analysts said he tried to balance competing interests, underscored by his visit to Tehran soon after traveling to Washington this summer.

His disarmament initiative has persuaded some militant groups to cooperate in the hope of having sanctions lifted. Asaib Ahl al-Haq, a U.S.-designated terrorist group, was among those that said they would work with the government.

"They seem to want to go legit," said David Schenker, a former assistant secretary of state for Near Eastern Affairs. "They want to go on vacation in

France with their families."

Even if Zaidi decided to confront the armed militants, he would face long odds. Iraq's underfunded army crumbled when fighting ISIS in 2014. The country's Counter-Terrorism Service, a U.S.-trained force known for battling ISIS, commanded an estimated 14,000 soldiers as of 2024, fewer than the militias.

To think that Zaidi could disarm the militias in a matter of months "was an impossible request," said Victoria Taylor, a former senior State Department official who left government this year after working on Iraq issues.

A U.S. defense official said the military was airlifting equipment and personnel out of Erbil, the last U.S. military base, in time to meet Wednesday's deadline. Some U.S. Marines will remain to protect American diplomatic missions, along with contractors to maintain Iraq's fleet of F-16 jet fighters and American-made tanks, according to current and former U.S. officials.

The military has already removed a Patriot air defense battery stationed around Erbil, current and former U.S. officials said. The U.S. is likely to concentrate its remaining air defenses to protect the U.S. Embassy in Baghdad and the consulate in Erbil, current and former U.S. officials said, despite continuing Iranian and militia strikes.

"These militia groups exist because Iran wants them to exist, and Iran finds continued utility in using them as a tool and a lever against the Iraqi government and the U.S. in the region," said Taylor, the former senior State Department official. "That will continue to be the case after the departure of U.S. troops," she said.

European Car Brands Eye SUVs

Continued from Page One
at data provider J.D. Power.

Detroit dominates the big-SUV category today, including luxury models.

Shares of General Motors—maker of the Cadillac Escalade, by far America's best-selling full-size luxury SUV—have traded at postbankruptcy records since Trump came to office with promises to cut electric-vehicle incentives and emissions regulations.

European automakers, with their share prices trading at multiyear lows, are getting in on some of the action.

Audi's new Q9 is around

209 inches long, approaching the dimensions of the Cadillac Escalade (about 212 inches). While the \$87,700 standard Q9 is powered by a three-liter V6 engine, a special \$118,000 Q9 aimed even more squarely at North America uses a four-liter V8.

"The American buyer in this space will expect the most engine they can get," said Jominy.

Audi, which doesn't have a U.S. factory, is making the Q9 in Slovakia. Vehicle imports from the European Union incur a 15% tariff imposed by Trump. Deliveries start in November.

Details of the new SUVs in the works at Volvo and BMW are scant, but both companies have factories in South Carolina that would make natural homes for their biggest SUVs.

BMW's plant in Spartanburg is running at full tilt. The company is likely to shift production of some of its smaller

X5 SUV to Europe to make space for the new model, according to a person familiar with its planning. Making each region more self-sufficient would also cut tariff costs.

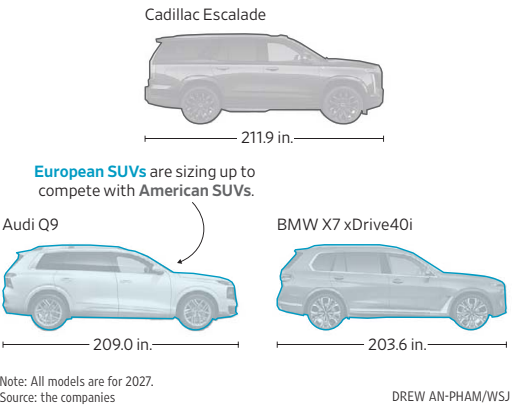
Unlike the BMW plant, Volvo's factory near Charleston has lots of spare capacity that the Swedish company is eager to fill.

"We put a lot of bets on building EVs, which has shown to be giving the factory too little volume. We need to build other cars in the factory," said Samuelsson.

While Europe's luxury brands appear to be targeting the same market as the Cadillac Escalade and Ford's Lincoln Navigator, the new models are expected to have a different feel.

The Cadillac and Navigator adopt the traditional body-on-frame approach also used in pickup trucks, where the cabin is bolted onto a separate chas-

Size comparison of popular SUV models



sis. European carmakers specialize in "unibody" designs, where the body and frame are built as one unit. Unibodies typically perform better on fuel economy and road handling, whereas body-on-frame

models are typically used for off-roading and towing.

The exception could be the Volkswagen brand itself, which is likely to build body-on-frame models such as a pickup truck and big SUV for

the U.S. market, according to people familiar with its planning. The company is currently debating whether to team up with another automaker that already uses body-on-frame designs or work with North American suppliers to build one itself.

The focus on big SUVs is part of a broader strategic shift under way at European carmakers toward a more regional approach.

Luxury brands in particular used to try to sell the same cars globally. Now higher tariffs, local-content rules, diverging emissions standards and different consumer tastes are pushing them to bring out more vehicles tailored to the needs of their biggest markets.

"The Americans and Chinese have increasingly different ideas about what a luxury vehicle is," said Simon Schnur, global head of automotive at consultant Oliver Wyman.

By DALVIN BROWN

When John Bonadeo called Social Security to inquire about collecting his benefits, the representative asked whether he had any children under the age of 18. That question unlocked a gusher of government money that he hadn't known existed.

Bonadeo, a semiretired general contractor who is now 72, and Betty McDonald had six children they had adopted in their 50s. The youngest was 2 years old. Bonadeo's Social Security benefits came with an additional roughly \$600-a-month benefit for his children, he said.

"We were really floored," said McDonald, 69, a retired Secret Service agent who lives in Del Mar, Calif. The family needed the money while all the children were still young, she said.

There are more older parents than ever, and they are learning—sometimes by surprise—about Social Security's dependent benefit. Once a parent or grandparent with a dependent files, a child generally can collect up to half of the full retirement-age benefit until they turn 18, or 19 if they are still in high school. The federal agency doesn't market it widely, but it can alter the calculus about when to draw benefits.

The number of households headed by someone 65 or older with a child under 18 has more than tripled between 2000 and 2024, to about 410,000, census data show. Children collecting on retired workers' records grew by about a quarter over roughly the same span, to 323,000 as of December 2024, though it has fallen in the past few years, according to Social Security data.

Americans can begin collecting Social Security between the age of 62 and 70, but their benefits generally go up the longer they wait to start. In recent years, fewer people have been claiming at age 62.

The dependent benefit complicates this calculus. Parents pursuing the benefit generally collect more months of payments for their children the earlier they collect. Waiting means fewer or no payments before a child ages out, but can mean a bigger monthly check for the parent over the rest of their life.

Deciding when to draw the benefit turns on how long a child has left to collect, how long the parent expects to live, whether a second parent can file instead and when the family's biggest expenses arrive.

Elaine Floyd, a certified financial planner at Horseshmouth, gave the example of a husband and wife, both 62, with an 8-year-old. She assumed full-retirement



Parents Who Have Kids Late Can Get Social Security Boost

Retirees with dependent children are eligible for added benefit, altering strategy on when to file



▲ Dawn Lyons and her daughter.

age benefits of \$3,800 for the husband and \$2,500 for the wife. If both claimed at 62, the child could collect for 10 years, versus two if both parents waited until 70. Both filing immediately would reduce the husband's check to \$2,676 and the wife's to \$1,760. The child would receive \$1,900—

half the husband's full retirement age benefit.

If the husband lives to age 88 and the wife to 91, the model still projects more lifetime benefits if both wait because their retirement checks would be larger. They would get about \$2.78 million over their lifetimes, versus \$2.26 million, a difference of roughly \$520,000.

While children can collect as much as 50% of the parent's benefit, there is a family maximum that caps the total payout, regardless of how many qualifying children they have. It generally runs from 150% to 188% of the parent's full benefit, and the parent's own payment counts first.

Phillip Nieburg, a retired pediatrician and epidemiologist, had children at age 44, 49 and 52. Nieburg, now 82, of Charlottesville, Va., filed between 62 and 63, limiting his check for life so his two youngest could collect. His oldest was eligible, too, but a third child wouldn't have increased the family's total.

The two younger children received just under \$1,000 a month between them. The money went into their two college accounts and reduced the family's borrowing for three tuition bills.

By his calculation, waiting would have given him more money if he lived past 80 or 81, he said.

▲ John Bonadeo and Betty McDonald and their six children.

Nieburg said he would make the same choice again.

"It did provide the money when we needed it," he said.

The longer you live, the more it typically makes sense to wait to collect, said Laurence Kotlikoff, a Boston University economist whose company sells Social Security claiming software. His 2023 study found that, among households headed by workers age 45 to 62, more than 90% would come

out ahead if the workers waited until 70 to claim.

Kotlikoff said couples can stagger their claims. The lower earner can file early to start the child's payments while the higher earner waits, preserving the larger future retirement check. When the higher earner files later, the child moves to that record and the check size rises.

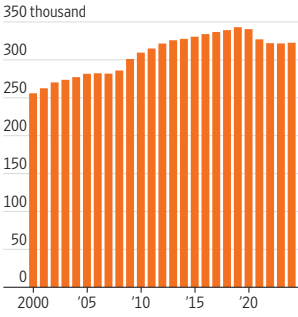
Some parents said they value having the additional money more while their children are still at home, when costs of living tend to be higher anyway.

Dawn Lyons, a federal contractor in New Orleans who turns 60 this month, is leaning toward filing early once she is eligible. She plans to claim in October 2028, when she turns 62 and her daughter, now 16, will be a high-school senior. Lyons expects her daughter could collect for less than a year, but the money could help with college.

Lyons mainly wants to claim before Congress makes any changes to the Social Security program if it moves to bolster the solvency of the fund, which is slated to run out of money in 2032. She theorizes that an overhaul would spare people already receiving benefits. Filing at 62 would permanently reduce her benefit, but she is OK with that.

"I want to live my life," she said. "I don't want to work and die."

Number of children* on retired workers' Social Security records



*Under age 18
Source: Social Security Administration

Thriving at Work Amid AI Upheaval

By CHIP CUTTER

For decades, there has been a predictable formula for success in the white-collar world.

"Knowing more than other people was what made you valuable in knowledge work by definition," says Adam Grant, the bestselling author and organizational psychologist at the University of Pennsylvania's Wharton School.

Artificial intelligence upends that typical career edge. In an era of information overload, the ways in which professionals prove their worth at work will likely cease to be effective, he argues.

"The currency of success is shifting under our feet," says Grant, the author of a coming book, "Vibe: The Secrets of Strong Connections in a Lonely World."

Grant spoke with The Wall Street Journal recently about the challenges of this era, and how people can begin to adapt. This interview has been condensed and edited for clarity.

WSJ: This is a tricky moment for white-collar professionals. What's the issue?

Grant: Great careers used to hinge on ability, and now they depend on agility. The past was basically: Become a subject matter expert, define what you're better at than ev-

erybody else and then that is essentially how you make yourself rare and valuable.

WSJ: And now?

Grant: The expertise you have today may be obsolete tomorrow.

Pre-AI, what was rewarded and valued and promoted was how much information you had in your head; we're now in an environment where information is a commodity. So the differentiating skill set or capability is: Can you recognize patterns? Can you synthesize lots of disparate pieces of information? Can you figure out what perspectives are credible and which ones aren't?

All of that is a long way of saying that human judgment is going to supersede human expertise.

WSJ: This is troubling for people who want to cling to their skills, though, right?

Grant: It is, and that's where you're seeing a fair amount of threat rigidity—as organizational psychologists like to describe it—where people are just trying to figure out, OK, what is the distinct expertise or skill set that I have that's most impenetrable right now?

The problem is that in three months that may look really different.

What I don't think AI will be able



◀ Adam Grant speaking onstage at a 2022 small-businesses event.

of written information. So I actually think that the phone and the voice is an underused technology. I'm going to run a little experiment, and people that I would normally shoot an email to with some ideas, I'm just going to cold call them. I'm not going to schedule a Zoom. But I'm just going to try calling people and bouncing some ideas off of them, and see both if what I learn is different, and also if the bond we form is different. Really simple could be really fruitful.

WSJ: Say you're up for changing, but you've got a manager who seems stuck in the past. How do you navigate that?

Grant: I'd go to the manager and I'd say, "Hey, look, I'm sure you're facing a ton of pressure from above and from below to get a lot done. I've got a few ideas for how we could become more efficient. I'd love to run three of them by you and get your take on whether there's one that you would prioritize if you were in my shoes."

What's really effective about that is, number one, you're speaking to the manager's goals and making it in their interest to do this. The second part is we know from negotiation research when you present people with multiple options, it tends to get them out of an accept or reject mode and into: *Which one do I like better mode.* Instead of looking for reasons to say no to your one idea that you brought, they are now looking for one to say yes to.

to crack anytime soon is the hard work of synthesizing information into a compelling framework that is memorable, that rings true with human experience, that resonates emotionally, that's sticky, that is pithy. Maybe what that means is that

WSJ: What sort of daily habits would you put in place to do well in this new era?

Grant: In an ideal world, we all pick an experiment every week: I'm going

'The expertise you have today may be obsolete tomorrow,' says Adam Grant.

to run a pilot, see how it goes, and then based on what I learn, I'm going to evolve my hypotheses and run another experiment next week.

WSJ: What's an example?

Grant: One is to come in and rotate to a meeting to say, OK, I've got a hypothesis that we're going to get stuck in a rut if we always have the same person running the show, and just by rotating who's in charge, we're going to inevitably hear different things and interact in different ways. That's an experiment worth running.

I've got a hypothesis that people are becoming increasingly skeptical

FROM TOP: BETTY McDONALD; DAWN LYONS

BRIAN STUKES/GETTY IMAGES

PERSONAL JOURNAL.



CARRY ON
DAWN
GILBERTSON

Ready or not, the end of the year is almost in sight. So it's crunch-time if you've got one of those premium credit cards in your wallet, like the **American Express** Platinum or Chase Sapphire Reserve.

Many of the hyped perks, including hotel, airline and restaurant credits, are use it or lose it. With annual fees as high as \$895, it's time to make sure you're getting your money's worth.

Fair warning: it takes time. And math. And you have some catching up to do if you haven't checked in much all year. There's a reason my social-media feeds are filled with ads for apps like Kudos, which helps you track the benefits.

But you can do it yourself. And it's worth it. I recently snagged an \$860 a night hotel room in Rome for \$210 for a stay this month. And I'll get a decadent free breakfast, too.

Here's where to start, based on a review of my remaining Chase Sapphire Reserve and Amex Platinum perks. I stay on top of most throughout the year, but let a couple of big ones go unused until now.

You can do the same with other premium travel cards. You just need to search the benefits and go through them one by one to make sure you're taking advantage. Start with the card's website, which tracks your progress. Reddit forums offer tips and even spreadsheet benefit trackers, and Facebook groups for each card can be helpful, if overwhelming.

My weak spot this year was cashing in on generous hotel benefits.

Chase Sapphire Reserve (\$795 a year) and Amex Platinum (\$895 a year) each offer a credit for luxury

It's Use or Lose It Time For Elite Credit Cards

Perks that turned \$860 hotel stay into \$210 one often expire at year-end



hotels. If you can't fathom forking over hundreds of dollars a night, or more, for a hotel, this is yet another reason the premium cards probably aren't right for you.

There is plenty of fine print on the hotel perks, including minimum nights, a certain dollar amount in each half of the year and booking through the bank travel portal. I am generally not a fan of third-party booking sites and often find prices to be higher.

I managed to find two deals that I couldn't beat elsewhere.

For a two-night work trip to Miami in October, I double dipped on two Chase hotel benefits and

will get more perks when I check in to the Kimpton hotel.

The tab through Chase Travel was \$1,116 including taxes and fees. Chase immediately gave me two \$250 statement credits (you get these twice a year), bringing the total to \$616 for two nights. That was cheaper than the \$890 all-in rate on the hotel's website.

On top of those savings, I'll get a lineup of extras at check in, including daily breakfast for two, a \$100 resort credit and early check in/late check out if available. No one in accounting is going to complain about that.

Just make sure the hotel you're

booking in the Chase portal is part of its high-end Edit collection to collect the statement credits. (I know, more homework!) I thought I was getting the credit for a hotel in Europe this spring but I missed out because I booked too quickly and found out it wasn't eligible. So I still have another \$250 credit to use if the math works out for a coming two-night stay.

Susan Friedland, a retired book editor who lives in New York, made a similar mistake when booking a hotel through the American Express travel portal earlier this year. She thought her Dublin hotel would qualify for one of her twice-

a-year \$300 hotel credits from the Amex Platinum. But it didn't due to the timing of her booking.

Friedland did knock \$300 off her bill at a luxe hotel in Cork this summer thanks to her American Express hotel credit. Combine that with another \$300 statement credit from a coming London hotel stay and she's smartly used up the \$600 annual hotel credit.

Then there's the extras at the participating hotels, including daily breakfast for two and a \$100 credit. She says it all offsets the high card fee.

"I think I'm getting my money's worth," she says.

My big hotel win: an American Express Platinum booking in Rome for a one-night stay with my mom in late October. At \$860 including taxes and fees, this isn't a hotel in my typical budget.

I instantly shaved \$300 off the bill with the twice-a-year \$300 Fine Hotels & Resorts credit. (It only requires a one-night stay unlike Chase's two-night requirement for luxury Edit hotels.) Then I knocked another \$350 off the tab by cashing in 35,000 American Express points.

I typically transfer those to airline loyalty programs for flights because it's a far better value than a statement credit. But I was pleasantly surprised at the value for prepaid hotel bookings through Amex Travel.

Is this a little in the weeds? Yes. Just take this away: I nabbed a nearly \$900 hotel for \$210. And will get free breakfast, a resort credit, late checkout and room upgrade if available.

So take stock of your card benefits now. American Express and Chase have handy sections on their websites that show you the benefits and whether you've maxxed them out.

Beat your fellow fancy cardholders to the finish line for the best booking options. Procrastinators made Dec. 31 one of the busiest booking days for Chase's Edit hotels last year.

We're All Talking Like Bots

Continued from Page One

bots," says the founding partner of a venture capital firm in Stockholm.

Wimmercranz says conversation at the office increasingly sounds like it came straight from Claude or ChatGPT. She finds herself using more punchy phrases and partaking in an un-Swedish practice: giving fawning feedback, such as telling someone they're "brilliant" or "so smart" just like a sycophantic large language model (LLM) would serve up. "In Sweden, the culture would just be quietly listen," she says.

It's not nothing. You're right to push back. I mistakenly repeated a common myth as fact—that's on me. But here's the honest truth: People are spending so much time with AI that they're adopting chatbots' favorite phrases in conversation, Slacks, emails and texts. Some call them LLMisms, others refer to it as "Claude speak."

Will Barnett, head of recruiting for a Bay Area startup, swears he still speaks like a human but finds AI-use is influencing his communications over Slack and email.

"I will catch myself when I'm writing where I'm like, 'Oh my God, I shouldn't have even written that. I should have just let AI do it because it sounds the same,'" he says. "It's trained me to be more like it, instead of the reverse."

Barnett, 42, has taken to editing correspondence he wrote himself to make it sound like less AI, which he notes would be "the exact same workflow if I was actually just using an LLM."

Allie K. Miller, an AI adviser to Fortune 500 companies who lives in New York, says that in a recent group chat with founders, the conversation turned to "cave man speak." It's their name for a hyperdirect and cost-ef-



▲ Sara Wimmercranz says she finds herself using more punchy phrases.

fective prompting style that uses as few words as possible to direct the AI.

"They all shared that their cave man speak was bleeding into their everyday and that they would say things like, 'Why no bullets?'" she says.

Miller says she has a new

One adviser said a conversation with founders turned to 'cave man speak'

appreciation for any piece of writing that predates ChatGPT's launch in November 2022, and for words that an LLM would be unlikely to spit out. "Cacophony," she says wistfully. "Man, I don't think I've ever seen AI write that word."

Because top LLMs respond so well to upfront goal statements, Miller said people will sometimes prompt each other in team meetings.

Daniel Wolkowitz, who works at an AI startup, has started to find it difficult to tell whether a Slack or email message was written by a co-worker using AI, or one who has unwittingly started writing like AI.

What he does know is that

more messages come through with phrases like "it's not this, it's that," "these are the problems," and "this is how it happens."

Deepan Mehta, who runs an AI startup, started keeping the equivalent of a "swear jar" but for "prompt speak," at the office. Instead of a jar there's a white board and every time someone speaks in AI-like language, they get a tally mark.

Words and phrases that will earn you a mark: genuinely, load-bearing, smoking gun, X is the new Y, and any "crazy hyphenated contractions that no one would normally use," says Mehta, 33. If you have the most tally marks at the end of the week? "You pay for happy hour."

David Bohigian of Washington, D.C., who works as a nonprofit CEO, has a theory that much of AI-speak is drawn from the same linguistic style that classically trained business professionals and lawyers have been using for years.

"I had read 500 business books before AI came out," says Bohigian, 56. "And AI has read those same books and 500 more."

For years, Bohigian has been throwing out prompt-like directions such as "think like an analyst" or "let's red team this." These days, he finds more people understand what he's talking about because AI has made the language familiar to a broader group. "Bottom line up front," he says. "BLUF was an acronym back in the day. Now people get it more when you say that."

Angela Nibbs has spent 20 years working in PR trying to get executives to not use corporate speak or jargon. AI is making that even harder.

When Nibbs asks founders why they started their company, instead of sharing a story, they'll launch into three key pillars, the market opportunity and their competitive differentiation. "Everyone sounds polished," she says, "but no one sounds particularly interesting."

The WSJ Daily Crossword | Edited by Mike Shenk

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CLASSICAL SYMMETRY | By Kathleen Diamantakis & Jeff Chen

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► Solve this puzzle online and discuss it at [WSJ.com/Puzzles](https://www.wsj.com/puzzles).

Previous Puzzle's Solution

ASP	POP	BAND	MAA
CPR	FORE	SE	UMM
CLAW	FOOT	TOB	DOI
LETAT		RET	IRE
ANIS	OSCAR	SN	OB
IDNO	LLM	GNAT	
MAGNO	COAT	REES	
	PIE	HAM	
	WATER	RAB	OB
LOOP	GLIE	YMHA	
MOB	BURGERS	LIAM	
MENS	SREA	SATIE	
OLD	ASS	BACKWARD	
NEE	LASALLE	TEA	
YTD	STY	MI	EDY

ARTS IN REVIEW

ART REVIEW

An Exhibition Of Creative Abundance

The Whitney devotes a show to Minnie Evans, immersing us in her lush, enigmatic visions

By LANCE ESPLUND

It is unusual to see a traveling exhibition at two venues—rarer still to find each setting evoking such a different facet of an artist’s sensibility. That was my experience with “The Lost World: The Art of Minnie Evans,” a retrospective of about 100 oil paintings and mixed-media drawings by Evans (1892-1987), a self-taught African-American artist. Though featured in Newsweek in 1969 and given a solo show at the Whitney Museum of American Art in 1975, she remains little known.

Conceived and organized by Katherine Jentleson at Atlanta’s High Museum of Art and first shown there, the survey appears now at the Whitney, where curator Barbara Haskell’s installation is on view through Jan. 10, 2027. Encountering the exhibition in both cities, I felt Evans’s voice shift in register. In Atlanta, her visionary cosmologies read as foreboding, otherworldly—paradise lost. In New York, the same universe of botanical abundance, deities and searching eyes suggests paradise found.

Mystery surrounds the origins of Evans’s enigmatic art. A devout Baptist, Evans, who lived and worked in Wilmington, N.C., began making art in the 1930s, after her grandmother’s death. Over the course of the next half-century, she produced more than 5,000 works in crayon, oil and collage: landscapes and masklike images—amalgams of abstraction, figuration, flora and fauna. Possible precedents flicker: Maya hieroglyphs, Buddhist mandalas, Hiberno-Saxon manuscripts, Bosch, Gauguin, feathered Trinidadian carnival masks. Rarely, however, did Evans disclose her influences. She believed her craft, a gift from the Almighty, emerged from her conversations with God and lifelong

dreamlike visions of Genesis, Revelation and the Great Flood.

Descended, in part, from Africans who had been enslaved in Trinidad, Evans grew up in America’s Jim Crow South. In 1898, as a small girl, she witnessed the Wilmington massacre and coup by white supremacists, during which black people were murdered, properties were burned and many survivors were displaced. Marrying young and working for decades as a domestic—an education in itself—she absorbed art not through formal instruction but through daily intimacy with the objects on the estates of collectors such as Henry Walters (of the Walters Art Museum in Baltimore). From 1948 to 1974, as gatekeeper at Airlie Gardens, Evans inhabited a neo-classical Eden where, locally celebrated, she made and sold her work. In 1962, she was discovered by the photographer and art historian Nina Howell Starr, who launched her career in New York.

At the High, the atmosphere of “The Lost World” was theatrically charged. A mural-scaled reproduc-



tion of “Untitled (Red Lips on Moon)” (1959)—one of Evans’s many deities merging head and nature—greeted visitors like a carnival’s colossal funhouse visage. In the low-lighted galleries, painted black, deep purple and green, Evans’s proliferating eyes flitted between predators and prey. In 1944, just before D-Day—right after she met with a fortuneteller who encouraged her to channel her visions—Evans painted the breakthrough oil “Invasion Picture,” a writhing field embedded with fighter planes, angels, blood and human skulls that approximated the automatism of André Masson. Light-sensitive, “Invasion Picture” was installed in Atlanta behind a burgundy velvet curtain, beside photographs of fortunetellers’ façades.

The Whitney’s presentation—without soothsayers, murals or drapes—is decidedly more neutral. Its skylighted galleries, painted green-tinted white, provide an airy atmosphere. The chronological installation begins with Evans’s first two pen-and-ink drawings from about 1935: abstract radiating eyes, spirals, zigzags and squiggles—feverish doodles resembling ancient pictographic narratives

set down in a trance. Other works, from the 1940s and ’50s, reveal a range of experimentation and approaches. Some suggest the patterned backs of playing cards. Others—depicting grinning clowns, crying women and morphing objects and creatures, including human figures potted like plants—recall children’s drawings and John Tenniel’s illustrations for “Alice’s Adventures in Wonderland.”

“Untitled (Stacked Faces),” from 1943, seemingly combines Russian nesting dolls with a Christian Tree of Jesse. And, like several of these works, “Mosquito Bombs” (1943) blurs the line between childlike and childish. Around 1944, Evans’s clowns transform into her signature symmetrical, archetypal masks and mandalas—totemic images and icons that feel urgent, primeval and alive. “Untitled (Face With Teeth)” (1944)—merging head, fire, feathers and flowers—is bold, heraldic and erotically charged. “Untitled (Many-Eyed Form)” (1945), visceral and flesh-like, flits among face, insect, emblem and hide. She also persistently produced landscapes in oil. “Temple by the Sea” (1955)—haunting, surreal—fuses elements of Henri Rousseau and Giorgio de Chirico. And “Airlie Oak” (1954), a bas relief, reads less as painting or sculpture than as a venerated relic.

Evans’s art is wildly uneven—at times naïve, illustrative, provincial—especially in her literal interpretations of the New Testament. But in the 1960s, she fused her mandala-faces and landscapes into dense, mysterious worlds—relief-like frontal fields in which deities, animals and foliage, woven to-

gether, blossom and interchange between figure and ground. The abstract mixed-media works “Untitled (Visionary Garden Design)” (1960-68), “Untitled (Green Leaf Collage)” (c. 1966) and “Designs, Wrightsville Beach” (1968) impress not as images but as kaleidoscopic, paradisiacal visions.

What these ecstatic works signify—and whether they depict angels or demons, predators or prey, creators or destroyers—remains elusive. Their tropical light and decorative symmetry hold opposites, before and after the Fall, in a kind of suspended equilibrium. Seen in two venues, that balance shifted: The High’s theatrical immersion emphasized Evans’s ominous undercurrents, while the Whitney’s understatement illuminates her generative spirit. Evans’s art didn’t change, but its environments did—proof that curatorial framing shapes perception, and that her universe, like any living cosmology, continues to unfold.

The Lost World: The Art of Minnie Evans
Whitney Museum of American Art, through Jan. 10, 2027

Mr. Esplund, the author of “The Art of Looking: How to Read Modern and Contemporary Art” (Basic/Hachette), writes about art for the Journal.

THE WHITNEY

ART REVIEW

Teresa Margolles Dissects Tragedy at MoMA PS1

By BRIAN P. KELLY

Long Island City, N.Y. **CONCEPTUAL ART** is easy to deride as pretentious and obfuscatory or, on the other end of the spectrum, sophomoric and heavy-handed. So often are these charges true that it can feel shocking when we encounter conceptual work that truly lands, that elevates its subject matter in a way that makes it deeply resonant without preaching. The Mexican sexagenarian Teresa Margolles does just that across a body of work that focuses on violence, femicide, migration and border issues.

Her first large-scale museum exhibition in the U.S., “Teresa Margolles: En el lugar de los hechos (At the Scene),” is not just a paragon of what strong conceptual art can be—it’s also one of the most affecting shows I’ve ever seen. The presentation at MoMA PS1 is a curatorial coup. Organized by Ana Janevski and Inés Katzenstein with Chloë Courtney and Julia Detchon, it is tightly focused, cutting to the very heart of Ms. Margolles’s ideas and her methods without becoming bogged down in the frequently challenging subject matter.

If you could distill that subject matter down to a single item, it would be the scars left by violence—the physical kind, yes, but also the psychic, emotional, economic and spiritual marks left by every sort of brutality. Ms. Margolles witnessed these outcomes first-hand in her earlier career as a forensic technician in Mexico City’s morgue, an experience that infuses her work with

elements of scientific exactitude as well as ritualistic imagery.

The latter is visible in “El agua de la ciudad, Dallas (The Water of the City, Dallas)” (2016), a lengthy video in which Ms. Margolles enlisted the help of volunteers to visit sites of violence around the city and carefully clean the ground where these tragic events occurred. It’s a simple idea, each clip lasting just a minute or two, preceded by information about the victim and where and how the incident took place. But as the people bend down to wash a patch of ground, we are transported to the realm of the holy, bringing to mind Jesus washing his disciples’ feet or St. Veronica mopping the suffering Christ’s brow. We recognize each location, marked by a damp square when the collaborators have finished their task, as a site of great loss—less historic than Gettysburg or the beaches of Normandy, but as tragic as those hallowed grounds in the minds of the families of those slain on these suburban streets and city sidewalks.

The absence felt in these videos is even more profound in “La búsqueda (The Search)” (2014). A trio of glass panels removed from an abandoned building in Ciudad Juárez still bears the missing-persons posters that were hung there years ago. These female faces speak to the epidemic of violence against and abduction of women by gangs who traffic in people as well as drugs, the rumbling sound of a train overwhelming the installation space. Cryptically, one of the panes is emblazoned with the word “inicios,”



which means “beginnings,” underlining the morbid commencement each of these posters represents: of a family having to cope with a loved one being lost; of these women’s unknown fates; of the unanswerable question faced by those who knew them of “what happened to . . .”

Loss is the subject of the show’s centerpiece as well. “La promesa (The Promise)” (2012) considers the mass exodus of residents from Ciudad Juárez as it industrialized following the implementation of the North American Free Trade Agreement. While that process may have been good for the Mexican economy, it was bad for the locals who were faced with real-estate specula-

Installation view of the exhibition, which is the first major museum show in the U.S. for Ms. Margolles, a Mexican conceptual artist and former forensic technician.

tion and drug-related violence as new people moved into the area, just south of the U.S. border. Ms. Margolles purchased a home in the middle of this and demolished it, here reconstructing the rubble into a rectangular minimalist monument that stretches across a large gallery. Throughout the run of the show, performers will slowly chip away at the block, symbolically eroding what is left of the original communities.

Elsewhere the artist turns her eye to the media, which sensationalizes tragedy. Stacks of real tabloids emphasize the link between sex and violence: Each front page features a grisly story with graphic pictures alongside a photo of a sultry woman advertising a different sort of titillation inside the periodical. It is especially notable that, while Ms. Margolles is also interested in sex and violence in her work, the only explicit images in the entire show come from these publications.

Migration is another focus here, and a collection of tiles made from clay collected from the Rio Grande, arranged in a grid on the wall, offers a serial meditation on the variations of the natural landscape—the color, texture and size of each square slightly different from the ones around it—and how its ever-shifting contours reflect the motivations of migrant groups: fleeing war, searching for opportunity, looking for a new start, reuniting with family.

Among professionals in any field, Ms. Margolles is one of the keenest observers of the politics and social climate surrounding the border. That her visually striking commentaries are emotionally arresting makes that accomplishment all the more impressive.

Teresa Margolles: En el lugar de los hechos (At the Scene)
MoMA PS1, through Feb. 8, 2027

Mr. Kelly is the Journal’s associate Arts in Review editor. Follow him on X @bpkelly89 and write to him at brian.kelly@wsj.com.

MoMA PS1

OPINION

A Suggestion for Young Radicals



UNRULY REPUBLIC
By Barton Swaim

Bloomington, Ind. The resurgence of totalizing ideologies among the young has a lot of smart people puzzled. Communism on the left, assorted racist nationalisms on the right. I favor two explanations. First and more obvious: a failed education system. Second, the decadeslong recession of religious belief across the West has produced a generation of young people who long for something more heroic and satisfying than, as they see it, the morally thin lives of their elders.

Aurelian Craiutu, a professor of political science at Indiana University, asks his students, especially the ones inclined to radicalism, to ponder the virtues of moderation. In his book “Why Not Moderation? Letters to Young Radicals,” published in 2023, Mr. Craiutu responds to two fictional zealots, Lauren and Rob, one an intolerant progressive, the other a hard-leaning rightist. His two interlocutors employ arguments, often verbatim and duly cited, that have appeared in periodicals that might fairly be termed immoderate: the Jacobin and In These Times on the left, and American Greatness and the American Mind on the right. Mr. Craiutu makes the case for moderation as a political ideal quite as intellectually and morally satisfying as any all-embracing ideology.

The word “moderate” has a

messy history in American politics. It can either signify policy centrism or, pejoratively, a tendency to follow the consensus. It's also unhelpfully relative: Today's “moderate” Democrats are yesterday's strident liberals who don't want to abolish the police.

“I grew up in Romania, the wrong side of the Iron Curtain,” Mr. Craiutu, 60, tells me in his office in July. “I was 23 when the Berlin Wall fell. That's a good time in life to weigh the importance of ideas, good ones and bad ones.” He came to the U.S. in 1993 as a graduate student and developed a keen appreciation for the American system's ability to steer away from radicalism and remain in the untidy middle.

Moderation in his telling has three components. It seeks the mean between extremes (think of Aristotle's “Nicomachean Ethics”). It builds and fortifies institutions that require political actors to reason, argue and compromise with one another—checks and balances, federalism, bicameralism and so on. And it cultivates a certain style or ethos. “Moderation is not too sure of itself,” he says. “There's an openness to learning from others. There's a skepticism, an acceptance of the fact that you don't know the answers, though you search for them.”

Mr. Craiutu distinguishes moderation from “lukewarm wishy-washiness.” His hero is the French philosopher and journalist Raymond Aron, who “attacked ideas rather than people but expressed his arguments firmly and with conviction.” When Aron's fellow in-

tellectuals, chiefly Jean-Paul Sartre, wanted to ignore or lie about the millions murdered in Soviet Russia, Aron refused to keep silent and wrote about Stalin's crimes with moral clarity. “Aron paid a great price for speaking the truth,” Mr. Craiutu says. “Sartre's disciples savaged him. But his moderation in this way required him to write as he did.”

Aurelian Craiutu recommends an underrated principle: moderation.

Mr. Craiutu contends that the truest sign of moderation is “eclecticism”: the ability to hold views or take attitudes to different parts of life that appear, to those who place a high value on purity, contradictory. He cites the American sociologist Daniel Bell's memorable self-description as “a socialist in economics, a liberal in politics, and a conservative in culture” and the Polish dissident intellectual Leszek Kolakowski's essay “How to Be a Conservative-Liberal-Socialist.”

I express discomfort with his examples—I revere Kolakowski but regard socialism as itself a form of extremism. Mr. Craiutu notes that many people see a grave contradiction between free-market economics and traditionalist views on culture and family. The combination of these stances became known as “fusionism” in the 1960s, so antithetical did some hold them to be. Sympathetic

as I am to the fusionist outlook, I take his point.

Mr. Craiutu's contention about eclecticism aligns with Emerson's famous line (alluded to in “Why Not Moderation?”) that a foolish consistency is the hobgoblin of little minds. “The world is very complex,” Mr. Craiutu says. “There is no privileged access to understanding its direction. You need to look through as many windows as possible. We humans are limited and exhausted and can't comprehend the world in its fullness.”

The hard left, from the French Revolution to the collapse of the Soviet Union, tried to explain life's complexities in terms of class warfare. That effort has resumed. Lately parts of the right have rejected pluralism, deplored the messiness of constitutionalism and posited the desirability of an all-encompassing metaphysics. Many on both sides dabble in antisemitism, another habit of mind that purports to explain the world's complexity.

In a brief note on the origins of his book, Mr. Craiutu mentions scriptwriter and Yiddish scholar Leo Rosten's “A Trumpet for Reason” (1970). In that very funny tract, Rosten addressed young baby boom radicals: leftists who had lost faith in America because of the war in Vietnam and reactionaries who wanted to ban hippies from college campuses. Change some of the nouns and Rosten's book reads as if it were published in the 2020s. A fine reminder that the campaign for sense and moderation isn't new and isn't hopeless.

BOOKSHELF | By Jason Snell

The Genius Of Retail

Shop Different

By Ron Johnson with Zander Nethercutt
Harper Business, 320 pages, \$32

Apple has become one of the world's most valuable companies because of its products: the Mac, the iPad, the Apple Watch and most especially the iPhone. But the company's product sales have been aided over the past 25 years by the presence of its iconic brand in more than 500 retail stores scattered across 27 countries and regions. Anyone who has ducked into an Apple store for a new iPhone or toted a broken Mac through the mall for a repair appointment at the Genius Bar has experienced what Steve Jobs and Ron Johnson built.

In “Shop Different: How Retail Revealed Apple's Genius,” Mr. Johnson details the remarkable story of how, in 1999, Jobs recruited him from Target to join Apple as head of retail and launch perhaps the biggest long shot of Jobs's entire tenure as chief executive. At a time when computer stores were a moribund category and Apple's brand was near its lowest ebb, the two men concocted a daring strategy: find some way to connect with the millions of consumers who had no interest in or understanding of Apple's products.

Mr. Johnson cuts the profile of the perfect retail executive. Born in Minnesota, he was entranced as a child by the Midwestern, midcentury power of Dayton's department store. After Harvard he eschewed an obvious career path into

finance and instead took a job at Mervyn's, a West Coast department-store chain owned by Dayton's parent, Dayton Hudson Corp. (now Target). From there it was on to the Target stores themselves. Mr. Johnson transformed the chain's toy departments by devoting an entire aisle to Lego products.

When Apple hired Mr. Johnson in 2000, he was based in Minnesota and didn't own a computer. (Jobs sent him an iMac.) But Mr. Johnson had retail experience Apple lacked, and Jobs seems to have identified in Mr. Johnson an enthusiasm for the project that matched his own. Apple had only recently avoided bankruptcy. Jobs was persuaded that a retail presence would be vital to the company's comeback.

The CEO was making a gamble, but he and Mr. Johnson realized that to rebuild the company's profile Apple needed to reach the regular people who shopped at places like Target. “Most of our future customers will be introduced to Apple through the store,” Mr. Johnson recounts saying to Jobs. “So, eventually, it will become the most powerful physical expression of the brand.” They agreed to model the store's approach to customers on the Ritz-Carlton hotel chain, rather than a traditional retail outlet, which led to the concierge-like experience of the Genius Bar.

It's hard to imagine now, but in the late 1990s Apple products had little luster. As computers running Microsoft's Windows 95 took over the world, Apple seemed dedicated to selling niche products. Jobs's return to the company in 1997 and the introduction of the iMac (Apple's first hit product in years) started to change perceptions, but Apple needed to reach buyers beyond its loyal base. Mr. Johnson knew where to find those people—in America's shopping malls.

Apple stores struggled until the release of the iPod music player, which made even Windows users curious enough to wander inside.

Jobs brought his trademark product-development focus to Apple's retail stores, joining Mr. Johnson for regular drives to a warehouse in which a secret mock-up of an Apple store would regularly be revised. At one point after most design decisions had been made, Mr. Johnson realized that a forthcoming new product strategy—the “Digital Hub,” which positioned Apple's computers at the center of a constellation of digital cameras, music players and accessories—required a complete rethink of the retail operation. Jobs was furious, until he thought about it—at which point the mercurial CEO changed his opinion. “Ron thinks we've got it all wrong. . . . And you know, he's right,” Mr. Johnson recounts Jobs telling Apple's retail team.

The success of the strategy was hardly a *fait accompli*. Many stores struggled until Jobs's product pipeline came to the rescue. With the introduction of the iPod music player in 2001, Apple had a product that made even Windows users curious enough to wander into an Apple store. Under Mr. Johnson's watch, Apple's retail division became a behemoth operation, selling millions of iPods, iPhones and Macs while opening stores around the world.

For a generation of people, the iPod was the first Apple product they ever bought. Those buyers frequently ended up buying Macs, and the arrival of the iPhone converted even more customers. It's hard to imagine Apple's rise to a trillion-dollar company happening if its products weren't readily available in local retail stores.

Jobs and Mr. Johnson were kindred spirits when it came to strategy, but temperamentally they were a mismatched pair—California tech and Midwestern retail. The book details Mr. Johnson's belief in a Christian view of love and service, which informs his understanding of how to treat customers and co-workers. The cynical and secular Jobs didn't seem to entirely get that. Mr. Johnson recounts upbraiding Jobs at one point after the CEO swore at and insulted his retail team during a meeting; he made his outspoken boss promise never to do it again.

Mr. Johnson doesn't spare himself from questioning one of his worst decisions, which was to leave Apple in 2011 for the struggling retailer JCPenney, a move that even at the time seemed misguided to market observers. The book recounts his temptation (after 12 years at Apple) to lead a company himself, a choice made exponentially more difficult because of Jobs's terminal cancer diagnosis.

But having read “Shop Different,” it's easy to understand why a Midwestern kid who was dazzled by department stores might want to take a chance on one of America's most storied 20th-century retail brands. Maybe he didn't realize at the time that he'd already helped create one of the 21st century's best.

Mr. Snell has written about Apple for 30 years and is the co-host of Designed in California (designed.fm), a podcast about the company's history.

A Blundering 2026 Midterm Campaign

By Karl Rove

The White House midterm strategy—outlined by Trump political chief James Blair in a recent interview with the Free Press—looks good on paper. It has two elements. First, remind voters what President Trump has achieved and wants to do. Second, show voters that Democrats lack a governing vision.

Mr. Blair admits “domestic economic pressure” will be central to the campaign. Still, he believes that in light of the president's achievements and the economy's underlying strength, there won't be “a blue wave at all.” The country is narrowly divided, with “not many voters to move around.” It will be “trench warfare” in battleground contests, but he's confident the president can turn out Republican voters.

Mr. Blair's view is backed by Mr. Trump's pollster John McLaughlin. He told the Free Press that the challenge is “to not let it become a referendum on President Trump” but instead make it “a contrast election.” Still, a successful strategy must be executed properly on all fronts. That's the problem.

Some things we can't evaluate until after Election Day—such as how effectively Team Trump will have wielded its financial advantage. The fundraising totals for GOP groups and MAGA dwarf those of Democratic candidate, party and political-action committees. Whether Republicans will deploy this well and before voter opinions harden is an open question.

Similarly, it appears the GOP's get-out-the-vote operation is well-planned while the Democratic National Committee's is flailing. These activities are hard for outsiders to quantify. Yet whatever mechanical advantages the GOP has could be offset by the raw emotion of Democrats eager to vote against the president.

Messaging is one of the few areas of Team Trump's execution we can judge in real time. The past month it's been awful.

The GOP strategy looks good on paper. What's lacking is competent execution.

Especially given Mr. Trump's poor approval numbers, he has to drive home each day what the GOP has accomplished and will accomplish—and clearly contrast that with what Democrats believe and promise. Instead, we've gotten off-putting confusion.

Start in early September. The big news out of Republicans' first-ever midterm convention: If the GOP won, Mr. Trump would give every adult \$5,000. There was no prior consultation with congressional Republicans, and there were conflicting explanations of how it would be paid for. No choir of supportive voices cheering the idea had been organized. It was crickets.

Then on Sept. 14, Donald Trump Jr. confirmed to the

media that a Russian oligarch paid for his lavish post-wedding celebrations. That's never a good look.

Two days later, the president asserted Iranian leaders “want to make a deal.” Six days after that, he said he might have to “annihilate the Islamic Republic and do it quickly.” This left voters whipsawed.

On Sept. 16, the president said the Kennedy Center would “end up being ripped down” unless the administration received “recognition”—i.e., his name on the building.

Later that week, the president banned CNN, MS NOW and Politico from the White House press room. A judge soon restored access with a temporary restraining order as the outlets' lawsuit against the administration proceeds.

Even as GOP candidates are trying to make radical New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani the Democratic Party's face, the president met with the mayor in what a reporter called a “lovefest.” It's hard to make Mr. Mamdani a pariah—and tarnish Democrats by extension—when Mr. Trump says the self-described socialist has “great potential.”

Then there was last Thursday's lavish White House dinner honoring Xi Jinping. Mr. Trump's praise of the dictator as “truly outstanding, amazing” couldn't hide the summit's lack of substantive achievement.

Now there's controversy over the White House's using government money to run partisan ads as “public service announcements.” (The White

House maintains they are patriotic, not partisan.) With Republicans spending nearly \$1 billion on election ads, adding \$2.5 million in taxpayer dollars isn't going to win votes. It only creates another needless distraction.

Then there's Mr. Trump's Truth Social post early Sept. 20 that he has “agreed to convert” his planned Triumphal Arch at Arlington National Cemetery into “a top grade Military Complex,” complete with “drones, plus Snipers” with “large quantities of sniper ammunition in storage.” Who will snipers be targeting? Commuters on the parkway the arch will overlook?

All these items dominated the news cycle. None advanced the Republican cause. They wasted time that can't be recovered—time that could have been spent explaining how the GOP is fighting inflation, showing how it's stopping fraud and wasteful spending, sharpening contrasts with Democrats on issues swing voters really care about, or making the case that preventing Iran from impeding the flow of oil through the Strait of Hormuz will lower gasoline prices.

Without better application, the White House's campaign theory will come to nothing. A blue wave is forming. The White House has to do better. Starting now.

Mr. Rove was senior adviser and deputy chief of staff for President George W. Bush and is author of “The Triumph of William McKinley” (Simon & Schuster, 2015).

Gross Output Signals an Economic Surge

By Mark Skousen

Last year stagflation was a legitimate concern. Real gross domestic product rose only 2.2%, while business-to-business spending declined in real terms. In the fourth quarter last year, real GDP rose at an annual rate of 0.5%, and B2B spending declined 2.2%, according to my calculations based on Bureau of Economic Analysis and Census Bureau data. The supply chain experienced stagflation. Consumer spending was robust, but there was a mild business recession in 2025.

The economic picture is changing, and we can see it thanks to a little-known but powerful macrostatistic that measures spending at all stages of production. GDP leaves out the all-important supply chain, a leading indicator.

There is a better, broader statistic that tells what's really going on in the economy. Known as gross output, or GO, it measures spending at all stages of production.

Supply-chain economics is big business. Total spending in the U.S. in the intermediate stages of production amounted to about \$35 trillion in 2025, more than GDP (\$31 trillion). Business spending in the supply chain is much bigger and more volatile than final consumption and does a better job of measuring the ups and downs of the business cycle.

Good news: Business activity is quickly changing this year and is exploding upward, at double-digit rates.

It started in the first quarter and now has been confirmed. In the first quarter, the BEA reported a pickup in gross output. On Wednesday it was

revised upward by 0.6% for a real return of 2.3% for the first quarter. Unlike GDP, it includes the value of the supply chain and all B2B spending.

Wednesday's release of second-quarter GO was a blockbuster. GO is suddenly growing faster than GDP, a significant positive trend, and one that suggests real GDP in the third quarter could be explosive.

Second-quarter GO grew 5% in real terms, compared with real GDP growth of only 2.2%.

The difference is in the value of the supply chain. Business to business more than doubled compared with the first quarter and grew 13.8% in the second quarter. This is the fastest growth in business activity since the bureau started measuring the GO statistic in 2005 (excluding the postpandemic rebounds 2021-22).

Moreover, business spend-

ing is growing faster than consumer spending, which grew only 3.8% in the second quarter compared with business increasing at a double-digit rate.

Spending on AI and data centers is undoubtedly behind the explosive growth in business activity, and capital spending by foreign investment in the U.S. might also be contributing.

Most economists focus on GDP when gauging economic outlook. But GO should be viewed as the top line in national income accounting, and GDP as the bottom line. Both metrics are essential to understanding where the economy is headed.

Mr. Skousen holds a chair in free enterprise at Chapman University and is author of “The Making of Modern Economics.”

OPINION

REVIEW & OUTLOOK

The U.S. Economy Is Accelerating

You'd be forgiven for thinking the U.S. is slouching toward recession based on the gloomy headlines. But cheer up—the Commerce Department on Wednesday made an unusually large upward revision in its economic growth estimate for the first half of the year. Might rising yields on the 10-year Treasury reflect accelerating economic growth?

The Commerce Department raised its GDP growth estimate for the first quarter to 2.5% from 2.1%, as well as for the second to 2.2% from 1.5%. These large revisions reflect newly available data as well as updates to annual benchmarks that include refinements in methodology since 2021.

The upward revisions to real GDP growth stem partly from reduced inflation estimates. But the bigger story is that business investment and consumer spending have been stronger than economists thought. Business investment was revised up half a percentage point to 9% thanks to higher spending on intellectual property and structures tied to AI. Commerce says data centers drove the increase, while information processing equipment contributed to stronger consumer spending.

Admissions to spectator amusements also buoyed consumer spending during the second quarter. A World Cup dividend? Regardless, higher gasoline prices don't seem to be restraining consumers. Consumer spending has been growing faster than personal incomes in recent quarters, perhaps in part owing to the wealth effect from a booming stock market. Fidelity recently reported that the number of Americans with more than a \$1 million in the company's 401(k)s surged 19% during the second quarter to a record 769,000.

Americans can thank the AI boom, assisted by the GOP tax bill, for lifting corporate profits and equity prices. Corporate profits in the second quarter rose 20.8% from a year earlier. Even if

some company valuations are stretched, increases in stock prices are broader than a couple of years ago when indexes were driven by the so-called Magnificent Seven.

Net exports subtracted 1.1 percentage points from GDP in the calculation, as AI companies imported more chips and equipment for their data center build-out. But this is a positive for U.S. domestic investment and growth. Imports aren't a sign of economic weakness.

The larger story here is that the economy as a whole looks to be on a stronger footing than during the Biden years when growth was driven by government handouts. Recall how the Biden team boasted that its climate spending was increasing construction and even defended its endless student loan forbearance as propping up consumer spending.

Last year's tax bill phased out green-energy subsidies and made much-needed reforms to food stamps that have reduced enrollment to pre-pandemic levels. The Trump team also made student loan borrowers make payments again. Democrats said this would imperil the economy. Apparently not.

The press has been in a panic over the rising yield on the 10-year Treasury, which has crept up 100 basis points this year to 5.29%. The conventional wisdom is that higher energy prices and expectations of more debt issuance are the culprit, but faster growth and competition for capital are contributing. Estimates for third quarter GDP growth have also been rising as September looks strong.

So if the economy is good, why do Americans feel so glum? The likely answer is the hangover from the Biden inflation, which continues to erode wage gains and make it hard to save. Border taxes and higher gas prices haven't helped. Yet despite the prophecies that the war in Iran would plunge the U.S. into a recession, the evidence is that America's economic animal spirits are alive and well.

Passengers Defeat a Would-Be Hijacker

Twenty-five years after the 9/11 attacks, the legacy of Flight 93 lives on. Israeli passengers and Emirati crew members fought off an apparent hijacking attempt of a flight from Dubai in the United Arab Emirates to Tel Aviv on Wednesday. They landed the commercial jet in Saudi Arabia and saved some 180 lives. Call it the Abraham Accords in action.

Details are still emerging, but the hijacker appears to have been the Omani co-pilot, who stabbed his fellow pilot, Smit Machchhar of India, and took control of the aircraft to drive it into the ground. In 30 seconds the plane fell more than 14,000 feet.

An Israeli passenger, Yaniv Hayun, and a crew member broke into the cockpit, which the wounded Indian pilot may have unlocked before collapsing by the door. Mr. Hayun then put the terrorist in a choke hold and worked with others to throw him out of the cockpit.

With the pilot removed, Mr. Hayun took the controls. "I pulled the yoke backward," he recounted to Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. "You see it on 'Mayday,'" the TV show, Mr. Hayun added by way of explanation. Passengers tied up the terrorist and tended to the wounded pilot. Mr. Hayun and another bloodied Israeli can be seen on video standing guard.

Landed by other pilots on board, the flight was diverted to Saudi Arabia, where the Israelis

were treated. This is new for the Saudis, who still refuse formal relations with Jerusalem and reportedly didn't want an Israeli plane to pick up the passengers. But what the terrorist meant for evil became an opportunity for good.

Though the Omani co-pilot is currently believed to have acted alone, Mohsen Rezaei, Iran's top national security adviser, released a statement after the hijacking to threaten the U.A.E. even more than it already has for having hosted Mr. Netanyahu on Sunday. Also on Wednesday, U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham said there are "strong indications" that Iran aided the recent terror plot against a Royal Air Force base used by U.S. war planes in the United Kingdom.

The Emiratis are unlikely to be intimidated. Flydubai flew to and from Israel through some of the most dangerous periods of the post-Oct. 7, 2023 war, even as U.S. airlines canceled. One way of viewing the hijacking is as an attack on that route and the Abraham Accords behind it. It failed and, other than vigilance, the best response will be more flights, tourism, diplomacy and commerce.

The threat from Islamic terrorism isn't over. But on their way home to Israel at last, survivors of the hijacking could be seen on video breaking into an old Jewish song: "The whole entire world is a very narrow bridge / and the main thing—is to have no fear at all."

The End of the Fed Building Fiasco

How many economists does it take to renovate an office building? The optimal number is zero, to judge from a new report into the fiasco of a Federal Reserve building project. The salient point is that this project fell victim to as much incompetence as you'd expect, and no criminality.

Fed Inspector-General Michael Horowitz on Wednesday released his report into cost overruns on renovations of the Fed's main Eccles building and an office complex across the street. Budgeted for \$1.3 billion, the current cost estimate has ballooned to \$2.4 billion and it's on track to be completed three years behind schedule.

You've heard about this because President Trump tried to exploit the cost overruns and delays to concoct a governance crisis at the Fed. His Justice Department in January issued a criminal subpoena to then-Chairman Jerome Powell concerning allegedly incorrect testimony Mr. Powell had given to Congress about the project. Mr. Trump hoped to push Mr. Powell out of his chairmanship early.

Mr. Horowitz's report finally tells the public what happened, and the IG describes a long and expensive comedy of errors. The renovation on a different Fed building, completed in 2022, had run over budget and past schedule. That prompted an earlier IG examination. The Fed tried to apply those lessons to this project but did so ineptly.

For instance, for the Eccles project the Fed attempted to adopt the recommendation to use a type of construction contract that shifts the risk of cost overruns to the contractor. But officials tried to sign the agreement at a phase in the design process when the contractor couldn't estimate key costs, negating the benefits. Officials also kept changing crucial elements of the design—such as switching to a closed-office from open-

plan—that made the cost a moving target.

Some of the problems are classic Washington. The government always seems surprised by the engineering challenges with building in a malarial swamp, which explains why other recent nearby projects also ran way over budget. Some shortcomings are unique to the Fed, including a governance model

that requires academic macroeconomists on the Board of Governors to oversee a complex construction project. Picture the faculty lounge trying to build a new football stadium.

New Fed Chair Kevin Warsh in his response to the IG report proposes the solution the Fed should have adopted from the start. He's handing the Eccles project to the General Services Administration, the branch of government that has experience, er, mismanaging building projects within normal parameters.

But the key conclusion here concerns the accusations of criminality. "At no point during our evaluation did we find reasonable grounds to believe that a violation of federal criminal law had occurred," Mr. Horowitz writes. "Further, while our report outlines deficiencies in the management of the renovation project . . . we did not identify administrative misconduct during our evaluation."

This is a political opportunity. Mr. Powell has bucked convention to linger on the Fed board past his chairmanship ostensibly to defend the Fed's independence from Mr. Trump. The report now offers reassurance that Mr. Powell is in the legal clear. This clears the path for Mr. Powell to resign in line with tradition and do his part to de-escalate the unhelpful political battles that have ensnared the Fed.

Then the GSA can finish the building, the Fed can worry about monetary policy, and Mr. Trump can talk about the growing economy. Or so we can dream.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

AI's Behavior Will Matter More Than Its Mind

Holman W. Jenkins, Jr. states that "a long fight is brewing over whether AIs are conscious" ("Will the AI Frenzy Add Up to Anything?" Business World, Sept. 26). Much has been debated about when or whether this will happen, but neuroscientists like me and my colleagues can't even truly agree on a definition of what consciousness is.

In the case of AI, this debate is moot. It doesn't matter whether we can define whether AI will become conscious, but behavior is what matters. There is ample evidence that its behavior is almost indistinguishable from that of conscious beings. It won't be long before these programs operate at the same level as a 10-year-old who has mastered the fundamentals of reading and can learn independently from that point forward. At that point it doesn't matter whether AI is conscious or not; it matters what it does.

MATTHEWS W. GWYNN, M.D. FAAN
Atlanta

Peggy Noonan's "Trump Is in Denial About AI's Danger" (Declarations, Sept. 26) and Mr. Jenkins's "Will the AI Frenzy Add Up to Anything?" look

at the same rapidly developing technology and come away with strikingly different conclusions. Ms. Noonan sees an approaching danger requiring urgent action. Mr. Jenkins sees serious risks but warns against confused, hurried responses.

Their disagreement illustrates something missing from much of the current debate: We keep talking about AI as though it were one thing. But there is an enormous difference between increasingly autonomous frontier systems that may act with limited human supervision and the AI tools already being used every day in medicine, science, education and business.

We should take the warnings of Dario Amodei, Sam Altman, Geoffrey Hinton and others seriously without allowing fears about tomorrow's frontier systems to frighten us from responsibly using today's technology.

Perhaps the sensible position lies somewhere between Ms. Noonan's alarm and Mr. Jenkins's restraint: Be cautious about the frontier, but decisive about responsible adoption.

MARK R. GIANNINY
Rochester, N.Y.

How America Should Power the AI Revolution

Regarding Peter Earle's op-ed "AI and the 'Dangers of Electric Lighting' " (Sept. 24): Mr. Earle's comparison of artificial intelligence to the early days of electrification raises an enduring question: How do we manage legitimate risks of new technologies without impeding their promise for prosperity and quality of life?

That question matters today as AI accelerates infrastructure build-out across domestic manufacturing sectors while boosting efficiency and optimization. Yet this progress runs on power—and a lot of it: Data centers could consume as much as 12% of the nation's electricity by 2028, according to the Energy Department, up from 4.4% in 2023.

The answer should be risk-based policies that protect consumer safety and energy system reliability without one-size-fits-all prescriptions that become barriers to innovation. Transparent, consensus-based standards play an equally important role, giving companies common benchmarks while

allowing technologies to evolve and improve.

That is the approach my organization is taking alongside ASHRAE and Pacific Northwest National Laboratory through the AI Data Center Energy Performance Framework, which brings together experts to guide the safe, reliable and efficient expansion of digital infrastructure.

The electroindustry already supports 2.35 million American jobs and contributes more than \$375 billion to the U.S. economy annually. AI offers enormous opportunities for that workforce and the broader economy. But realizing them will require infrastructure and standards capable of keeping pace.

The lesson from electrification isn't to fear transformative technology. It is to manage its risks intelligently while giving innovation room to serve.

DEBRA PHILLIPS
President, CEO
The National Electrical
Manufacturers Association
Arlington, Va.

Stop Funding the College Conformity Machine

Manu Meel is correct that many students are "tired of uncurious orthodoxy" on college campuses ("Who's Afraid of Civility and Dialogue on Campus," op-ed, Sept. 26). I have seen that firsthand while leading discourse programs at Bucknell University and several others. Yet if tomorrow's leaders are going to get the serious and vigorous education they deserve, action is needed from a host of others.

Donors should only entrust their money to administrators and projects that break the depressing collegiate mold. Lawmakers should only entrust the public's money to institutions that prove they're serious about exposing students to unorthodox views and voices. And parents should only trust their children to schools where reasoned disagreement and the search for truth define the campus experience.

AI Risk Is a Human Problem

Regarding "AI Leaders Are Standing on a Liability Landmine" (Heard on the Street, Sept. 23), Palantir CEO Alex Karp's key proposition in a recent CNBC interview was the opposite of nationalizing the risk of loss, namely "the first line of defense is you're liable for your own actions."

Mr. Karp is right that AI developers should remain subject to civil liability for the systems they create, but he doesn't go far enough. Directors of Delaware corporations owe fiduciary duties that include a duty of oversight and can face personal liability when they act in bad faith by consciously disregarding sufficiently serious "red flags" concerning risks to the corporation.

Effective regulation requires technical expertise, much of which resides within or is financially connected to the industry being regulated. Existing fiduciary law offers a partial answer. Personal liability changes the risk-reward calculation, giving directors an incentive to demand credible safety systems. And fiduciary oversight is largely self-executing. It doesn't require government regulators capable of matching the technical expertise of AI labs.

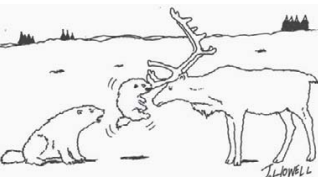
If AI poses the extraordinary risks its developers describe, the solution may be in the boardroom, not Congress.

STUART IRVIN
Washington

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Pepper ... And Salt

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL



"Your wolverine aggressiveness is on point but I think we need to start with smaller prey."

PAUL W. HOFF
Bedford, N.H.

OPINION

Ukraine’s Stealthy Drone Warriors

By Jillian Kay Melchior

The scene resembles the Ukrainian flag: yellow fields of corn, sunflowers and wheat, a crisp blue September sky. We park on the perimeter of a field, in the shade of a row of lindens. “These trees are quite inhabited,” says my guide—call sign Leon—a soldier in a brigade of Ukraine’s Unmanned Systems Forces known as Magyar’s Birds. Under the dense foliage, soldiers on the ground work in what looks like a pumpkin patch. Instead of tending squash, they are rigging 12 fixed-wing drones with 22 pounds of explosives. “Agriculture in Ukraine,” Leon says with a smile.

These drones have a range of up to 250 miles, enough to cover all the Ukrainian territory Russia occupies. Today they’ll fly toward Novozovsk, a district of Donetsk between Mariupol and the Russian border. A Magyar’s Birds reconnaissance team spotted a cluster of expensive enemy vehicles—a “tasty” or “juicy” target, the soldiers say.

Midrange drones have degraded some Russian electronic-warfare systems and hobbled 300 vessels.

Given the risk of Russian reconnaissance, the plan is to “get in, get armed, and get in the air” fast, Leon says. Launching a drone is far less cumbersome than firing a missile. The foliage conceals the drones as they are prepared, and a barn could do the same in the winter. On larger missions involving several dozen drones, the Ukrainians might use several launch sites. The launches are dispersed and inconspicuous—making them harder for the Russians to counter. In the Middle East, the U.S. and Gulf partners are struggling against Iranian drones for similar reasons.

The drones I saw were rigged with explosives powerful enough to pene-



A drone launched by Ukrainian soldiers in the Kharkiv region.

trate 11 inches of steel in a direct hit. The research-and-development department of Magyar’s Birds custom-makes as many as 100,000 warheads a month for short- and midrange strikes and supplies more than a dozen other units, mainly within the Unmanned Systems Forces. Magyar’s Birds assemble more than 50 different models, each calibrated for the specific type of drone and target.

Once the drone is ready, soldiers gingerly place it on the catapult launcher. As propellers whirl during warm-up, one drone’s camera shakes. An engineer tinkers and steadies it so the pilot will have a stable view. But generally the drones arrive mission-ready, partially a result of “continuous feedback” with Ukraine’s arms developers, says the field commander, who goes by the call sign Cousteau. The drone rises, then disappears into the sky. “Two years ago, we needed to have our pilots near us,” and proximity put the pilots at risk, Leon says. Today with an internet connection they can fly from hundreds of miles away.

Leon later updates me on the mission’s results, with footage. Unmanned Systems Forces units get credit for a kill only if they have video proof. The Russians shot down

two midrange drones, and another was lost after communications went down, possibly because of electronic warfare. One more missed its target. But the remaining eight hit their marks. The mission destroyed four Russian military cargo trucks and three fuel trucks and damaged an additional fuel truck.

“We understand logistics is the blood flow of war,” says Maj. Robert “Magyar” Brovdi, commander of Ukraine’s Unmanned Systems Forces. Until now, to cut a logistics artery, you needed to position infantry close enough to hit targets with artillery, lay mines or blow up bridges. “But now,” Maj. Brovdi says, “the question is only the availability of drones and the quantity of drones.”

Such an interdiction campaign is one feature of the Third Army Corps’ Operation Vivaldi, which has thwarted a Russian offensive aimed at encircling the Ukrainian eastern defensive stronghold known as the Fortress Belt. Third Army Corps also says it has recently reclaimed about 68 square miles in the direction of Lyman, a city in the Donetsk region. One example of how midrange strikes helped there: Some of Russia’s electronic warfare systems run on generators, so hammering fuel lo-

gistics helped degrade this enemy capability.

Maj. Brovdi cites other recent successes. Oil and gas revenue pays for Vladimir Putin’s war, and Russia uses its shadow fleet to evade sanctions and smuggle fuel abroad. Since July the Unmanned Systems Forces have targeted these vessels in the Black Sea and the Sea of Azov. Sinking an oil tanker could cause an environmental disaster, but it’s easy to incapacitate the vessel with a drone strike on a crucial area like an engine room. Maj. Brovdi says that as of Sept. 22, his soldiers had turned 300 Russian vessels into “drifting warehouses in the sea . . . incapable of moving by themselves.”

He says his troops are also blockading Crimea “without a foot on the ground” and without any losses from the Unmanned Systems Forces. Attacks on missile launch sites in Crimea have dramatically decreased the number of ballistic and cruise missiles launched from that direction, he says. If it had Starlink access over Russia to go after more mobile missile launchers, Ukraine could further erode the enemy’s ability to hit Kyiv and other cities.

“The aim is to create a systematic effect, not only to disrupt logistics,” Leon says. Ukraine’s midrange strikes on air defenses leave Russian forces at the front more vulnerable. They also open a corridor for Ukraine to conduct aerial attacks deep in Russia while stretching the Kremlin’s air defenses even thinner. The Russians are adjusting to the midrange strikes, in part by moving men and munitions stealthily in civilian vehicles. They also have increased the number of mobile fire groups that try to shoot down Ukrainian drones.

The Unmanned Systems Forces has identified thousands of potential Russian targets, and it has crews ready to take them on. But Ukraine’s most acute problem remains supply. Leon estimates the Unmanned Systems Forces has only 14% of the mid-range drones it needs.

Ms. Melchior is a London-based member of the Journal editorial board.

Getting To Know Kevin Warsh

By Alan S. Blinder

New Federal Reserve chairmen don’t come around often. It’s a major event for markets even if most people ignore it. The term lasts four years, but most chairmen serve longer and there are no term limits. Alan Greenspan was chairman for an astounding 18½ years.

Kevin Warsh has been on the job since May, the 11th Fed chairman since the central bank’s 1935 restructuring. Remember the old song “Getting to Know You”? Markets need to get to know Mr. Warsh better, and Mr. Warsh needs to get to know the markets better. It’s normal but may be more important than usual now because Mr. Warsh says he wants markets to do their own forecasting of Fed decisions with little or no guidance from the central bank. So what have we learned about Mr. Warsh’s leadership? Five things:

First, the new Fed chief handles himself well on television and in public generally. He is personable, well-spoken and telegenic and has abundant people skills.

We’ve learned a lot about him since May. The market needs to learn even more.

Second, those people skills may extend to dealing with Donald Trump. I say “may” because it’s early days. Mr. Warsh has now managed one interest-rate hike without Mr. Trump blowing his top. We know the president craves lower interest rates, not higher ones. But reporting suggests he gave Mr. Warsh the green light rather than see his newly installed chairman outvoted on the Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC). That was sensible, but it might have taken a large dose of those people skills.

Third, and related, Mr. Warsh remained true to his hawkish roots despite Mr. Trump’s hyperdovish views. If you worried that Mr. Warsh would be a sock puppet for the president, you can worry less now.

Fourth, Mr. Warsh made clear he believes in the Fed’s dual mandate of low inflation and high employment. That mandate distinguishes the Fed from many other central banks with an inflation-only mandate. Critics have argued this is a shortcoming of the Federal Reserve Act.

In some early statements, Mr. Warsh sounded as if he might agree. But he made clear, first in his Aug. 28 Jackson Hole speech and then in his Sept. 16 press conference, that he believes in and will be guided by the dual mandate. Hurrah for that.

Fifth, while Mr. Warsh has said repeatedly that he doesn’t want the Fed giving “forward guidance”—indications about its leanings for future policy—he and the FOMC have done exactly that. More likely it’s the nature of forward guidance and its volume that he wants to change.

I was in the audience listening to his talk at Jackson Hole—at a time when the betting on a September rate increase was about 50/50. The speech made a clear and persuasive case for raising interest rates. So clear that on the eve of the September FOMC meeting, markets were pricing in a 92% chance of the 25-basis-point hike that actually occurred.

What Mr. Warsh really doesn’t like, I believe, is something forward guidance normally doesn’t do: locking the central bank into future decisions. The FOMC did that for a while as it tried to help the economy escape the 2008 financial collapse. Several FOMC statements promised not to raise rates for a defined period.

But the Fed wound up abandoning that approach. So even that episode actually illustrates that worries about precommitment are overblown. Forward guidance stating that rates were frozen until date X was used several times, but the dates changed in later rate announcements as circumstances warranted. Monetary policy wasn’t locked in.

Today, the FOMC gives forward guidance—without calling it that—in its quarterly Summary of Economic Projections, which forecasts several key variables, including the federal-funds rate, over several years. These projections change all the time. There is no indication of lock-in and almost no one thinks of those forecasts as commitments. They are more like guesses about the future.

All in all, I come away from Mr. Warsh’s early months in office feeling I’ve gotten to know him better. With midterm elections and more interest-rate hikes on the horizon, markets need to do that, too.

Mr. Blinder is a professor of economics and public affairs at Princeton. He served as vice chairman of the Federal Reserve, 1994-96.

Shareholders Should Pay for AI Dangers

By Gabriel Rauterberg And Sarath Sanga

Dario Amodei of Anthropic has warned that, within a year, swarms of artificial-intelligence agents could take over the internet and do hundreds of billions of dollars in damage. His biggest rivals, Sam Altman and Elon Musk, agreed. Suppose they’re right and the damage is done. Who pays?

Under current law, you do. If a bankrupt company can’t pay its debts, shareholders aren’t liable and the people it harmed have nowhere to go.

This rule is called limited liability. It’s so familiar you might think it’s in the nature of any corporation. But it isn’t. National banks didn’t have limited liability until the rise of deposit insurance in the 1930s. Neither did California corporations of any kind. American Express traded actively without it until 1965. Sole proprietorships and general partnerships have never had it.

Limited liability for torts is a subsidy to today’s shareholders paid for by tomorrow’s tort victims. For AI, that subsidy should end. That means if an AI company faces a mass tort and runs out of money, its shareholders should have to pay.

Limited liability for AI companies isn’t always a problem. For lenders and other contract parties, limited liability is merely a term in a deal. It means that if the company can’t pay, the lenders can’t go after the owners for the rest. A bank that lends to an AI company knows the rule and can price it into the loan. If it wants more protection, it can ask the owners for a personal guarantee.

But tort victims never made a deal. A hospital hacked by rogue AI never chose to do business with the company at all. That’s why limited liability shouldn’t apply to torts.

Most of the time we tolerate limited liability because mass torts are

rare and we don’t know they’re going to happen in advance. Had asbestos manufacturers announced in 1950 that their product might kill hundreds of thousands, no legislature would have said their owners should have limited liability. The heads of frontier labs have said their companies could be responsible for such a mass tort, or worse. They’ve made the case against limited liability.

Companies that say they’re endangering the public shouldn’t get the privilege of limited legal liability.

That case, as we argue in a recent paper, is strongest when a corporation’s profits and the risks it poses rise together, and when those risks are extreme and unbounded. That’s exactly the situation AI executives describe. Customers demand the capabilities that make the product so dangerous. The more successful the product, the more risk likely lands on the public.

Building more-capable models without these risks is the engineering problem that labs say they need more time to solve. Congress isn’t about to solve it. But Congress doesn’t have to. It can establish a liability rule and let incentives do the work.

In the 19th century, locomotives threw off hot embers that set nearby fields and barns ablaze. Lawmakers didn’t engineer a technical solution. They and the courts made the railroads pay for the damage. The railroads responded by fitting spark arresters to their engines and clearing brush along the tracks. Once the incentive to do so was in place, the companies supplied technical fixes.

Shareholder liability can be narrow and still work. It need only ap-

ply to the handful of firms that train frontier models. Passive investors can have their liability capped, so index funds can still hold AI stock and price the risk. Controlling shareholders such as Mr. Amodei and Mark Zuckerberg should pay without a cap, since by their own admission they control the risk.

The predictable objection to such a policy change will be China. For now, America is leading the global race for AI leadership. Anything that slows the home industry, so the argument goes, only helps the other side.

That objection assumes that Washington has so far been hands-off. In reality it’s already up to its elbows. The government decides which chips may be sold to China, which labs get Pentagon contracts, and which labs get blacklisted. Even if the rule did handicap U.S. firms, a powerful Washington lobby would have reason to push for imposing the same terms on Beijing’s AI

Rocky Is Back on Top

By Randy Maniloff

The city of Philadelphia has permanently installed an 8½-foot bronze sculpture of Rocky Balboa outside the Philadelphia Museum of Art. It is about time.

This is an underdog story worthy of Rocky, the boxer portrayed by Sylvester Stallone in the film franchise. The sculpture first appeared in 1982’s “Rocky III,” when the character was world heavyweight champion. Philadelphia paid tribute to its fictional hometown pugilist by placing his image at the top of the 72 steps that he ran up in a memorable scene from the inaugural film in 1976.

Mr. Stallone gave the bronze, by the sculptor A. Thomas Schomberg, to the city. It remained at the museum for a short period. But the museum and the Philadelphia Art Commission wanted Rocky gone. They feared that having a former movie prop close to the museum could damage its reputation. Rocky was exiled to South Philadelphia and installed outside the Spectrum arena, where the 76ers and Flyers played until the 1990s.

In 2006 Rocky returned to the art museum as part of a mayoral effort to revitalize public spaces, but in a much less prominent perch—at the foot of the steps.

Even installing it near the museum proved controversial. Two members of the city’s art commission voted against it. One said it was “not a work of art,” another that it didn’t “raise the standards of the city.”

champions. Washington could make Chinese access to American chips conditional on adopting the same rule.

The U.S. can go on pouring capital into AI research and data-center construction. It can extend cheap loans, tax credits and whatever else it likes, even in exchange for giving up limited liability. But it shouldn’t extend a subsidy that pushes AI risks onto everyone else.

Anthropic is about to go public. Before it does, it could set an example and waive limited liability for torts on its own; state law expressly allows that. Anthropic is already a public-benefit corporation, with a majority of its board appointed by an independent trust. If its chief executive thinks the industry should slow down, this is how he can put his money where his mouth is.

Mr. Rauterberg is a professor at Columbia Law School. Mr. Sanga is a professor at Yale Law School.

SPORTS

By Andrew Beaton

Barely a week after tying the knot with Taylor Swift in July, Kansas City Chiefs tight end Travis Kelce was back at work inside Johnny O's Gymnasium in Florida. The wedding pictures were behind him, but he wasn't finished on his mission to get into the best football shape his 36-year-old body would allow.

"Whatever's going on in his life, he's locked in and he makes time for training," says longtime trainer Andrew Spruill. "But of course, that's always in the back of your head when you get fitted for a tux."

Entering this season, Kelce's 14th in the NFL, Kelce's production had decreased for three consecutive years. And ahead of his 37th birthday next week, any typical aging curve suggested that trend would only accelerate. His trainers, however, could tell something else was coming at the tail end of Kelce's Hall-of-Fame career.

Through three games, Kelce has practically returned to his peak production with 231 yards and two touchdowns. It's no coincidence that the Chiefs, whose 10-year playoff streak ended last season, are off to a 3-0 start and looking like contenders to win the fourth Super Bowl of the Patrick Mahomes era.

Even more surprising than Kelce's numbers is that he's posting them with his signature style. Whereas some players compensate for age with craft and guile, he has simply tapped back into the power and athleticism that made him great in the first place.

In Kelce's heyday, his superpower was reeling in passes from Mahomes and then picking up huge chunks of yards with his legs. While that had fallen off in recent years, Kelce leads the entire NFL with 157 yards after catch this season.

Along the way, Kelce has broken long-time Rams running back Marshall Faulk's all-time record for yards after catch, which has been officially tracked since 1992.

"Everybody questioned [his focus] with the wedding and all that. Would he be out of shape and honeymooning the whole time?" Chiefs coach Andy Reid said recently. "But he works his rear end off."

Speculation that Kelce might retire swirled around after last season's disappointing finish. Mahomes had gone down with injury as Kansas City slumped to a 6-11 record. But his team of trainers had a hunch that he might have another year in him. They knew it for sure once they saw him back in the gym. Kelce was dead set on rediscovering the explosiveness that once made him practically impossible to cover.

157
Yards after catch for Travis Kelce this season

Kelce Got Into Wedding Shape For a Late-Career Honeymoon

Months after marrying Taylor Swift, the Chiefs tight end is playing better than he has in years



Through three games, Travis Kelce has practically returned to his peak production after his wedding to Taylor Swift, below. The Kansas City Chiefs tight end worked with trainer Johnny Olson, below right.

Working with Tony Villani, the founder of XPE Sports, Kelce focused on "game-speed drills" to maximize his pace when he's running actual routes, not just reeling off sprints in shorts. Villani compares it to a race-car driver heading into a corner: taking it too fast will slow the car down because the driver will need to tap the brakes. In order to beat defenders, Kelce needed to optimize his speed for every turn.

Before Kelce even showed up to training camp, his trainers had proof it was working. They measured him at his best levels in four years.

"He doesn't have a body that you would be like, 'Wow, this guy's a specimen,'" said Johnny Olson, the owner of Johnny O's. "But the fact is he is, even though he doesn't have that look."

Instantly, Kelce was playing like his old self. In the Chiefs' opener against the Denver Broncos, he caught a pass five yards



beyond the line of scrimmage and turned it into a 59-yard gain with 54 yards after the catch, his highest in a decade. It was also his longest reception since 2021—before his Taylor Swift era.

The results are also showing up in Kelce's game-speed numbers. According to the NFL's Next Gen Stats, his average route speed this season is 11.68 miles per hour, his



CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: DOUG MURRAY/AP; JOHNNY OLSON; CHARLIE RIEDEL/AP

highest since 2022. Villani has heard people joke about how Kelce suddenly picked up speed after getting married. But he believes it might hide a serious point. Villani noticed that the real work began again last year, when Kelce recommitted after a couple of lighter offseasons. And when he continued with even more dedication this year, it

wasn't hard for Villani to see the connection between the renewed effort and the presence of a certain someone. "We know if you're putting a good woman in your life and cutting out some of the nonsense, you're probably taking care of yourself a little better," Villani says. "Good surroundings create good outcomes."

The Stage Is Set for Historic Sanctions for Manchester City

By Joshua Robinson

AFTER YEARS OF SILENCE on the largest cheating scheme English soccer has ever seen, the Premier League didn't mince words on Tuesday.

In a 40-page decision, the league found Manchester City guilty of orchestrating "sham contracts" over nearly a decade to secretly funnel in money from its Emirati owner and circumvent rules on spending. The scheme, according to the league, obscured the true source of more than \$1.1 billion in funding. Investigators also found that City witnesses gave "evidence at the hearing that they knew to be untrue."

Now, following historic wrongdoing, the stage is set for historic sanctions. Although the league didn't announce a penalty—and Manchester City, which denies any impropriety, plans to launch an appeal that could delay the process for months—the scope of charges suggests unprecedented punishment.

"This disciplinary case, and this decision, are the most significant in Premier League history," Premier League chief executive Richard Masters said.

The most draconian outcome would see the club stripped of several championships and Manchester City expelled from the Premier League. In that scenario, it would be busted down one or more divisions and forced to work its way back up over the course of several seasons. This type of punishment isn't unheard of—even for a European giant.

Two decades ago, Juventus landed at the center of a sweeping match-fixing scandal in Italy

known as *Calciopoli*, which happened to explode in the middle of the 2006 World Cup. By the time national-team stars such as Gianluigi Buffon returned to Juve, the club had been banished to the second tier and stripped of two league titles. (Fiorentina, Lazio, and AC Milan were also relegated.)

Until then, European soccer's most dramatic sentence had come in France, where Olympique Marseille was stripped of its 1992-93 national title, relegated to the second tier, and banned from Euro-

pean competition following the revelation that owner Bernard Tapie had organized bribes for rival players to throw a game.

"I lied," Tapie would say later, "but it was in good faith."

The Premier League has never been quite so bold. No titles have ever been vacated. When it brings down the hammer, the league has historically favored fines and points deductions. In fact, the furthest it has ever gone in disciplinary matters was issuing a 10-point deduction to Everton in 2023 for

breaching spending rules. That was later reduced to six after an appeal and combined with a further 2-point deduction for a separate offense.

But this case is on a completely different scale. In total, the Premier League's independent panel had found Everton guilty of two charges. City was found guilty of more than 50 times as many. The Premier League, which has been widely viewed as a model of good governance in sports, is heading into uncharted waters.

And whatever the penalty, City insists it will not take it quietly.

"Surprisingly for us and for our lawyers, after nearly two years, the Premier League commission has issued an opinion that supports the Premier League's conspiracy theory," City Football Group CEO Ferran Soriano said in a message to staff.

This isn't the first time that the club and its legal team have dug in for a fight. As far back as 2018, the German newspaper *Der Spiegel* published a leaked email from a City lawyer explaining that club chairman Khaldoon Al Mubarak "would rather spend 30 million on the 50 best lawyers in the world to sue them for the next 10 years" when faced with allegations of financial impropriety by UEFA, European soccer's governing body.

Two years later, UEFA again took a close look at City's books and found the club in breach of spending rules and guilty of inflating sponsorship values. Though City was initially banned from the Champions League for two seasons, it won an appeal at the Court of Arbitration for Sport by arguing that the statute of limitations had run out on the allegations.

That combativity is precisely why the league's panel was so fastidious in building the case against City. It called on roughly witnesses and accumulated more than 7,000 pages of evidence.

"The proceedings were at all times extremely hard fought on both sides," the panel wrote in its decision. "We in no way mean that as a criticism of either party; it is simply fact. No stone was left unturned."



Manchester City has denied any impropriety and plans to launch an appeal that could delay the process.

IAN WALTON/AP

Walgreens Owner Nears U.K. Sale

Deal with Weston family for Boots would be valued at \$9 billion, with debt

By CARA LOMBARDO AND BEN DUMMETT

Walgreens' private-equity owner is nearing a deal to sell U.K. pharmacy chain Boots for close to \$9 billion including debt, according to people familiar with the matter.

It has been discussing a deal to sell Boots to the Canadian arm of the Weston family, which owns a food-business empire, the people said. A deal could be completed in the coming weeks, assuming talks don't fall apart.

Sycamore Partners took Walgreens private in 2025 in a deal valued at \$24 billion including debt (and roughly \$10 billion without).

It separated the company into five units to facilitate potential sales of noncore units,

including Boots, which houses the former international businesses of Walgreens. That includes Boots operations in the U.K. and businesses in Thailand, Mexico, Germany and China.

The Weston family is a Canadian-British food-business clan that traces its roots to a bakery business founded in Toronto in 1882.

The family's Canadian contingent oversees an empire that includes Loblaw, Canada's largest food retailer and the

operator of Shoppers Drug Mart, one of the country's biggest pharmacy chains.

Walgreens was in the midst of a turnaround effort when Sycamore bought it. Its market value had dropped more than 90% from its roughly \$100 billion peak in 2015.

Selling Boots at the price being discussed would be an early win for Sycamore, which is poised to make a sizable return on the sale.

It would also allow the firm to focus on reviving Wal-

green's U.S. operations. The pharmacy chain has roughly 8,000 stores across all 50 states and Puerto Rico, according to its website.

Sycamore, which is based in New York, oversees assets of about \$14 billion and largely focuses on buying retail-related businesses.

Its holdings include Staples, an office-supply retailer, and KnitWell Group, which oversees Talbots, Soma and Ann Taylor, among other fashion brands.

Selloff in Treasurys Sends Yield To Highest Since 2002

By SAM GOLDFARB

The bond market keeps turning back the clock.

Relentless selling pressure pushed the yield on the 10-year U.S. Treasury note above 5.3% Wednesday—blowing past its 2007 peak to reach its highest level since 2002, according to Tradedeweb.

The milestone is particularly notable because it hints that U.S. borrowing conditions haven't just returned to a pre-2008-2009 financial crisis normalcy, as some investors have recently suggested. Instead, something even bigger might be afoot.

When Treasury yields last were this high, the U.S. economy was in an entirely different era. The dot-com stock bubble had largely deflated, but investors still had memories of the robust economic growth and consistently high interest rates of the 1990s—and even the sky-high inflation of the early 1980s.

As yields fell in subsequent years, many economists concluded the world had entered a new epoch of tepid inflation and permanently low interest rates. Those views were challenged by the Covid inflation surge earlier this decade. But they have now been completely cast aside, replaced by new forecasts of an extended period of elevated borrowing costs.

Bonds could be volatile in the near term, but “the trend in yields is upward,” said Bleirina Uruçi, chief U.S. economist at T. Rowe Price. “There are many factors driving yields higher that are structural, and those factors are here to stay.”

Though unexpected events such as Covid and wars have helped drive yields to current levels, investors and economists also point to more durable forces as well. Those include a growing tide of government debt testing the limits of investor demand, the artificial-intelligence investment boom that is powering economic growth, and rising trade barriers that are pushing up inflation.

Investors and economists care about the 10-year Treasury yield because it plays a critical role in setting borrowing costs across the country. As the yield has climbed in recent months, so too has the cost of getting a mortgage for

DoorDash To Boost Deliveries Of Shoes, Clothing

By SARAH NASSAUER

DoorDash is betting big that Americans want more than dinner delivered.

A dress from Anthropologie. A North Face puffer vest. Face cream from **Macy's**.

On Wednesday, the app known for delivering meals from pizza to lo mein said it was adding more clothing, shoes and other items to its lineup. Its new partners include Timberland and Vans, in addition to Anthropologie, Macy's and the North Face.

The deals add to a string of new partnerships in recent months for DoorDash, Uber and other delivery apps, intensifying the competition among the companies—and with Amazon.com and Walmart—to satisfy Americans' growing hunger to get their purchases right away.

“Five- to seven-day shipping might have been acceptable five years ago. That is not the case today,” said Fuad Hannon, DoorDash's vice president of new verticals.

Consumers' expectations were set by firms like Amazon and Walmart that have offered faster and faster delivery in recent years.

Fast, often free shipping is “now the floor—not the ceiling—for every category of retail,” said Marc Iampieri, a leader of logistics and transportation at AlixPartners, a consulting firm.

Retailers risk the loyalty of their shoppers when they don't meet such expectations, he said. To satisfy the demand, many department stores and



China is Nike's second-largest market but it has moved from being its fastest-growing region to one of its worst.

Nike Lifer Tackles China Retooling

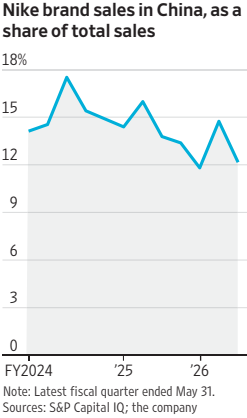
By JON EMONT

Cathy Sparks' first job at **Nike** was selling sneakers in one of its Oregon stores. Thirty years later, she has a tougher assignment: Convincing China's millions of sneaker fans that they should give the company a second chance.

It is a daunting challenge for a Nike lifer who became head of its China business this spring—one that carries outsized importance for a sports giant that is struggling globally.

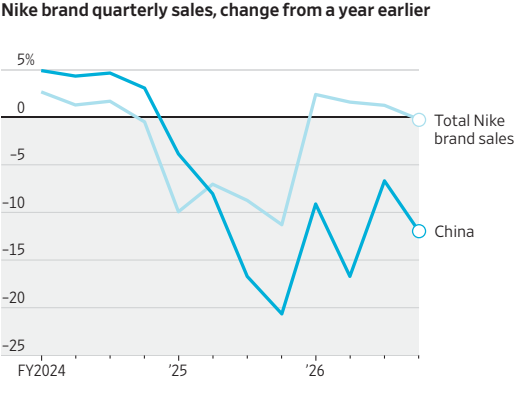
China is Nike's second-largest market. But over the last five years, it has moved from being its fastest-growing region to one of its worst as Nike failed to capitalize on a sporting boom that has boosted rivals such as On and Hoka. Nike's revenue in China and Taiwan is down nearly 30% from its peak five years ago.

“Being a large multinational Western brand in the China



marketplace no longer is enough to win,” Sparks said in an interview.

In six months, Sparks, who reports to Chief Executive Elliott Hill, has decided to end most online stores run by retail partners to boost the brand's



premium cachet and is rapidly rolling out new made-for-China lines. She has visited nearly a dozen cities to understand how Nike can seize on China's booming sporting scene, popping into gyms, where sweaty workouts such as Hyrox are in, and

watching local pickup basketball games.

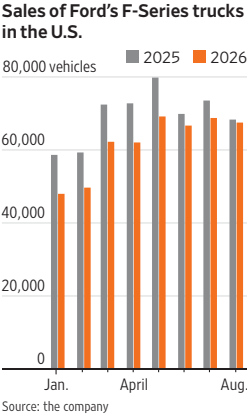
In China, the number of marathon runners has doubled over the decade. Pickleball and padel courts are popping up. Young people congregate for early-

Ford Faults Supplier For F-150's Sales Drop

By RYAN FELTON

Ford Motor's profitable F-150 took a hit this quarter because of a supplier issue that took production offline in recent weeks at a key truck assembly plant, the automaker's chief executive said Wednesday.

Ford's latest supplier issue temporarily halted production at a Michigan plant that makes the F-150 for about one week.



“It is impacting our third quarter wholesale, but I'm very optimistic,” Ford CEO Jim Farley told reporters on the sidelines of a company event in Detroit. The automaker sent a supply-chain team to quickly solve the problem, and fourth-quarter production shouldn't be affected, Farley said. “We're on track,” Farley said.

A Ford spokesman said the latest issue involved a shortage of components.

The drop-off marks the latest challenge for Ford to recover sales of the F-150 over the past year following a series of fires at an aluminum supplier that had rocked the company's truck production for over a year. Ford's overall U.S. sales through August were down 10%. Sales of Ford's F-Series trucks, which include the F-150 and heavy-duty pickups, are down 11%.

Ford took about \$800 million in costs related to the issue with the supplier, Novelis, through the first half of 2025, Ford told analysts in July. The aluminum plant restarted production in June.



BUSINESS NEWS

Cereal maker General Mills picks its operating chief to be the CEO. **B3**



TECHNOLOGY

The chief of Logitech spells out how she plans to beat the chip shortage. **B4**

Condé Nast CEO Steps Down, Will Join Toy Company Mattel

By ALEXANDRA BRUELL

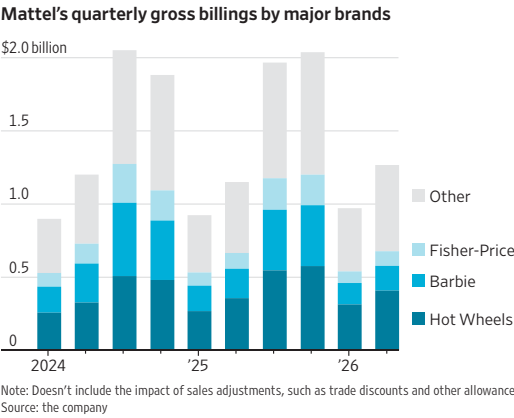
Condé Nast Chief Executive Roger Lynch is stepping down after more than seven years to become CEO of toy company **Mattel**.

Lynch succeeds Chairman and CEO Ynon Kreiz, who will depart Mattel on Oct. 2 to become co-CEO of the combined **Paramount**-Warner Bros. Discovery once the \$81 billion deal closes.

Mike Perlis, the former CEO of Forbes and Ziff-Davis Publishing, as well as Condé Nast's lead independent board member, will become Condé Nast's interim CEO while the board searches for a new executive, the company said Wednesday.

Steven Newhouse, co-president of Condé Nast parent company **Advance Publications**, said Lynch called him on Monday to share news of his planned departure. “It was an unpleasant surprise,” said Newhouse, who said Lynch helped steer the company through a number of challenges.

“The board hasn't really had a chance to do anything other than to thank Roger and wish him well and implement a



long-planned emergency succession with Mike Perlis, who, quite frankly, was always in the wings.”

Mattel, the maker of Barbie dolls and Hot Wheels cars, has spent years trying to transform into a toy and entertainment company. During Lynch's time at the helm, Condé Nast, which owns Vogue, the New Yorker and Vanity Fair, faced disruption in a fast-changing industry.

Artificial intelligence is

transforming the way people seek and consume information, hurting web traffic to many publishers, and social-media platforms such as TikTok have diverted audiences' attention and diluted the influence of magazines that once set the cultural agenda.

Advertising, once the bedrock of the magazine business,

◆ **Mattel CEO named Paramount co-CEO..... B2**

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BUSINESS & FINANCE

Kreiz Named Paramount Co-CEO

By JOE FLINT

Mattel Chief Executive Ynon Kreiz has been tapped to become co-CEO of the combined **Paramount-Warner Bros. Discovery** once the \$81 billion deal closes—as David Ellison continues to set plans in motion for his growing media and entertainment empire.

In his new role, Kreiz will be heavily involved in the day-to-day management as well as strategic planning and the integration of the combined businesses. Ellison will remain chairman and CEO, and Kreiz will join the board. They will oversee the combined company's businesses, which will report jointly to both men, Paramount said.

Kreiz said he and Ellison are “looking to build what will become a cohesive, global entertainment platform.”

A federal judge on Wednesday approved the settlement Paramount reached last week with 12 state attorneys general who had sought to block the Warner merger on antitrust grounds, clearing one of the final obstacles to completing the deal. The deal is expected to



Ynon Kreiz has been Mattel's chief executive since 2018.

close Oct. 6, Paramount said.

Warner CEO David Zaslav was meeting with Ellison to discuss the integration of the companies when word came that the judge had signed off, Ellison said.

The hiring of Kreiz reflects Ellison's willingness to look beyond the existing ranks of Paramount and Warner as he builds the leadership team for the combined company.

It also adds a veteran chief executive with experience overseeing a large public company to what will be a sprawling entertainment empire. The combination of Paramount and Warner would place two legacy movie and television studios, two subscription streaming services, CNN, Food Network, MTV, CBS and HBO under one corporate umbrella.

Gerry Cardinale, founder and managing partner of Paramount's co-controlling share-

holder **RedBird Capital Partners**, said that “historic” leaders “know when to bring in the right partner to make it last—and that’s what David has done.”

Tapping Kreiz is the second major executive move Ellison has made in recent days in advance of the Warner deal's anticipated closing. Casey Bloys, content chief at Warner-owned HBO and HBO Max, is expected to oversee the combined company's streaming operations, people familiar with the matter said. On Tuesday, Paramount's top streaming executive, Cindy Holland, resigned, making way for Bloys. Ellison is expected to unveil the combined company's organizational structure in the coming days, including leadership teams for the movie and television studios—and potentially CNN and CBS News, people familiar with the matter said.

Condé Nast Top Officer Joins Mattel

Continued from page B1

has faced significant pressure across the industry.

“We navigated a pandemic, enormous disruption across

our industry, and a media landscape that seemed to change beneath our feet every year,” Lynch said in a note to staff announcing his departure.

Lynch, a board member at Mattel since 2018, will remain on the Condé Nast board.

Even as Mattel signaled its ambitions to become a more influential player in the entertainment and live-experience space—where the toy industry is increasingly finding its profits—most of Mattel's revenues

has still been coming from toy sales.

Competitor Hasbro, for example, now derives a major source of growth from its “Wizards of the Coast” franchise, a suite of role-playing digital games and trading cards. As birthrates fall, adults are increasingly a target demographic for toy companies, as the concept of play is recalibrated.

Mattel has been under pressure from investors, notably

Southeastern Asset Management, which manages a 4% stake on behalf of clients, to take in private-equity investment or sell itself to a competitor or a media company.

“The most logical strategic buyer of Mattel is likely another ‘toy’ company,” Southeastern wrote to Kreiz in May. “We put ‘toy’ in quotes as the industry has a broad spectrum, and Mattel itself is not and should not be focused only on selling physical items.”

Ford Sales Of F-150 Decline

Continued from page B1

Ford has said it expects to build an additional 150,000 trucks this year over 2025's reduced volume to make up for sales lost from the aluminum plant shortage. Ford needs to have F-Series production output of at least 95,000 a month through the end of the year to hit that target, Barclays analysts said in a note Wednesday.

Ford's steep drop-off in sales in 2026 is expected to result in South Korean automaker **Hyundai Motor** unseating it as the No. 3 car company in the U.S. by sales, according to estimates from industry research firm Cox Automotive. The F-Series production challenges and a move to discontinue the mass-market Escape SUV contributed to the company's decline, said Charlie Chesbrough, Cox's senior economist.



The drop marks the latest challenge for Ford to recover sales of the F-150 following a series of fires at an aluminum supplier.

Nike Looks For China Turnaround

Continued from page B1

morning yoga sessions in **Lululemon** shops. Beyond training, hip Chinese people wear tennis skirts and high-end running sneakers as fashion statements.

The challenge is making them excited about wearing Nike. Yiqi Feng, a 27-year-old from Zhejiang province, used to love the brand for its association with sports icons such as Kobe Bryant and Michael Jordan, but now he says the brand's quality isn't as good as Chinese rivals. “Plenty of domestic brands now offer superior technology at a fraction of the cost,” he said.

To understand the perspectives of customers like Feng, Sparks has attended focus groups where Chinese consumers are quizzed about which sports they play, where they play them and what they do when they get home.

“We're going to test and learn,” Sparks said. Understanding the Chinese consumer “will get us to the right formula.”

A risky move

Sparks faces a fiercely competitive landscape. Local competitors boast they can produce new models at twice the speed Nike does. Anta, Nike's chief Chinese competitor, owns a swath of brands for the China market such as Fila and ski-brand Descente, and is offering consumers a range of stylish sporting looks. Chinese sportswear giant Li-Ning is releasing new sneakers quickly.

Sparks is fighting back by

trying to restore Nike's premium feel. In her previous job, where she ran the company's Asia-Pacific and Latin America businesses, she worked to clean up bloated inventory and improve the experience of buying online.

Now, Nike will largely stop selling products online through third-party vendors in China, including local retail giant Topsports. Sparks says third-party vendors have created a fragmented online sales experience, and that she is trying to reduce heavy discounting.

On Topsports' store on a popular online retailer, discounted Nike basketball sneakers sell for under \$50. That is at least half the price of newer models sold on Nike's own site on the same platform.

It was a risky decision. A large share of Nike sales in China—estimated in the high teens—come from online third-party wholesalers.

While some analysts lauded Sparks' move, others said it would hit revenue and cede market share to rivals like **Adidas**, which continues to sell via Topsports. Instead of paying full price, many customers will “switch to another brand within their price-range,” analysts at Bernstein wrote in July, saying it could delay a return to revenue growth in China.

In June, Nike said average retail discounts in China were down but that revenue was expected to continue declining over the year.

Brian Fenn, who worked at Nike for eight years until 2024, including a stint as director of product in Shanghai, said that it could take two to five years to come up with a new product when he was at Nike—too slow in China's fiercely competitive market. He said Sparks' strong connection to Nike's leadership in the U.S. will help give her the resources to speed up product development.

efforts have sometimes flopped. Nike's Zoom Court Dragon, a basketball shoe with a dragon's scale pattern released in 2022, was criticized for its \$130 price tag and relying on the tired dragon motif to connect with Chinese customers.

Sparks says she wants a new approach, appointing a first-ever head of local product creation for China at the vice-president level, who will report to her. The team, which is doubling in size, will bring Nike sportswear lifestyle lines to market in October, just six months after planning began. The collection will play on young Chinese people's interest in blending traditional and modern motifs. Sparks says the new line will at first be sold exclusively at bricks-and-mortar stores to create an in-store experience that will drive foot traffic.

The company also plans to focus on fast-growing activities such as hiking, racket sports and Hyrox. The Nike Hybrid RN, a shoe designed with both stability and speed for the running and lifting required in Hyrox training, came out this month, two weeks earlier than other markets.

Local creations

Nike was the pinnacle of cool in China in the 2000s, when the brand was known for outfitting top National Basketball Association stars such as LeBron James and Kobe Bryant. Today, with many more entertainment options on offer in China, the NBA is less of a cultural force.

Meanwhile, the quality of local brands has improved, making it hard for foreign companies to persuade Chinese consumers to pay up. Anta basketball shoes can sell for \$50 or less, and Chinese online reviews often say they offer superior quality.

To break through, Sparks wants more locally designed products that speak to Chinese culture and fashion. Past such

DoorDash To Deliver More Clothes

Continued from page B1

specialty-apparel retailers seeking to boost sales are finding partners to deliver their goods.

“Hopefully, I'm going to reach a broader audience and a different customer base,” said Max Magni, chief customer and digital officer at Macy's.

Under its deal with DoorDash, the retailer will offer two-hour delivery from about 360 stores this fall. Macy's has around 430 locations.

Macy's, which had subtly offered DoorDash delivery within its own website and app for a few years, now will make its products available for purchase within DoorDash directly and make fast delivery a more prominent option on its own website, Magni said.

San Francisco-based DoorDash had for years mostly marketed itself as a restaurant-delivery service, competing with rivals such as Grubhub and Uber. Retailers weren't sure whether customers would gravitate to their products such as clothes or hardware supplies through the app, DoorDash's Hannon said.

Now more shoppers crave delivery within hours and are willing to pay extra for the speed. About 13% of 1,000 U.S. adults surveyed last year by Al-iPartners said they wouldn't pay extra for same-day shipping, down from 30% the year before.

Earlier this year, DoorDash announced deals with Barnes & Noble, Gap and Kohl's. As of June, it sold around 30 million products directly, up from around nine million at the same time last year, a company spokeswoman said.

Uber has rolled out several partnerships with retailers this year. Wholesale retailer **Costco** said this month that it would offer fast delivery through DoorDash and Uber across the U.S., adding to an existing delivery deal with Instacart.

Younger shoppers are “still visiting the clubs regularly but use these as fill-in shops,” Costco CEO Ron Vachris said on a recent earnings call.



DoorDash expands deliveries beyond restaurant food.



Revenue in China has steadily declined over the last two years. A Nike store in Shanghai.

BUSINESS NEWS

General Mills Gets New CEO

Current COO Dana McNabb to helm the company, expected to help cut costs

By Jesse Newman
and Colin KellaHer

Cereal giant **General Mills** is replacing its chief executive as it works to turn around its business following a tough spell for America’s packaged food companies.

The company tapped Chief Operating Officer Dana McNabb to succeed Jeff Harmening after his nearly decade-long run as CEO.

General Mills said McNabb, who joined the Minneapolis company in 1999 and was named chief operating officer earlier this year, will become CEO on Jan. 1.

McNabb said in an interview she will focus on reviving sales and carrying out a companywide effort to cut costs, including by modernizing General Mills’ supply chain.

“If you understand consum-



COO Dana McNabb, who will become CEO effective Jan. 1, said she will focus on reviving sales and a cost-cut effort.

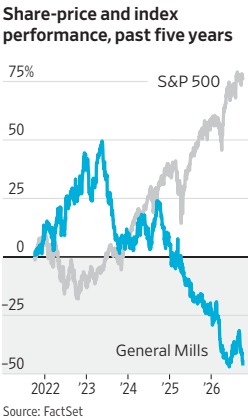
ers well, there is growth to get,” she said. “I feel confident that we know how to do it.”

As a result of better marketing, General Mills has recently seen growth in brands that McNabb said many people had written off, such as Lucky Charms and Cinnamon Toast Crunch.

The Cheerios and Pillsbury dough maker is working to woo customers with new and

improved products more in line with what today’s consumers want to eat. Last year, General Mills cut prices across roughly two-thirds of its North America grocery products in a bid to win over budget-conscious consumers.

General Mills said that its efforts are bearing fruit, though many consumers remain stressed and the company has more work to do. The



company’s stock has fallen 44% in the past five years.

McNabb, who was raised on a grain farm in Manitoba, Canada, joined General Mills at age 23 as an associate marketing manager in the company’s fruit-snacks business. She went on to roles in the U.K., Australia, and Switzerland, before taking over General Mills’ North American retail business in 2024.

Volkswagen’s Union Warns on Wage Plans

By Dominic Chopping

A German union warned of a potential conflict with **Volkswagen** after the car-maker said Wednesday that it plans to terminate a number of wage agreements.

The group, which houses a vast stable of brands that includes VW, Audi and Porsche, has been working on a broad cost-cutting plan throughout 2025 and 2026 following an agreement with its powerful unions that included 50,000 job cuts in Germany by 2030 and billions of euros a year in cost savings.

But the German automaker recently conceded the agreed plan wouldn’t be enough, warning that it needed to do more in its fight against mounting industry headwinds to remain competitive.

A fresh deal with unions agreed earlier this month will see a further 50,000 jobs go, on top of a halving of its model lineup.

In a statement Wednesday,

the IG Metall union said it met with Volkswagen management to discuss progress of the original cost-cutting plan, a meeting that Volkswagen used to announce its intention to terminate several wage agreements at the end of the year, according to the union.

“The board is now conflating two separate issues: the negotiations concerning the contractual commitments from 2024 and demands for the current round of collective bargaining for 2026/2027, which is only just beginning,” IG Metall said.

Volkswagen said it is giving formal notice to terminate several collective agreements, effective Dec. 31, as it needs to adjust some of the terms, given “enormous pressure on prices and significantly intensified competition.”

“We will not accept this,” IG Metall chief negotiator Thorsten Groger said. “Anyone who wants to pick the pockets of the employees must expect a corresponding confrontation.”

BMW to Employ AI to Boost Efficiency, Trim Workforce

By Dominic Chopping

BMW will use artificial intelligence to become more efficient, with the new technology expected to help the group do more with fewer employees as it readies for increasingly challenging market conditions.

AI will become a key driver as part of plans to save costs and accelerate development, with the automaker planning to further integrate the technology across the group to aid vehicle development, material purchasing, sales and marketing, and aftersales.

Outlining its strategy at an investor event Wednesday, the company said that through the efficient use of artificial

intelligence the group will become more agile and effective, which will call for fewer management layers and a reorganization of business divisions.

The number of divisions and management roles will be cut by 20% over the coming months to streamline the structure, with “a comparable reduction at the organizational levels below,” it said.

Executives had already reached agreements with labor representatives in July for an extensive workforce restructuring that could affect up to 8,000 white-collar workers in Germany, a person familiar with the matter previously told The Wall Street Journal. BMW’s global workforce was just under 155,000

at the end of 2025.

“We are improving our structures and cost base so we can meet the increasingly fierce competition that will define this industry in the coming years,” Chief Executive Milan Nedeljkovic said in a statement from Wednesday’s event. “The workforce restructuring program is an important lever for this.”

German automakers are doubling down on efforts to slash costs as pressure in the key China region intensifies with fierce competition and a shrinking market, while elevated energy costs and the Trump administration’s tariff regime are also hitting their bottom lines.

The company said it must

significantly increase speed and efficiency across the group, as it works toward getting its automotive earnings before interest and taxes margin to within 8% and 10% by the start of the next decade.

The margin landed at 5.3% in 2025, and BMW expects no improvement in the interim, targeting between 3% and 5% in 2028.

Other plans presented Wednesday include a new focus on its most profitable models for individual markets while building more vehicles tailored to the European, U.S. and Chinese markets. The number of model variants will also be streamlined to boost profitability.

In China, the company ex-

pects to ramp up domestic production of cars designed for local consumers, while imports will be limited to higher margin models and it will mull exporting more China-made cars to Southeast Asian markets.

The U.S. could see a new top-end sports activity vehicle built specifically for consumers there, as the vehicles—which combine the space of a traditional sport-utility vehicle with sporty handling and performance—have proved popular, it added.

BMW’s Spartanburg plant in South Carolina produces its X3, X5, X6, X7, and XM sports activity vehicles and coupes, most of which are for export, and the company said the ve-

hicles global success means the plant is running at full capacity. It is now looking at expanding production of the models in other markets.

Elsewhere, Europe will see new compact models built on its Neue Klasse platform—the new base for its future generation of tech-heavy cars with increased software capabilities.

“Under increasingly challenging conditions, we have defined measures to reposition ourselves and will implement them with strong momentum,” Nedeljkovic added.

BMW said a large number of additional measures are currently being evaluated, with decisions expected by spring 2027.

BUSINESS WATCH



Some 40 plaintiffs had accused holding company Porsche of manipulating capital markets.

PORSCHE
Court Dismisses \$6.1 Billion Lawsuit

Porsche Automobil Holding SE said a German court has dismissed appeals from hedge funds seeking damages of around 5.4 billion euros, or \$6.12 billion, plus interest from the company’s failed takeover bid for Volkswagen

in 2008.

Around 40 plaintiffs, mostly U.S. hedge funds, had claimed that holding company Porsche SE manipulated the capital markets by not accurately disclosing its true intentions during a gradual build-up of its stake in Volkswagen.

Porsche SE tried to take over the much-larger Volkswagen but ultimately failed.

On Wednesday, the German Federal Court dismissed the plaintiffs’ appeal against an earlier ruling by the Higher Regional Court of Celle that had rejected their claims, the holding company said. The decision is final and it is now established that the plaintiffs have no claim to damages, it added.

—Dominic Chopping

CONAGRA
Food Maker’s Sales Slip, Profit Rises

Conagra Brands said steps it has taken to expand profitability are starting to pay off, as the company logged a higher fiscal first-quarter profit despite lower sales.

The food manufacturer, which owns Orville Redenbacher’s popcorn and Slim Jim meat sticks, on Wednesday posted a profit of \$174.3 million, or 36 cents a share, compared with \$164.5 million, or 34 cents a share, a year earlier.

Stripping out certain one-time items, earnings came in at 41 cents a share. Analysts polled by FactSet expected adjusted earnings of 28 cents a share.

Net sales slipped 1.4% to \$2.6 billion, roughly in line with Wall Street estimates. On an organic basis, sales were down 1.1%.



MADISON SQUARE GARDEN
Knicks, Rangers Businesses Split

Madison Square Garden Sports’ board has approved splitting the New York Knicks and New York Rangers businesses into two independent companies.

The company will change its name to MSG Knickerbockers Corp., which will span both the reigning NBA champion New York Knicks and the Westchester Knicks.

A new independent company, called MSG Rangers Corp., will include the New York Rangers, Hartford Wolf pack and MSG Training Center. James Dolan will serve as executive chairman and chief executive of both companies. The transaction is intended to be a tax-free distribution for shareholders, the company said.

—Elias Schisgall

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TECHNOLOGY & FINANCE

Logitech Aims to Beat Chip Crunch

CEO Faber talks about 'begging and borrowing' her way through the squeeze

By CHIP CUTTER

Logitech Chief Executive Hanneke Faber has zipped around the world for months, visiting suppliers on a quest for a critical component in her company's keyboards, mice and gaming equipment. "I've spent my summer begging, borrowing and stealing chips," Faber said, then clarified: "I don't want to say steal. Begging and borrowing!" The chip shortage persisting across the economy isn't likely to let up in the near term, she said. Only a handful of companies make memory and storage chips right now, much of which is fueling the artificial-intelligence boom. That is squeezing consumer-tech companies like Logitech. Faber spoke with The Wall Street Journal about how she is managing the challenge, while also finding some upside in the disruption. This interview has been condensed and edited for clarity.

WSJ: What does navigating the chip shortage look like for you?
FABER: Traveling in Asia and finding chips—and in Switzerland, actually, where some of our chip suppliers are, too. It's a real thing: This AI is eating my chips. Almost every single one of our products depends on some sort of chip. So that's been a challenge.

WSJ: How long does this last?
FABER: I don't have a crystal ball, but I don't see it getting a lot better for another 12 to 18 months.

WSJ: How do you think about setting prices for your products, and whether people will pay more?
FABER: We launch about 40 new products a year and that is our main way to grow the average consumer price because new products we introduce at a premium price—they have premium performance, otherwise I wouldn't be launching them. Like the newest gaming mouse, the Superstrike.

WSJ: How much does that cost?
FABER: That's \$180, while your average gaming mouse is



Hanneke Faber

probably about \$60. So that's a massive premium, but for a massively better performance. It broke the clicking-speed Guinness World Record.

WSJ: That's a thing?
FABER: Oh, totally.

WSJ: If the conflict in the Middle East continues, will you need to change anything?
FABER: We've made some changes in our supply chain with the Strait of Hormuz being closed, where we take products from, how we move them around.

WSJ: What's an example?
FABER: Our biggest distribution center for Europe, the Middle East and Africa actually is in Dubai. We've changed that and now our distribution centers in Holland and even in China serve part of those regions because it just is not very practical at the moment to have that go through Dubai.

WSJ: In the AI era, more people are using their voice rather than typing. Does that change how you build products?
FABER: So we actually love that; that is a real change. Well, actually on a personal level, I don't love it. My husband's a big voice user. So annoying, but anyway...

WSJ: He's using voice to text all day long?
FABER: Nightmare! [Laughs.] But it is an additional modality for work and that's a good thing. I think of Logitech as kind of the eyes, the ears and the hands of AI. We watch coders: And, yes, they're coding with microphones, they're coding with headsets, they're speaking to their code. But, because they want to go so fast, some are using gaming pedals to code

now with voice. So that was new, but hey, we're the market leader in that, too.

WSJ: You spent much of your career at Procter & Gamble, and later you were at Unilever. What do those companies do to get close to consumers that you've brought to Logitech?
FABER: Sometimes I'm, like, "Oh, three years ago I was selling ice cream at Unilever." It is different, but there's also a lot of similarities. In the end, you've got to be really close to your consumer, your user. At Procter & Gamble, you're very used to doing in-home visits. So you go to India and you go look at how people wash their hair. It's always fun. That was not something we were doing at Logitech. So that's been kind of an eye-opener to people. I like going into people's homes and seeing how they work or how they're gaming.

WSJ: Do people know the CEO is in their house, watching them game?
FABER: [Laughs.] No. But wherever I travel, I do that with the team and you notice things.

Apple Pay Service Launches In India

By JIAHUI HUANG

Apple has launched its mobile payment services in India, entering one of the world's fastest-growing markets for cashless transactions. Users in India can now use Apple Pay on iPhones, iPads and Apple Watches via a partnership with **Axis Bank**, one of the largest private-sector lenders in the country. Customers with Axis Bank-issued **Visa** and **Mastercard** credit cards can add them to Apple Pay to make purchases at stores and online, Apple said Wednesday. The move positions the tech giant to tap the millions of consumers in India that are increasingly using noncash payments.

According to the India Brand Equity Foundation, the South Asian economy's consumer market is set to grow by 46% by 2030, driven by rising incomes, a young workforce and rapid urbanization. Consumer spending is estimated to reach \$4.3 trillion by the end of the decade, up from \$2.4 trillion in 2024. A growing segment of that expanding consumer class is using cashless payment methods, a trend fueled by the establishment of the Unified Payments Interface—the backbone of India's digital payments ecosystem. As of 2025, UPI accounted for nearly 49% percent of the world's real-time payment transaction volume, officials have said. Apple said its payment services will be accepted by millions of merchants across the country including at Apple Store locations, **Reliance** brands and Zomato. Support for payments on Apple's Mac computers will come soon. "India is home to a dynamic and digitally savvy population that continues to embrace a cashless future," said Jennifer Bailey, vice president of Apple Pay and Apple Wallet.

Amex Corporate Card Adds AI, Expense Tracking

By KATHERINE HAMILTON

American Express is rolling out an expense-management platform with AI features alongside its new corporate card, as the company's corporate business faces mounting competition from fintechs. The new corporate cashback card is Amex's first to be integrated with expense-management software. The platform, powered by a new dedicated mobile app, will eventually deploy AI agents to automate some routine expense management and accounts payable workflows. "Amex Corporate is a fundamentally different way that we are allowing middle-market companies to manage their expenses with greater control and greater transparency," said Raymond Joabar, group president

of global commercial services at Amex. Expense-management fintechs such as Ramp and Brex are creating more competition for card companies that have historically led the corporate finance industry. Ramp, which provides bookkeeping and AI finance tools to businesses, announced a funding round this spring that valued it at \$44 billion. The corporate card and expense-management provider Brex was acquired by Capital One Finance for \$5.15 billion in April. Amex, meanwhile, has taken a measured approach to beefing up its corporate business. In April 2025, it acquired a smaller expense-management software platform called Center. This year, it bought Hyper, a platform backed by **OpenAI** co-founder Sam Altman that uses

AI agents to autonomously execute expense-management tasks. As fintechs offer more modern spend-management services, Amex's corporate business has become a top priority for growth initiatives. "I need to see that this business receives probably a lot more attention than it has ever received in its entire life at American Express," Chief Financial Officer Christophe Le Caillec said during a conference earlier this month. The expense-management software coming out alongside the new card is designed to allow finance teams to tailor spending policies for different employees or departments. The software also automatically captures spending data across cards to help close the books faster. There also will be a new ex-

pense mobile app that automatically generates spending reports based on purchases, so employees don't have to create the reports manually. The app also can review expenses against company policy and flag anything that doesn't align. The services are meant to give more control to employers who want to track how much and where money is being spent. For employees, the new services will provide more clarity on company policies and how much they are allowed to spend on various items. The platform is geared toward middle-market businesses that make between \$10 million and \$300 million in annual revenue, Joabar said. The new services will all be available on one platform, with plans for more AI features and accounts payable offerings to roll out in the

weeks and months after this initial launch. Amex first started its efforts to integrate its corporate card with an expense-management platform back in April 2025, when it acquired Center. Amex has been working to integrate Center ever since, and Wednesday's launch is the culmination of that work, Joabar said. "There's a whole pipeline of software that will continue to build out our business membership," Joabar said. Later this year, the company intends to introduce new AI agents that can message employees with recommendations about their expenses. Employees also can ask the agent about expense policies, submission deadlines and other questions. Finance teams can ask the agent about company spending and ask for spend-data analysis.

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COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

NOTICE OF PUBLIC SALE OF COLLATERAL

PLEASE TAKE NOTICE that 100% of the limited liability membership interests in KPG-IMW Owner, LLC, a Delaware limited liability company ("Mortgage Borrower") and KPG-P 100 IMW SUB 1, LLC and KPG-P 100 IMW SUB 2, LLC, each a Delaware limited liability company (collectively, "**Mezzanine Borrowers**") (collectively, the "**Membership Interests**"), will be offered for sale at a public auction and sold to the highest "qualified bidder" on December 1, 2026, at 3:00 p.m. (New York Time). The sale will be conducted through both via Zoom Meeting: Meeting link: <https://bit.ly/IndependentPlazaUCC> (URL is case sensitive) Meeting ID: 821 7804 8331 Passcode:799818 One Tap Mobile: +16469313860, 82178048331, "799818" US +16465588656, 821 78048331, "799818" US (New York) Dial by your location: +1-646-931-3860 (US) and in person at the offices of Alston & Bird LLP, 90 Park Avenue, 15th Floor, New York, New York 10016.

The principal asset of the Mortgage Borrower is the office building located at 100 S. Independence Mall West, Philadelphia, PA 19106 (the "**Property**").

This sale is held to enforce the rights of DOF VI REIT Holdings, LLC, a Delaware limited liability company as secured party (together with its successors and assigns, collectively "**Lender**") under (i) that certain Mezzanine Loan Agreement dated as of September 28, 2018 (the "**Loan Agreement**") and between Mezzanine Borrowers and Lender and that certain Mezzanine Promissory Note dated as of September 28, 2018 (the "**Note**") made by Mezzanine Borrowers to Lender and secured by, inter alia, (ii) that certain Pledge and Security Agreement (Interests in Mortgage Borrower) dated as of September 28, 2018 by Mezzanine Borrowers in favor of Lender (the "**Mortgage Pledge**") pursuant to which Mezzanine Borrowers pledged and granted to Lender a first priority security interest in Mezzanine Borrowers' limited liability company membership interests in **Mortgage Borrower** and (iii) that certain Pledge and Security Agreement (Interests in Mezzanine Borrower) dated as of September 28, 2018 by KPG-P 100 IMW Holdings, LLC, a Pennsylvania limited liability company ("**Pledgor**") in favor of Lender (together with the Mortgage Pledge, collectively, the "**Pledges**") pursuant to which Pledgor pledged and granted to Lender a first priority security interest in Pledgor's limited liability company membership interests in Mezzanine Borrowers.

The Membership Interests are being sold "AS IS, WHERE IS", with all faults, and Lender makes no guarantee representation, or warranty including without limitation any representation or warranty of merchantability or fitness for use (express or implied), of any kind or nature whatsoever. The sale of the Membership Interests will be subject to all applicable third party consents and regulatory approvals, if any, as well as the terms and conditions of sale prepared by the Lender (the "Terms of Sale"). Without limitation to the foregoing, please take notice that there are specific requirements for any potential successful bidder in connection with obtaining information and bidding on the Interests, including, but not limited to, execution of a confidentiality agreement.

Lender will be permitted to bid at the sale, and notwithstanding any requirement herein that the sale of the Membership Interests be for cash, Lender may credit bid all or any portion of the outstanding balance of the amounts due under the Loan Agreement. Lender reserves the right, in its sole and absolute discretion (for any reason or no reason), to (a) reject all bids and terminate the sale or adjourn the sale to such other date and time as the Lender may deem proper, by announcement at the place and on the date of such sale, and any subsequent adjournment thereof, without further publication, and (b) impose any other commercially reasonable conditions upon the sale of the Membership Interests as Lender may deem proper in its sole and absolute discretion.

Interested parties who would like additional information regarding the Mortgage Borrower, the Mezzanine Borrowers, Property, or the Terms of Sale (including the requirements to be a "qualified bidder") should execute the confidentiality agreement which can be reviewed at the website <https://tinyurl.com/UCC100Indep> (case sensitive). For questions and inquiries, please contact Stephen Schwalb at Stephen.Schwalb@nmrk.com.

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COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE

NOTICE OF SALE OF REAL PROPERTY - QUEENS

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
EASTERN DISTRICT OF NEW YORK.

GOLDEN BRIDGE LLC d/b/a GOLDEN BRIDGE FUNDING LLC, Plaintiff against 150-30 12 AVE REALTY LLC and ANDY WEIHAN HO, et al Defendant(s). Pursuant to that certain Amended Judgment of Foreclosure and Sale entered hereinto and dated September 2, 2026 (the "Judgment"), I, the undersigned Referee will sell at public auction outside the main entrance of the property located at 150-30 12th Avenue, Whitestone, New York, on October 29, 2026 at 12:00 p.m. that certain premises situate, lying and being in the Borough and County of Queens, City and State of New York, bounded and described as follows: BEGINNING at a point on the southerly side of 12th Avenue, distant 267 feet 6 inches easterly from the corner formed by the intersection of the southerly side of 12th Avenue with the easterly side of 150th Street; being a plot 150 feet by 42 feet 6 inches by 150 feet by 42 feet 6 inches.

Said premises to be auctioned is known as and located at 150-30 12TH AVENUE, WHITESTONE, NEW YORK.

The approximate amount of the lien is \$3,344,200.00 plus default interest & costs. Premises will be sold subject to provisions of filed Judgment and forthcoming terms of sale, which will be made available to all interested bidders.

All interested bidders must appear at the aforementioned location, date, and time with certified funds made payable to the undersigned Referee as follows, "ANTHONY W. VAUGHN, JR., AS REFEREE." Ten percent (10%) of the successful bid is due at the time of the auction. The undersigned Referee may allow any other manner of funds in his absolute discretion.

Federal Case No.: 23-cv-09045 (NCM) (PK) ANTHONY W. VAUGHN JR., ESQ., Referee Zeichner, Eilman, & Krause, LLP Attorney(s) for Plaintiff 730 Third Avenue, New York, New York 10017

THE MARKETPLACE

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Grindr, its ad featured on a sign in Times Square, is expanding into the healthcare business.

Grindr to Buy HIV-Prevention Telehealth Provider Freddie

By ELIAS SCHISGALL

Grindr agreed to acquire the HIV-prevention telehealth provider Freddie for \$250 million, the company's first major acquisition as it expands into the healthcare business. The cash-and-stock deal reflects Chief Executive George Arison's ambitions to transform Grindr from a dating and hookup app into a broader platform for the gay community that also provides health and wellness, travel, and luxury experiences. Grindr's expansion into a gay superapp had been seen as a theoretical vision before the acquisition, Arison said in an interview. "With Freddie, now this is much more real," he said. Grindr will buy Freddie's parent company, PurposeMed, for \$190 million in cash and \$60 million worth of stock. PurposeMed might also receive up to an additional \$70 million in cash tied to 2027 performance targets. The deal

is expected to close in the fourth quarter. Arison said the acquisition would help sell drugs like PrEP, a prophylactic drug to ward off HIV, at little to no cost to gay men on Grindr's platform who aren't already taking the drug. "This is the logical next step, where we can deeply integrate the Grindr product experience with getting a medication that is lifesaving, and that a lot more people should be on than are on today," Arison said. "That number should be in the millions." Freddie started in Canada in 2020 before expanding to the U.S. in 2024. Grindr's priority will be scaling Freddie's presence in the U.S., with the company projecting an annual revenue opportunity of around \$240 million based on a U.S. patient base of 50,000. Freddie could capture four times that many U.S. patients based on the company's current market share in Canada, Grindr said.

Grindr expects the deal to immediately add to earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization, but that it might initially dilute combined Ebitda margins as the company invests in scaling Freddie's U.S. operations. Ultimately, Grindr expects margins to improve and become similar to the more-than-40% margins of its core business. The acquisition will build on Grindr's first major play in the healthcare space. Last year, Grindr launched a telehealth business called Woodwork that provides drugs including GLP-1s and erectile-dysfunction treatments. Woodwork and Freddie will be merged into a single Grindr Health user experience, Arison said, though he added that the company was still figuring out branding details. "Grindr Health is going to be an area of the business that we're going to focus a lot more on, in addition to our normal subscriptions and advertising," Arison said.

BUSINESS NEWS

Nidec Books \$4 Billion Impairment

By KOSAKU NARIOKA

Nidec swung to a heavy annual net loss due to a \$4 billion impairment in its auto-parts division and other businesses, providing the first detailed view of the fallout from an accounting scandal that still failed to earn a nod from its auditor.

The results came a day after Nidec replaced its chief executive with its technology head, seeking new leadership to steer the company's future and revitalization. Nidec earlier this month also disclosed an independent investigation report that identified a series of issues such as falsification and fabrication of testing and inspection results.

The Japanese maker of electric motors and other equipment on Wednesday said it booked a net loss of ¥564.62 billion, equivalent to \$3.59 billion, for the year ended March, compared with net profit of ¥84.67 billion the previous fiscal year.

The company booked a ¥632 billion impairment loss in its latest fiscal year, citing a deterioration in its electric-vehicle motor business and excessive competition for mo-



The assembly line at a Nidec plant in Serbia.

tors used in household appliances in China, among other reasons.

Nidec's auditor, PwC Japan, declined to state its views on the financial statements. It said some of the officers and employees involved with previously disclosed irregular accounting still hold positions of responsibility in the financial reporting process.

The Japanese company in

March published a report from a third-party committee that said billionaire founder Shigenobu Nagamori pressured executives to achieve unrealistic earnings targets, ultimately leading to improper accounting. Nagamori stepped down as board chairman in December and as chairman emeritus in February.

The committee said many business units attempted to

meet their performance targets by early recognition of sales, avoiding inventory valuation losses and impairment of fixed assets, changing asset valuation methods and capitalizing costs.

On Tuesday, the company said Chief Technology Officer Michio Kaida would succeed Chief Executive Mitsuya Kishida.

Nidec said Kishida tendered his resignation after a review found that he had, on certain occasions, "made statements or engaged in conduct in relation to financial reporting that could not necessarily be regarded as appropriate."

The company faces a potential delisting. The Tokyo Stock Exchange placed Nidec's stock on special alert in October last year and said the company needed to improve internal controls or risk being delisted.

Nidec, led by its founder, expanded its businesses over the years through a number of acquisitions. The company makes a variety of motors used in everything from hard disk drives to electric vehicles. It also produces machine tools, inspection devices and cooling equipment used in data centers.

Audax Raises Third Direct-Lending Fund

By ISAAC TAYLOR

Audax Private Debt has \$10 billion to deploy for its latest direct-lending strategy, the firm's largest pool of capital in its nearly three-decade history.

Audax Direct Lending Solutions Fund III lends to private-equity-owned middle-market companies, which the firm defines as businesses with \$15 million to \$75 million in annual earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization.

The \$10 billion in total investible capital comprises \$5.4 billion in investor commitments, plus targeted leverage and separately managed accounts, said Kevin Magid, Audax's chief executive.

The fund is roughly twice the size of its predecessor, which closed in 2022 on \$3 billion in investor commitments and totaled over \$5 billion including leverage.

Audax collected capital from more than 100 institutional investors globally, including pension funds, sovereign-wealth funds, insurance companies and family offices.

The firm marketed the fund for 21 months.

The first two funds in this strategy provided double-digit returns, which ultimately led to a strong fundraising process, Magid said.

Audax plans for the fund to have a four-year investment period. It has already deployed \$1.5 billion of the new capital, targeting sectors including distribution, industrial manufacturing, business services and pharmaceuticals.

The firm aims to avoid what it calls high-incidence-of-loss sectors such as restaurants, retail, energy and travel. The check size ranges from \$75 million to \$350 million.

Audax Private Debt's portfolio includes Alcresta Therapeutics, a medical device manufacturer. It also has backed A1 Garage Door Service.

Since its inception in 2000, Audax Private Debt has invested \$56 billion across more than 1,350 transactions and provided financing to over 300 private-equity sponsors.

Isaac Taylor writes for WSJ Pro Private Equity.

Pool Seller Leslie's Files for Chapter 11

By AKIKO MATSUDA

Swimming pool retailer **Leslie's** filed for chapter 11 bankruptcy in Houston on Wednesday, aiming to eliminate roughly 90% of its debt.

Phoenix-based Leslie's entered bankruptcy in the U.S. Bankruptcy Court for the Southern District of Texas with an agreement backed by more than 80% of its existing lenders to cut \$685 million of its funded debt in exchange for control of the business, the company said in a press release.

The company secured commitments for \$150 million of new capital, including \$90 million of bankruptcy financing to fund its operations during the proceedings and \$60 million in equity financing, according to the press release. The retailer also secured a \$225 million asset-based bankruptcy financing.

The company plans to keep stores open during bankruptcy, though it will close 76 out of its more than 900 locations to cut costs. Leslie's said it would continue to evaluate its real-es-

tate portfolio during court proceedings.

Founded in 1963, Leslie's grew into one of the largest direct-to-consumer brands in the pool and spa-care industry in the U.S., serving residential and commercial clients. It has struggled with declining sales following a pandemic-induced boom and has tried to close stores to stabilize the business.

The company issued a going-concern warning last month, raising the possibility that it might not be able to continue as a viable business. The Wall Street Journal reported last week that a bankruptcy filing was imminent.

Leslie's reported \$722.2 million in assets and \$1.21 billion in total liabilities at the time of bankruptcy filing.

Simpson Thatcher & Bartlett and Haynes Boone serve as its legal counsel, BRG as its financial and restructuring adviser, and Centerview Partners as investment banker.

Akiko Matsuda writes for WSJ Pro Bankruptcy.

The chain plans to stay open but close 76 out of its more than 900 stores.



The U.K. bakery chain's planned move could eliminate 740 jobs.

Greggs Plans to Close 4 Manufacturing Sites

By ADRIÀ CALATAYUD

Greggs said it plans to close four sites as part of a restructuring of its manufacturing operations, a move that could lead to 740 job losses.

The U.K. bakery chain on Wednesday said the proposal to consolidate its in-house manufacturing activities is the result of a review that aims to ensure it operates in the most cost-efficient manner. The company employs around 33,000, according to its website.

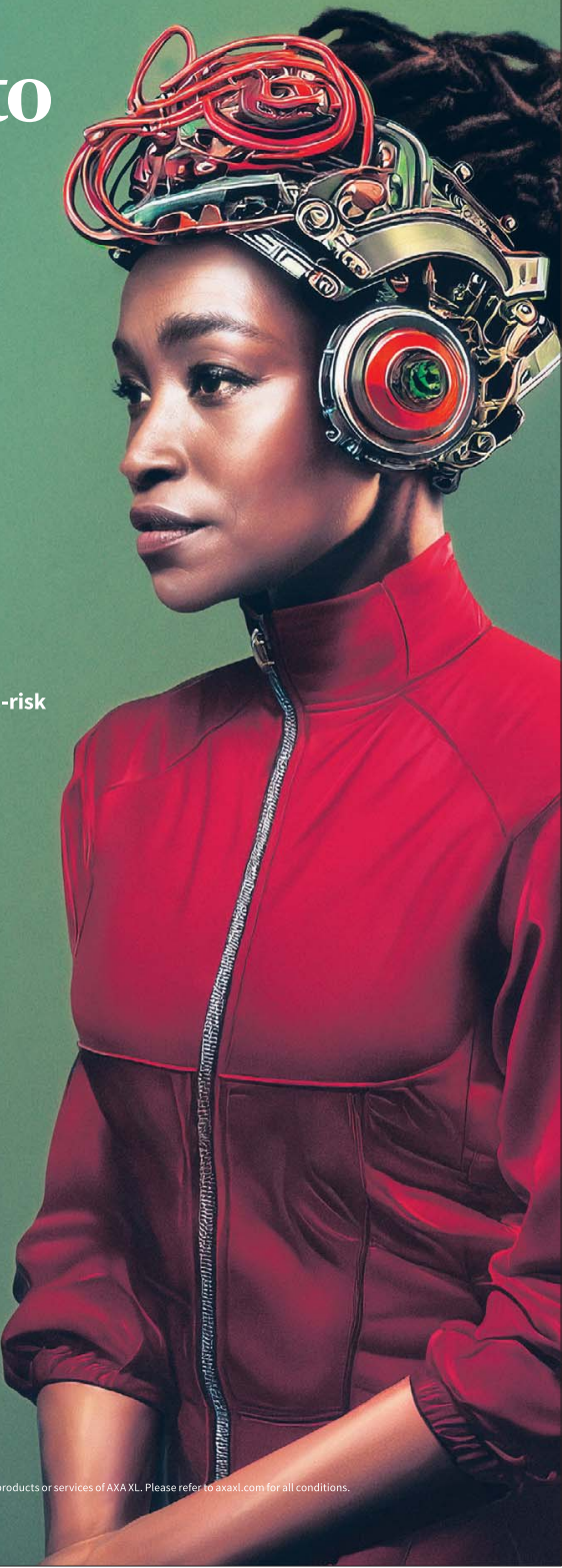
Greggs said it launched a consultation and is working with trade unions and employee representatives to refine and develop its plans.

Subject to consultation, the proposals would result in annual cash savings of about 20 million pounds, or \$26.5 million, at a cost of around £60 million, Greggs said. The company said it expected savings to be realized across 2028 and 2029.

The company disclosed its plans as it reported a 7.7% increase in total sales for the quarter ended Sept. 26, with like-for-like sales up 3.4% at company-managed shops.

An improved performance in recent months, coupled with continued cost controls, mean the company now expects a modestly better outcome for 2026, it said.





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BIGGEST 1,000 STOCKS

How to Read the Stock Tables

The following explanations apply to NYSE, NYSE Arca, NYSE American and Nasdaq Stock Market listed securities. Prices are consolidated from trades reported by various market centers, including securities exchanges, Finra, electronic communications networks and other broker-dealers. The list comprises the 1,000 largest companies based on market capitalization.

Underlined quotations are those stocks with large changes in volume compared with the issue's average trading volume.

Boldfaced quotations highlight those issues whose price changed by 5% or more if their previous closing price was \$2 or higher.

Footnotes:

i-New 52-week high; **I**-New 52-week low; **dd**-Indicates loss in the most recent four quarters.

Stock tables reflect composite regular trading as of 4 p.m. ET and changes in the official closing prices from 4 p.m. ET the previous day.

[illegible]

Mutual Funds

Data provided by **LSEG**

Top 250 mutual-funds listings for Nasdaq-published share classes by net assets

e-Ex-distribution. **f**-Previous day's quotation. **g**-Footnotes x and s apply. **f**-Footnotes e and s apply. **k**-Recalculated by LSEG, using updated data. **p**-Distribution costs apply, 12b-1. **r**-Redemption charge may apply. **s**-Stock split or dividend. **t**-Footnotes p and r apply. **v**-Footnotes x and e apply. **x**-Ex-dividend. **z**-Footnote x, e and s apply. **NA**-Not available due to incomplete price, performance or cost data. **NE**-Not released by LSEG data under review. **NN**-Fund not tracked. **NS**-Fund didn't exist at start of period.

Wednesday, September 30, 2026										
Fund	Net YTD			Net YTD			Fund	Net YTD		
	NAV	Chg	%Rt	NAV	Chg	%Rt		NAV	Chg	%Rt
AB Funds										
MunlinSens Inv	10.37	+0.08	-3.6							
American Century Inv										
Ultr	45.01	+0.02	6.7							
American Funds CI										
Ampca	45.01	+0.17	5.4							
AMutA	62.81	+0.47	6.7							
BaBia	39.75	-0.15	6.9							
BondA	10.73	-0.01	-3.1							
CapBIA	80.83	-0.30	7.0							
CapWGrA										
EupacA	81.34	-0.29	14.8							
FdlwA	10.71	+0.49	13.0							
GwThA	88.31	-0.39	9.8							
ICAA	68.18	-0.18	9.8							
InCoA	26.95	-0.15	5.1							
N PerA	75.37	-0.30	6.7							
NecoA	106.62	-0.13	18.1							
NwrWrdA	85.87	-0.31	14.7							
SmCPnA	81.32	-0.39	11.0							
WshA	65.96	-0.53	6.0							
Artisan Funds										
IntValInt	58.00	-0.40	9.2							
IntValInt	9.38	-0.01	9.2							
AgdBondSt	9.38	-0.01	9.2							
CorbInstn	9.74	-0.01	-1.5							
IntBdInstn	10.10	-0.01	2.4							
StbTbInstn	9.36	-0.01	0.8							
BlackRock Funds										
US CoreEqL	6.91	-0.01	0.4							
HvYdInstn	3.11	-0.01	0.5							
BlackRock Funds III										
ShS&P500IdK89.05	4.50	-0.24	12.4							
US TdVpAl	9.46	...	0.3							
Charles Schwab Funds										
StkTnTmPns	6.22	-0.01	0.3							
CausewayInstn										
CausewayInstn	24.47	-0.05	4.1							
Columnia Class A										
SelpColumniaA24.77	+0.25	58.1								
Columnia Class B										
DivIncM	39.25	-0.28	9.5							
Dimensional Fds										
EngMktCvA	44.85	-0.19	23.0							
IntValInt	32.45	-0.11	19.8							
IntValInt	10.10	-0.01	9.2							
IntValInt	32.12	-0.24	14.0							
IntSmcCo	27.61	-0.11	10.0							
IntSmvVa	35.05	-0.11	15.8							
LgCo	50.77	-0.12	12.7							
US CoreEqL	55.35	-0.22	12.4							
US CoreEqL	49.34	-0.21	12.4							
US SmaL	58.35	-0.33	12.4							
US SmaL	58.35	-0.33	12.4							
US TdVpAl	41.37	-0.37	13.1							
USLgVa	65.56	+0.47	17.9							
Dodge & Cox										
Balanced	13.45	-0.05	-2.1							
Income	12.01	-0.02	-3.4							
IntlBdStk	17.92	-0.08	-0.9							
IntlStk	17.93	-0.10	5.2							
DoubleLine Funds										
TotRetBdL	8.34	-0.04	-3.1							
Guggenheim Funds Tru										
TruRbBdFltClnst	NA	...	NA							
Harbor Funds										
CapAInstn	128.29	-0.11	10.0							
IntlBdInstn	29.96	-0.27	9.1							
John Hancock										
BondRf	12.85	-0.02	-0.3							
JP Morgan I Class										
CoreBnd	9.81	-0.01	13.7							
IntlBdInstn	27.66	-0.10	13.7							
CapGwth	86.40	-0.07	5.6							
JP Morgan R Class										
CoreBnd	9.82	-0.01	13.7							
CorePlusBd	6.89	-0.01	-2.9							
Ltd Albert I										
IntlBdInstn	15.51	-0.17	10.9							
FidAInstn	9.74	-0.11	2.9							
IntlValIndx	14.51	-0.12	15.3							
TotalBd	8.62	-0.21	-2.8							
Fidelity Selects										
Intl2030Pns	23.87	-0.08	6.0							
Intl2035Pns	28.44	-0.11	9.3							
Intl2404Pns	31.51	-0.13	9.7							
Intl2405Pns	34.25	-0.15	11.3							
Intl2505Pns	34.47	-0.15	11.6							
Fidelity Strategic A										
StratAdEmrMnt	NA	...	NA							
Guggenheim Funds Tru										
TruRbBdFltClnst	NA	...	NA							
IncomeFnd										
CapAInstn	128.29	-0.11	10.0							
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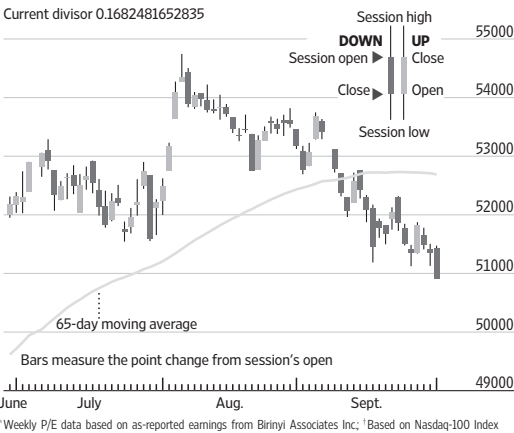
MARKETS DIGEST

EQUITIES

Dow Jones Industrial Average

50906.05 ▼443.87, or 0.86%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

Last	20.72	25.45
Year ago	19.52	22.05
Trailing P/E ratio	1.56	1.59
P/E estimate *		
Dividend yield		
All-time high	54349.12,	08/05/26



Major U.S. Stock-Market Indexes

	High	Low	Latest Close	Net chg	% chg
Dow Jones					
Industrial Average	51473.93	50906.05	50906.05	-443.87	-0.86
Transportation Avg	19695.96	19382.09	19382.09	-268.28	-1.37
Utility Average	1021.51	1009.74	1009.91	-6.02	-0.59
Total Stock Market	76061.25	75374.34	75374.36	-201.66	-0.27
Barron's 400	1578.25	1566.38	1566.38	-7.01	-0.45

Nasdaq Stock Market					
Nasdaq Composite	27108.20	26861.06	26861.06	63.52	0.24
Nasdaq-100	30630.45	30408.50	30408.50	69.17	0.23

S&P					
500 Index	7722.88	7651.54	7651.54	-19.30	-0.25
MidCap 400	3626.11	3595.97	3595.97	-22.50	-0.62
SmallCap 600	1671.86	1654.96	1654.96	-11.16	-0.67

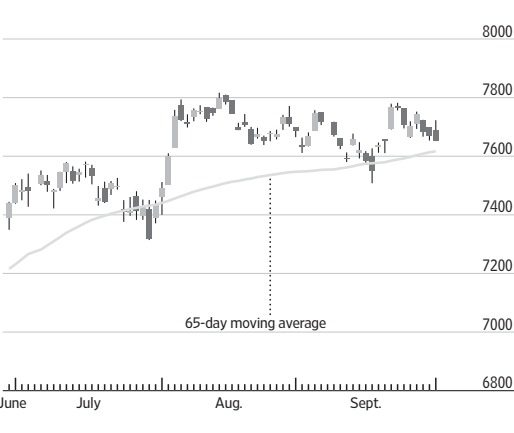
Other Indexes					
Russell 2000	2822.21	2796.86	2796.86	-11.06	-0.39
NYSE Composite	23740.90	23490.80	23490.80	-218.80	-0.92
Value Line	647.52	642.34	642.34	-3.560	-0.55
NYSE Arca Biotech	9584.62	9460.74	9475.79	-10.71	-0.11
NYSE Arca Pharma	1258.31	1231.91	1231.91	-19.76	-1.58
KBW Bank	172.06	169.96	169.96	-1.69	-0.98
PHLX [®] Gold/Silver	369.47	361.04	361.15	-5.08	-1.39
PHLX [®] Oil Service	93.02	92.03	92.05	-0.73	-0.79
PHLX [®] Semiconductor	12731.10	12555.65	12628.62	-0.54	-0.004
Cboe Volatility	16.61	15.62	16.34	0.30	1.87

[®]Nasdaq PHLX

S&P 500 Index

7651.54 ▼19.30, or 0.25%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

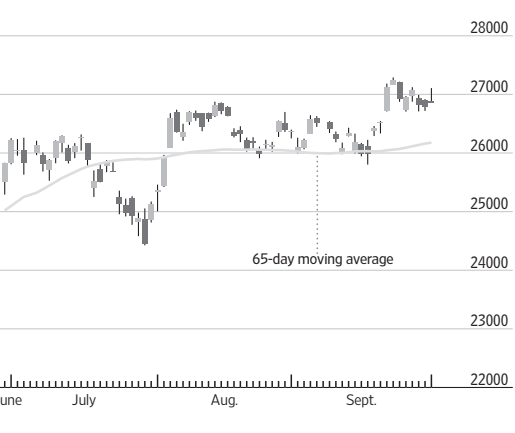
Last	23.48	25.27
Year ago	19.94	21.88
Trailing P/E ratio *	1.07	1.19
P/E estimate *		
Dividend yield *		
All-time high	7798.99,	08/13/26



Nasdaq Composite Index

26861.06 ▲63.52, or 0.24%
High, low, open and close for each trading day of the past three months.

Last	35.22	32.67
Year ago	24.15	26.51
Trailing P/E ratio **	0.54	0.66
P/E estimate **		
Dividend yield **		
All-time high	27244.28,	09/22/26



Late Trading

Most-active and biggest movers among NYSE, NYSE Arca, NYSE Amer. and Nasdaq issues from 4 p.m. to 6 p.m. ET as reported by electronic trading services, securities dealers and regional exchanges. Minimum share price of \$2 and minimum after-hours volume of 50,000 shares.

Most-active issues in late trading

Company	Symbol	Volume (000)	Last	Net chg	After Hours % chg	High	Low
NVIDIA	NVDA	14,714.9	228.63	0.25	0.11	243.47	215.69
State Street SPDR S&P 500	SPY	14,167.3	762.90	0.27	0.04	763.69	711.46
Krane CSI China Internet	KWEB	10,874.4	24.56	0.05	0.20	24.56	24.40
Direxion MU Bull 2X	MUU	9,118.7	36.10	-0.72	-1.95	38.24	34.90
Warner Bros. Discovery A	WBD	7,767.3	30.94	-0.01	-0.03	30.95	30.92
AT&T	T	7,281.3	24.42	0.02	0.08	24.57	24.40
Micron Technology	MU	6,565.2	1056.75	-8.36	-0.78	1088.55	769.80
Exelon	EXC	6,239.1	40.40	...	unch.	40.57	40.03

Percentage gainers...

Armada Acquisition II	XRPN	527.4	22.10	5.70	34.76	23.88	15.48
Logistic Prop Americas	LPA	2,655.2	3.36	0.50	17.48	3.50	2.86
Vicor	VICR	66.2	313.88	24.94	8.63	341.00	288.94
Monte Rosa Therapeutics	GLUE	64.1	12.88	0.95	7.96	13.35	11.93
CVR Energy	CVI	89.1	53.95	2.96	5.81	53.95	50.95

...And losers

GOWell Energy Technology	GOW	1,208.7	2.95	-0.23	-7.23	3.25	2.80
Alkami Technology	ALKT	182.1	13.17	-0.52	-3.80	14.10	13.17
Pacific Biosciences CA	PACB	1,187.5	2.29	-0.08	-3.37	2.37	2.26
Progress Software	PRGS	114.9	38.76	-1.21	-3.03	40.56	36.76
Grocery Outlet Holding	GO	105.4	10.96	-0.29	-2.58	11.25	10.96

Trading Diary

Volume, Advancers, Decliners

	NYSE	NYSE Amer.
Total volume ¹	486,645,337	27,157,578
Adv. volume [*]	474,596,113	10,826,670
Decl. volume [*]	989,346,765	13,089,904
Issues traded	2,697	299
Advances	1,018	115
Declines	1,628	169
Unchanged	51	15
New highs	23	1
New lows	301	14
Closing Arms ¹	0.67	0.99
Block trades [*]	4,296	204

	Nasdaq	NYSE Arca
Total volume ¹	8,300,260,870	401,555,807
Adv. volume [*]	4,692,435,986	88,861,531
Decl. volume [*]	3,491,124,313	308,190,452
Issues traded	5,316	2,728
Advances	2,241	750
Declines	2,890	1,936
Unchanged	185	42
New highs	91	33
New lows	368	223
Closing Arms ¹	0.58	1.09
Block trades [*]	55,387	1,928

¹Primary market NYSE, NYSE American NYSE Arca only.
^{*}(TRIN) A comparison of the number of advancing and declining issues with the volume of shares rising and falling. An Arms of less than 1 indicates buying demand; above 1 indicates selling pressure.

Percentage Gainers...

Company	Symbol	Close	Net chg	% chg	High	Low	% chg
Roze AI	RZAI	21.88	11.38	108.38	35.00	10.50	...
Tenon Medical	TNON	4.09	1.36	49.82	50.40	2.40	-90.1
Masonglory	MSGY	5.66	1.22	27.48	170.72	1.73	-96.5
Armada Acquisition II	XRPN	16.40	3.50	27.13	17.00	10.10	57.2
Republic Power Group	RPGI	16.39	3.41	26.31	66432.00	12.00	...
Lion Group Holding ADR	LGHL	5.68	1.17	25.94	3931.20	3.25	-99.8
DSC Holdings ADR	DSC	6.46	1.17	22.12	16.35	4.52	...
Antelope Enterprise	AEHL	10.27	1.68	19.56	418.08	2.98	-97.1
Sono-Tek	SOTK	5.90	0.92	18.47	6.38	3.40	33.2
Edesa Biotech	EDSA	4.21	0.65	18.26	20.32	0.72	70.4
Digimarc	DMRC	5.82	0.85	17.10	17.47	4.07	-40.4
MannKind	MNKD	3.90	0.56	16.77	6.51	2.23	-27.4
Contineum Therapeutics	CTNM	13.42	1.92	16.70	17.79	8.60	14.2
ClearOne	CLRO	5.23	0.67	14.69	16.50	2.71	-10.0
Azul ADR	AZUL	7.90	1.00	14.49	495.00	3.90	...

Percentage Losers

Company	Symbol	Close	Net chg	% chg	High	Low	% chg
Liquidia	LQDA	30.26	-40.43	-57.19	93.61	21.35	33.1
Darkiris	DKI	1.57	-0.98	-38.43	185.44	1.41	-92.4
Rafael Holdings CIB	RFL	1.32	-0.71	-34.98	3.96	1.12	-2.9
CVRx	CVRX	1.75	-0.88	-33.46	11.30	1.65	-78.3
Columbus Acquisition	COLA	7.30	-3.15	-30.14	12.95	6.89	-28.6
SVRN	SVRN	49.98	-17.35	-25.77	74.74	3.12	103.2
AdvisorShrs MSOS Dly Lvgd	MSOX	2.37	-0.76	-24.28	11.88	1.66	-69.4
Pop Culture Group	CPOP	3.37	-1.02	-23.17	382.50	3.06	-97.5
Cheche Group	CCG	6.00	-1.62	-21.26	47.95	6.00	-86.4
Stablecoin Development	SDEV	2.59	-0.68	-20.80	99.75	0.78	-59.5
Scribe Therapeutics Inc	SCTX	18.41	-4.63	-20.08	39.60	17.31	...
Pxyis Oncology	PYXS	2.33	-0.57	-19.66	5.55	1.03	5.0
BioStem Technologies	BSEM	3.09	-0.74	-19.32	8.40	2.25	-34.1
Indaptus Therapeutics	INDP	2.30	-0.55	-19.30	5.96	0.92	-19.9
ONE Nuclear Energy	ONEN	2.15	-0.47	-17.94	12.05	1.90	-78.9

CURRENCIES & COMMODITIES

Currencies

U.S.-dollar foreign-exchange rates at 5 p.m. ET

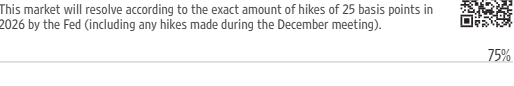
Country/currency	Wed in US\$	Wed per US\$	YTD chg (%)	Country/currency	Wed in US\$	Wed per US\$	YTD chg (%)
Americas				Vietnam dong	.00003852	25962	-1.3
Argentina peso	.00071524	9624	5.1	Europe			
Brazil real	.1933	5.1738	-6.2	Czech Rep. koruna	.04637	21.567	4.8
Canada dollar	.7026	1.4234	3.7	Denmark krone	.1516	6.5984	3.8
Chile peso	.001028	973.08	8.1	Euro area euro	1.1331	.8826	3.7
Colombia peso	.000302	3314.43	-12.1	Hungary forint	.003093	323.27	-1.2
Ecuador US dollar	1	1	unch	Iceland krona	.008271	120.91	-3.5
Mexico peso	.0553	18.0681	0.3	Norway krone	.1039	9.6215	-4.6
Uruguay peso	.02482	40.2830	3.1	Poland zloty	.2596	3.8514	7.2
Asia-Pacific				Sweden krona	.0999	10.0121	8.7
Australia dollar	.6944	1.4401	-3.9	Switzerland franc	1.1965	.8358	5.5
China yuan	.1491	6.7048	-4.1	Turkey lira	.0204	48.9947	14.1
Hong Kong dollar	.1274	7.8471	0.8	Ukraine hryvnia	.0223	44.7500	5.7
India rupee	.01042	95.948	6.8	UK pound	1.3264	.7539	1.6
Indonesia rupiah	.0000558	17937	7.4	Middle East/Africa			
Japan yen	.006353	157.41	0.5	Bahrain dinar	2.6525	.3770	0.01
Kazakhstan tenge	.002272	440.08	-13.3	Egypt pound	.0193	51.9350	8.9
Macau pataca	.1237	8.0851	0.8	Iceland shekel	.3253	3.0740	-3.5
Malaysia ringgit	.2451	4.0806	0.6	Kuwait dinar	3.2378	.3089	0.3
New Zealand dollar	.5633	1.7753	2.2	Oman sul rial	2.5994	.3847	-0.02
Pakistan rupee	.00361	277.070	-1.1	Qatar riyal	.2742	3.648	-0.1
Philippines peso	.0159	62.761	6.5	Saudi Arabia riyal	.2663	3.7551	0.2
Singapore dollar	.7826	1.2778	-0.6	South Africa rand	.0609	16.4208	-0.9
South Korea won	.0007370	1356.91	-5.8				
Sri Lanka rupee	.0030248	330.60	6.7				
Taiwan dollar	.03137	31.882	1.7				
Thailand baht	.02976	33.600	6.7				

Commodities

	Close	Wednesday Net chg	% Chg	High	52-Week Low	% Chg	YTD % chg
DJ Commodity	1444.52	3.50	0.24	1505.40	1076.65	33.11	27.75
FTSE/CC CRB Index	410.25	0.80	0.20	429.15	291.69	36.52	37.31
Crude oil, \$ per barrel	90.42	1.04	1.16	112.95	55.27	46.36	57.47
Natural gas, \$/MMBtu	3.026	0.015	0.50	7.460	2.523	-12.95	-17.91
Gold, \$ per troy oz.	4155.60	7.90	0.19	5318.40	3839.70	7.45	-3.93

Polymarket | A Dow Jones partner

Prediction Market: How many Fed rate hikes in 2026?



International Stock Indexes

Region/Country	Index	Close	Net chg	Latest % chg	YTD %chg
World	MSCI ACWI	1134.77	-1.09	-0.10	11.8
	MSCI ACWI ex-USA	472.01	0.76	0.16	12.1
	MSCI World	4902.65	-6.56	-0.13	10.7
	MSCI Emerging Markets	1704.87	3.12	0.18	21.4
Americas	MSCI AC Americas	2892.13	-7.169	-0.25	11.5
Canada	S&P/TSX Comp	35235.87	-224.40	-0.63	11.1
Latin Amer.	MSCI EM Latin America	3039.22	27.86	0.93	12.2
Brazil	Bovespa	186340.46	2512.87	1.37	15.6
Mexico	S&P/BMV IPC	64214.36	-896.21	-1.38	-0.1
EMEA	STOXX Europe 600	634.89	-3.19	-0.50	7.2
Eurozone	Euro STOXX	660.72	-4.81	-0.72	7.9
Belgium	Bel-20	5606.06	-41.23	-0.73	10.4
Denmark	OMX Copenhagen 20	1513.98	-3.45	-0.23	-5.9
France	CAC 40	7964.51	-71.36	-0.89	-2.3
Germany	DAX	25199.19	-200.02	-0.79	2.9
Israel	Tel Aviv	4203.98	-17.96	-0.43	15.8
Italy	FTSE MIB	51371.98	-432.96	-0.84	14.3
Netherlands	AEX	1114.90	-5.29	-0.47	17.2
Norway	Oslo Bors All-Share	2478.46	0.15	0.01	27.7
South Africa	FTSE/JSE All-Share	108506.88	-933.83	-0.85	-6.3
Spain	IBEX 35	19426.24	-91.26	-0.47	12.2
Sweden	OMX Stockholm	1125.99	-3.10	-0.27	7.7
Switzerland	Swiss Market	13830.34	-81.85	-0.59	4.2
Turkey	BIST 100	11947.18	-343.40	-2.79	6.1
U.K.	FTSE 100	10606.00	-30.71	-0.29	6.8
U.K.	FTSE 250	24539.99	165.18	0.68	9.2
Asia-Pacific	MSCI AC Asia Pacific	276.46	2.11	0.77	21.4
Australia	S&P/ASX 200	8789.30	80.05	0.92	0.9
China	Shanghai Composite	3842.19	11.74	0.31	-3.2
Hong Kong	Hang Seng	24613.27	89.70	0.37	-4.0
India	BSE Sensex	72480.29	-48.78	-0.07	-14.9
Indonesia	JSX Composite	6071.14	-50.56	-0.83	-29.8
Japan	NIKKEI 225	66753.72	1272.45	1.94	32.6
Singapore	Straits Times	5675.88	-38.96	-0.68	22.2
South Korea	KOSPI	6838.04	-32.77	-0.48	62.3
Taiwan	TAIEX	47940.13	308.17	0.65	65.5
Thailand	SET	1559.01	-35.29	-2.21	23.8

Futures Contracts

Metal & Petroleum Futures						
	Contract	Open	High	Low	Settle	Open interest
Copper-High (CXM): 25,000 lbs., \$per lb.						
Oct	6.5895	6.5895	6.5495		6.5590	0.0155 7,456
Dec	6.6540	6.6915	6.6025		6.6215	0.0180 173,182
Gold (CXM): 100 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Oct	4183.80	4217.40	4151.40		4155.60	170 12,328
Nov	4198.10	4235.00	4163.30		4171.50	7.50 3,954
Dec	4216.20	4251.10	4178.20		4186.70	7.00 325,931
Jan/27	4248.10	4267.90	4205.30		4205.80	6.80 586
Feb	4252.30	4286.40	4213.70		4221.60	6.70 41,282
March	4264.50	4264.50	4264.50		4237.90	6.10 231
Palladium (NYM): 50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Oct	1215.00	1215.00	1207.00		1201.40	-0.20 73
Dec	1230.00	1245.00	1208.00		1212.40	-1.30 17,979
Platinum (NYM): 50 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Oct	1706.00	1706.00	1698.00		1702.30	22.20 265
Jan/27	1720.20	1741.10	1712.40		1718.90	17.90 52,439
Silver (CXM): 5,000 troy oz.; \$ per troy oz.						
Oct	60.820	60.820	60.000		60.098	-0.570 3,271
Dec	61.835	62.110	60.380		60.566	-0.587 85,471
Crude Oil, Light Sweet (NYM): 1,000 bbls.; \$ per bbl.						
Nov	89.00	91.96	88.58		90.42	1.04 289,255
Dec	86.91	89.83	86.43		88.42	1.17 230,050
Jan/27	85.16	88.09	84.90		86.73	1.02 112,962
June	79.55	80.95	▲	78.98	80.28	0.73 128,073
Dec	74.59	75.80	▲	74.59	75.44	-0.43 173,675
Dec/28	70.10	70.64	70.10		70.24	-0.11 98,903
NY Harbor ULSD (NYM): 42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
Oct	4.8662	5.4275	▲	4.8630	4.9569	.0590 1,630
Nov	4.5348	4.7941	▲	4.5161	4.6881	.1781 74,807
Gasoline- NY RB0B (NYM): 42,000 gal.; \$ per gal.						
Oct	3.2302	3.4496	3.2296		3.4378	.1596 3,638
Nov	3.1099	3.2889	3.1040		3.2605	.1282 124,275
Natural Gas (NYM): 10,000 MMBtu.; \$ per MMBtu.						
Nov	3.014	3.058	2.966		3.026	.015 398,638
Dec	3.348	3.387	▼	3.310	3.370	.032 196,133
Jan/27	3.717	3.762	▼	3.695	3.752	.048 185,726
Feb	3.399	3.438	▼	3.378	3.428	.039 96,888
March	2.723	2.776	2.716		2.763	.043 205,840
April	2.630	2.674	2.620		2.664	.039 140,195

Agriculture Futures						
Corn (CBT): 5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Dec	522.00	526.25	498.75		500.75	-21.25 913,776
March/27	535.75	539.75	513.75		515.50	-20.50 395,423
Oats (CBT): 5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Dec	422.50	429.50	▲	418.00	418.75	-3.75 3,059
March/27	431.25	437.00	▲	428.75	429.25	-1.75 309
Soybeans (CBT): 5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Nov	1296.75	1311.50	1289.75		1293.00	-4.75 436,225
Jan/27	1311.50	1327.00	1306.25		1309.25	-3.50 205,120
Soybean Meal (CBT): 100 tons; \$ per ton.						
Oct	360.80	365.00	355.00		357.10	-3.00 3,576
Dec	359.00	365.20	355.50		356.90	-2.10 302,658
Soybean Oil (CBT): 60,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Oct	68.05	68.25	67.90		67.85	... 2,460
Dec	68.28	69.03	67.94		68.28	-0.08 256,147
Rough Rice (CBT): 2,000 cwt.; \$ per cwt.						
Nov	16.42	16.42	16.09		16.17	-26 11,712
Jan/27	16.71	16.85	16.55		16.63	-25 1,503
Wheat (CBT): 5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Dec	692.75	700.25	673.25		675.75	-17.00 252,704
March/27	707.50	714.25	688.75		690.75	-16.25 107,707
Wheat (KC): 5,000 bu.; cents per bu.						
Dec	743.25	752.25	729.25		733.00	-10.00 158,885
March/27	756.00	765.25	743.00		746.50	-9.25 74,927
Cattle-Feeder (CME): 50,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Oct	334.700	337.650	333.375		336.425	2.775 9,084
Nov	332.000	335.450	330.625		334.300	3.400 24,007
Cattle-Live (CME): 40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Oct	217.925	219.900	217.700		218.675	1.450 32,117
Dec	221.150	223.850	221.025		222.700	1.900 121,486
Hogs-Lean (CME): 40,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Oct	79.400	79.425	78.600		78.725	-6.50 28,948
Dec	69.525	69.950	68.925		69.425	-2.75 147,106
Lumber (CME): 27,500 bd. ft., \$ per 1,000 bd. ft.						
Nov	537.50	544.00	537.00		539.50	2.00 8,785
Jan/27	558.00	564.50	558.00		562.00	2.50 921
Milk (CME): 200,000 lbs.; cents per lb.						
Oct	14.90	14.95	▼	14.79	14.94	.04 6,444
Nov	15.23	15.57	15.18		15.50	.24 6,379
Cocoa (ICE-US): 10-metric tons; \$ per ton.						
Dec	5.345	5.505	5.292		5.367	-41 74,699

Macro & Market Economics

Watching the Gauges: U.S. Supply and Demand

Inventories, imports and demand for the week ended September 25. Current figures are in thousands of barrels or thousands of gallons per day, except natural-gas figures, which are in billions of cubic feet. Natural-gas import and demand data are available monthly only.

Inventories, 000s barrels							Imports, 000s barrels per day					
	Current	Expected change	Previous week	Year ago	4-week avg	5-year avg	Current	Expected change	Previous week	Year ago	4-week avg	5-year avg
Crude oil and petroleum prod												
Crude oil	1,244,313	...	1,251	1,288	1,249	1,258	7,215	...	7,350	7,932	7,832	8,065
excluding SPR	427,320	-200	426	417	425	427	5,698	...	5,877	5,833	6,364	6,206
Gasoline	204,362	...	206	221	206	218	500	...	401	668	476	577
Finished gasoline	14,219	300	14	15	15	16	137	...	60	164	79	79
Reformulated	22	...	0	0	0	0	0	...	0	0	0	0
Conventional	14,197	...	14	15	15	16	137	...	60	164	79	79
Blend.components	190,144	...	192	205	192	202	363	...	341	504	397	498
Natural gas (bcf)												
	3,351	...	3	4	3	3	...	...	...	...	...	...
Kerosene-type												
jet fuel	43,612	...	45	44	45	42	50	...	67	65	67	102
Distillates	105,180	-200	107	124	107	118	153	...	85	118	134	125
Heating oil	6,295	...	7	7	6	8	0	...	0	2	0	0
Diesel	98,886	...	101	116	100	55	153	...	85	117	134	125
Residual fuel oil	23,432	...	24	21	23	26	207	...	69	127	150	137
Other oils	306,895	...	310	336	308	313	532	...	760	988	554	825
Net crude, petroleum products, incl. SPR												
	1,528,080	...	1,536	1,695	1,534	1,692	-3,849	...	-3,803	-3,067	-3,788	-1,738

Weekly Demand, 000s barrels per day						Natural gas storage					
	Current	Expected change	Previous week	Year ago	4-week avg	5-year avg	Billions of cubic feet; weekly totals				
Total petroleum product	21,500	...	21,050	20,166	20,780	20,397	4250				
Finished							3250				
motor gasoline	8,689	...	8,847	8,518	8,721	8,923	2250				
Kerosene-type							1250				
jet fuel	1,809	...	1,650	1,740	1,761	1,551	250				
Distillates	3,948	...	3,975	3,617	3,776	4,070					
Residual fuel oil	374	...	196	362	291	198					
Propane/propylene	1,085	...	764	534	886	...					
Other oils	5,595	...	5,618	5,396	5,345	...					

Note: Expected changes are provided by Dow Jones Newswires' survey of analysts. Previous and average inventory data are in millions. Sources: FactSet; Dow Jones Market Data; U.S. Energy Information Administration; Dow Jones Newswires

Exchange-Traded Portfolios | wsj.com/market-data/mutualfunds-etfs

Largest 100 exchange-traded funds, latest session.							ETF						
Wednesday, September 30, 2026													
ETF	Symbol	Closing Price	Chg (%)	YTD (%)			Symbol	Closing Price	Chg (%)	YTD (%)			
AventusUS\$CValue	AVUV	117.77	-0.85	15.5			iSRuss1000	IWB	416.13	-0.27	11.4		
CapGrdPhvAl	CDGV	48.85	-0.36	11.9			iSRuss1000Grw	IWF	125.26	-0.03	5.9		
DimenUSCoreEq2	DFAC	44.45	-0.43	12.3			iSRuss2000	IWM	277.89	-0.40	12.9		
FidTotalBd	FBND	43.40	-0.12	-6.0			iS&P500Grw	IVV	122.28	-0.06	15.4		
InvscNasd100	QQQM	304.64	0.27	2.0			iS&P500Value	IVE	128.26	-0.46	7.6		
InvscPQ00	RSP	208.02	-0.71	8.6			iSemiConductor	SOXX	568.64	0.21	88.8		
Invsc&P500EW	RSP	208.02	-0.71	8.6			iSh7-10YreasBd	IEF	89.31	-0.16	-7.1		
iSBHcoin	IBIT	47.34	0.02	-4.7			iShSilver	SLV	54.51	-1.75	-15.4		
iSharesUSDHYCpBd	USGH	35.72	-0.17	-4.5			iSh20+YreasBd	TLT	77.78	-0.58	-10.8		
iShCoreDivGrowth	DGRO	75.39	-0.82	8.6			iShUSEqFacRotat	DYFN	69.26	-0.14	13.9		
iShCoreMSCIEAFE	IEFA	98.86	-0.80	8.3			iShUSTreasuryBd	GOVT	21.87	-0.07	-5.0		
iShCoreMSCIEAFE	IEFA	98.86	-0.80	8.3			iSh0-3MTreasBd	SGOV	100.68	...	0.3		
iShCoreMSCIEAFE	IEFA	98.86	-0.80	8.3			JPMnasdaqEAPrem	JEPO	61.26	0.13	5.4		
iShMSCIIntDev	IEVM	89.48	-0.56	8.5			JPMnasAACLO	JAAA	50.17	-0.02	-0.2		
iShCoreMSCITotInt	IXUS	94.99	-0.72	12.2			JPMPEPemiUnimcroe	JEPI	56.22	-0.48	-1.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	76.85	-0.22	11.8			JPMULtshInc	JPST	30.27	-0.02	-0.4		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			ProSHldPrfQQQ	PROSH	70.03	0.74	48.0		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			SPDRGold	GLDM	82.18	-0.56	-3.7		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			SPDRGold	GLD	383.04	-0.57	-3.7		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			SchwabIntEqMkt	SCHE	27.47	-0.27	14.3		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			SchwabUSBrdMkt	SCHB	29.31	-0.27	11.7		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			SchwabUSDiv	SCHV	32.53	-0.97	18.6		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			SchwabUSDivLC	SCSX	30.00	-0.30	11.5		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			SchwabUSLCGrw	SCHW	35.93	0.06	10.1		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLE	61.50	-0.06	37.6		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLF	53.40	-1.13	2.5		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLI	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
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iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.92	-1.35	8.8		
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iShCore&P500	IUV	71.95	0.90	1.0			S&P500Grw	XLS	166.				

NEW HIGHS AND LOWS

WSJ.com/newhighs

The following explanations apply to the New York Stock Exchange, NYSE Arca, NYSE American and Nasdaq Stock Market stocks that hit a new 52-week intraday high or low in the latest session. % **CHG**-Daily percentage change from the previous trading session.

Wednesday, September 30, 2026

52-Wk %

Stock

Sym

Hi

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Chg

52-Wk %

Stock

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HEARD ON THE STREET

FINANCIAL ANALYSIS & COMMENTARY

China Has Power to Bail Out Diesel Market

Chinese oil refineries are only using 75% of their capacity at the moment

China helped keep a lid on global oil prices this year when it cut crude imports.

In theory, it also has the power to cool high diesel prices and potentially even avert the need for a messy U.S. diesel export ban. But the odds that China will bail out the fuel market today look lower than they were back in 2022—the last time it stepped in to cool sky-high diesel prices.

China has an enormous refining network and is currently the only country with significant excess capacity. While U.S. refineries are running hot at around 97% utilization, Chinese refineries are only at 75% of their max output, data from Vortexa shows.

At last week's summit in Washington, President Trump asked Chinese leader Xi Jinping to boost exports of refined oil products. Five weeks out from the midterm elections, Trump is under pressure to lower U.S. diesel prices, which have hit all-time highs in recent weeks.

His other idea—to ban American diesel exports—is deeply unpopular with U.S. oil industry executives, who stand to lose billions of dollars of business if domestic refineries are cut off from the international diesel market.

U.S. diesel exports generated \$25 billion in revenue in the 90-day period between June 13 and Sept. 11, according to S&P Global Energy estimates. Oil bosses don't want that cash gusher cut off. Pulling American diesel from the global market would also be a disaster for customers in Latin America and Europe who are reliant on U.S. supplies.

And a ban could have unintended consequences on American consumers. Being cut off from export markets would leave U.S. refiners with a huge diesel glut. This would likely cause a collapse in refinery margins and lead to a 12% cut to refinery runs, according to S&P Global Energy analysis. As this would tighten supply of other transport fuels, such as gasoline, drivers would end up paying more



The price of diesel in the U.S. has been soaring, with its refineries running near capacity, while China is currently the only country with excess capacity.

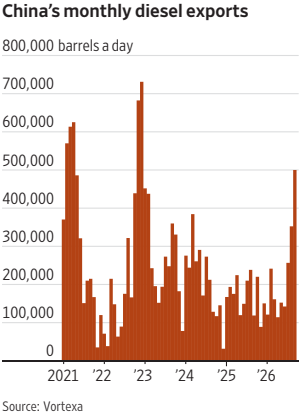
at the pump.

China's diesel exports have been ramping up lately. Beijing banned exports of refined fuels early in the war but told refiners they could resume shipping again in July, once it was clear there was no domestic fuel shortage.

Data from Vortexa shows that China's diesel exports in September reached around 500,000 barrels a day, up from 166,000 barrels a day on average from April through July.

There is a big financial incentive to send more overseas. Chinese diesel export margins, a measure of the profit refiners make from selling abroad, reached \$100.58 a barrel in September, according to Tom Reed, head of oil market analysis at Argus Media. This is up from \$21.40 in January.

But oil analysts don't expect an export boom like the one seen in



late 2022, which is the last time China bailed out an overheated global diesel market.

Back then, diesel prices rose in

the months after Russia's invasion of Ukraine. In September that year, Beijing issued extra export quotas to refineries. By November, China was exporting around 680,000 barrels of diesel a day, which helped to cool global prices.

Today, Beijing's priority is to make sure it has enough fuel supply at home rather than maximizing profits for refineries. The global supply of crude oil for refinery feedstock is more volatile now than it was four years ago.

Issuing extra export quotas at this stage could send Chinese buyers back into the crude market and push up oil prices, although freight costs are now a big consideration for buyers. A shortage of oil tankers is raising the all-in expense of shipping oil from the Middle East to China.

However, Chinese refineries

have used less of their existing export quotas than normal for this time of year, as they were banned from exporting fuel in the early days of the war. This means that even without a shift in policy they could export roughly an extra 100,000 barrels of diesel a day in the fourth quarter based on Vortexa estimates.

According to the International Energy Agency, global exports of diesel in August reached 4.6 million barrels a day, down from 5.1 million barrels a day the same month last year. Any extra diesel supply from China would help. But it probably wouldn't be enough to remove the threat of a U.S. export ban.

China already helped stave off an even worse oil-price shock this year. Don't bet on it fixing the diesel crunch too.

—Carol Ryan

Is Time to Give Bonds a Second Chance?

"Set it and forget it" can be a solid investing strategy. Just don't forget math.

Bonds, making headlines for the wrong reason recently, have been sinking for years. Incredibly, a dollar invested in the S&P 500, the most-followed stock index, would have more than doubled since the start of 2021 but lost value in the Bloomberg US Aggregate Bond Index, the leading fixed-income benchmark.

When stocks have had a really bad run, someone will always claim they saw it coming and that the signs were obvious. Well, maybe, but bonds' negative returns really were foreseeable.

Despite that, parts of millions of people's paychecks were dutifully invested in them based on cookie-cutter formulas. The percentage rises mechanically by age

because bonds are in theory less risky.

Vanguard's popular Target Retirement 2025 Fund, aimed at those right around retirement age, has just over half of its assets in bonds while the 2065 version designed for people just entering the workforce has barely 8%. That means older savers got hit harder by bonds' poor performance.

The best retirement strategy for most people is usually the cheapest and simplest. It should work on autopilot, avoiding rash decisions that can be influenced by scary or exciting headlines.

But you didn't need to be a newshound to get spooked when 10-year U.S. Treasury notes yielded barely half a percent in 2020. You were already losing money after inflation, and you

were going to lose a lot more when yields got back to normal. Low coupon bonds have higher duration and greater convexity—measures of their price sensitivity to interest rates.

That's all water under the bridge, and things look very different today. There's an argument that investors should now tilt away from stocks to bonds in those formulas given the multidecade highs in yields and lofty S&P 500 valuations.

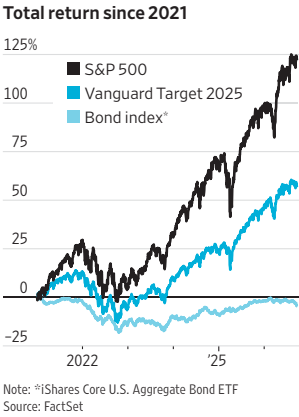
One measure that captures the trade-off is economist Robert Shiller's Excess CAPE Yield. This compares the yield on stocks (the inverse of his cyclically adjusted P/E ratio) with inflation-adjusted bond yields. The difference between the two, stocks' excess, is a low 1.01 percentage points today versus 4.88 percentage

points in March 2020.

So, in theory, the cookie-cutter approach that hurt older savers could help them today. Or maybe not, since future inflation is a wild card and it could dent bonds' value more than real assets like stocks. One way to get the best of both worlds—a hands-off portfolio that tries to account for that math—might be an asset-allocation fund.

These have dynamic formulas. One is Bridgewater's All Weather ETF, which is heavily overweight inflation-linked bonds. Another is Elm Wealth's much cheaper Market Navigator ETF. It's underweight both U.S. stocks and bonds at the moment, giving more weight to cash and emerging-market stocks.

There are no guarantees in life—there could be wars, finan-



cial crises, or worse. But a portfolio that runs the numbers and accounts for what has done well or poorly when conditions were similar in the past could smooth that future path.

—Spencer Jakab

MONEY & INVESTING

Stock Spotlight

- Boeing**

The aerospace company secured a contract valued at more than \$20 billion from the U.S. Navy to build its next-generation jet fighter. Despite news of the contract, Boeing's stock edged lower. Shares of Northrop Grumman, the only other competitor for the contract, fell more than 4%.
- Paramount**

Shares rose 3% after a federal judge approved a settlement with 12 state attorneys general, which paves the way for the David Ellison-run company to complete its hard-fought \$81-billion acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery.
- Mattel**

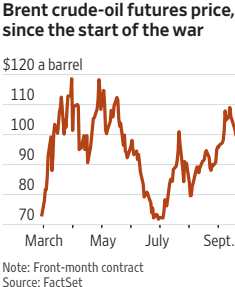
Condé Nast Chief Executive Roger Lynch is stepping down after more than seven



Roger Lynch

- years to become CEO of the toy company. Mattel shares were down more than 4%.
- Robinhood**
- The brokerage unveiled a slew of new tools and services including an in-app AI agent late Tuesday. Shares fell 3%, reversing a premarket climb.
- Cal-Maine Foods**
- The egg producer swung to a loss in its fiscal first quarter as sales fell, hurt by

- continually low egg prices. Shares dropped about 1%.
- Conagra**
- The food manufacturer said steps it has taken to expand profitability are starting to pay off, as the company logged a higher fiscal first-quarter profit despite lower sales. However, its shares fell nearly 5%.
- THURSDAY'S EVENTS:**
- ◆ Fed speakers: Vice Chair Philip Jefferson; Fed governors Waller, Bowman and Cook
 - ◆ Economic data: Manufacturing PMI data, jobless claims, construction spending, EIA weekly natural gas storage report
- EARNINGS EXPECTED:**
- Nike
Accenture
McCormick
Acuity



Oil exports from the Gulf have recovered to prewar levels in recent days as producers grow more adept at navigating the war in the Middle East. That hasn't done much to bring down oil prices.

According to Goldman Sachs analysts, markets are still nervous about dwindling oil stockpiles and the potential for long-term damage to energy infrastructure if the war escalates again.

Brent crude settled at \$103.53 a barrel on Wednesday.

Japan Pauses Forex Intervention as Yen Strengthens

- TOKYO—Japan didn't step into foreign-exchange markets in the past month, as repeated verbal warnings and historic intervention during the summer helped the yen regain some strength.
- The country didn't conduct any currency operations between Aug. 27 and Sept. 28, according to data released by the Ministry of Finance on Wednesday.
- The inaction follows a record \$98.7 billion operation the prior month involving coordination with Washington to defend the Japanese currency after it weakened to 40-year lows near 164 to the dollar in late July.
- A series of comments from Japanese officials, remarks from Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and expectations for faster interest-rate hikes by the

Bank of Japan have combined to cap the yen's depreciation. The Japanese currency stood at 157.43 against the dollar in afternoon dealings after strengthening as much as 152.90 in early September.

—Megumi Fujikawa

In Market History

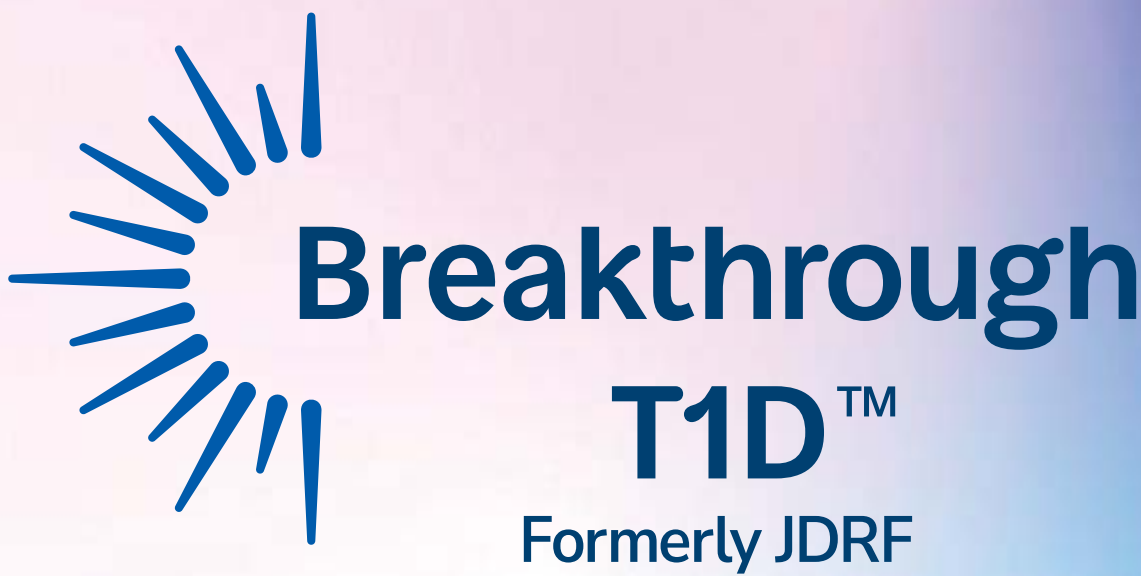
On this day in 1982, Billy Joel's "52nd Street" album was released on compact disc—the first album ever to appear on that cutting-edge technology.



ROBERT ALEXANDER/GETTY IMAGES

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the people who face it.

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